

THE COMPLETE IELTS MASTER BOOK

A comprehensive preparation course for Listening, Reading, Writing and Speaking

Compiled from the 12-lesson IELTS Master Course video series
Full practice tests | Model answers | Grammar and vocabulary reference

About This Book

The Complete IELTS Master Book is a single-volume, self-contained preparation course for the International English Language Testing System (IELTS). It covers all four tested components — Listening, Reading, Writing and Speaking — in the depth normally found across an entire shelf of preparation materials: full question-type breakdowns, examiner-focused strategy, grammar and lexis reference, model answers with commentary, complete practice sets with answer keys, and a minute-by-minute exam-day playbook.

The book was compiled from the twelve-part IELTS Master Course video series (Master-Course of 4 Components), a full 12-hour taught course recorded live with beginner-to-intermediate learners. Every teaching sequence in that course has been watched, transcribed and reorganised here into reference form, then expanded with the grammar, vocabulary, strategy and practice materials that a serious candidate needs in order to move from a Band 5 to a Band 7+.

What makes this book different

- Question-type first. Every skill is broken down by the actual question types you will meet in the

exam, because the exam tests techniques as much as English.

- Answer-first explanations. Practice sets are followed by keys that explain why an answer is right

and, just as importantly, why the tempting wrong answer is wrong.

- Band-descriptor driven. Every strategy is tied to what examiners actually reward, so you never

practise a technique that cannot earn marks.

- Teach-yourself friendly. Each chapter states its learning goals, gives worked examples, then sets

tasks — ideal if you are studying alone, without a teacher.

Who it is for

If your current level is...	Start here
Beginner (A2 – low B1), first time with IELTS	Chapters 1–5, then follow the 8-week plan
Intermediate (B1–B2), aiming Band 6.0–6.5	Chapters 4–20, focus on the practice sets
Upper-intermediate (B2+), aiming Band 7.0+	Chapters 2, 10, 14–16, 20–22 and the model answers
Re-sitting the exam	Chapter 23 plus the mock test in Chapter 22

The four components at a glance

Component	Time	Questions	What is tested
Listening	30 min (+10 min transfer)	40	Comprehension of monologues and conversations in 4 recorded sections

Component	Time	Questions	What is tested
Academic Reading	60 min	40	Skimming, scanning, inference and detail across 3 long texts
Academic Writing	60 min	2 tasks	Data description (150+ words) and argumentative essay (250+ words)
Speaking	11-14 min	3 parts	Interview, long turn and abstract discussion with an examiner

Table of Contents

About This Book	2
What makes this book different	2
Who it is for	2
The four components at a glance	2
How to Use This Book	16
Recommended study sequences	16
Conventions used in this book	16
Acknowledgements and How This Edition Was Built	17
A Word Before You Begin	17
Chapter 1: IELTS at a Glance: Format, Scoring and Test-Day Reality . . .	18
1.1 The complete test structure	18
1.2 Listening in detail	18
1.3 Academic Reading in detail	19
1.4 The band scale	19
1.5 Raw scores to bands: why they differ by paper	20
1.6 Writing: how it is marked	21
1.7 Speaking: how it is marked	21
1.8 Test-day logistics that change outcomes	22
1.9 What the exam is really testing	22
1.10 Your first action	22
Chapter 2: Band Descriptors Decoded: Exactly What Examiners Reward .	24
2.1 The logic of the four criteria	24
2.2 Writing Task 2: Task Response	24
2.3 Writing Task 2: Coherence and Cohesion	25
2.4 Vocabulary: Lexical Resource	25
2.5 Grammar: Range and Accuracy	26
2.6 Speaking: Fluency and Coherence	26
2.7 Speaking: Lexical Resource, Grammar and Pronunciation	27
2.8 The score-sheet you should keep	27
2.9 Four myths, corrected	27
2.10 Turning descriptors into daily habits	28
Chapter 3: Study Plans: The 8-Week Course and the 21-Day Sprint	29
3.1 Before you start: the 45-minute diagnostic	29

3.2 The 8-week plan	29
Daily template (8-week plan)	30
3.3 The 21-day sprint	30
3.4 How to use practice material properly	31
The error taxonomy	32
3.5 Weekly review ritual (20 minutes, every Sunday)	32
3.6 When you are studying without a teacher	32
3.7 What to do in the last 48 hours	32
Chapter 4: Core Grammar for Band 7+	34
4.1 The tense system, and which tenses IELTS actually wants	34
Common errors and repairs	34
4.2 Articles: the small words that shout "beginner"	34
4.3 Complex sentences: the four structures that earn Band 7	35
(1) Relative clauses	35
(2) Conditionals	35
(3) Concession (showing the other side)	36
(4) Passive voice	36
4.4 Modals: the vocabulary of caution	36
4.5 Cohesion: linking without sounding mechanical	36
4.6 Punctuation examiners notice	37
4.7 Nominalisation: the academic register	37
4.8 The grammar of Task 1: describing data precisely	37
4.9 Six drills to build grammatical range	38
Chapter 5: Academic Vocabulary and the Paraphrase Engine	39
5.1 The paraphrase engine	39
Drill: the three-synonym rule	39
The ten paraphrase pairs IELTS reuses constantly	39
5.2 Collocation: the difference between correct and natural	40
High-frequency academic collocations	40
5.3 The Academic Word List: the 60 you will actually use	40
5.4 Topic vocabulary for the ten most common Task 2 themes	42
1. Education	42
2. Environment	42
3. Technology	42
4. Health	42
5. Work and employment	43

6. Cities and transport	43
7. Society and family	43
8. Crime and law	43
9. Media and communication	43
10. Globalisation and culture	43
5.5 Register: formal writing has no room for slang	43
5.6 Spelling: the silent band-killer	44
5.7 Building a vocabulary notebook that works	44
5.8 Twelve phrases that immediately raise the register of an essay	45
Chapter 6: Listening: Test Format and Every Question Type	46
6.1 The four sections and what each one demands	46
The paper's skeleton	46
6.2 Instruction words: read them or lose the mark	46
6.3 Type 1: Form, note and table completion	47
6.4 Type 2: Multiple choice (single answer)	47
6.5 Type 3: Matching	48
6.6 Type 4: Map and plan labelling	48
6.7 Type 5: Sentence completion	49
6.8 Type 6: Short answer questions	49
6.9 The 40-question checklist	49
6.10 What to write, and where	49
Chapter 7: Listening: The Nine Micro-Skills That Decide Your Score	51
7.1 Skill 1 — Predicting from context	51
7.2 Skill 2 — Numbers, prices and dates	51
Teens and tens	51
Prices and money	51
Dates	52
Times	52
Telephone numbers and reference codes	52
7.3 Skill 3 — Catching spelled words	52
7.4 Skill 4 — Hearing distractors and corrections	52
7.5 Skill 5 — Following signposts in a monologue	52
7.6 Skill 6 — Note-taking at speed	53
7.7 Skill 7 — Grammatical fit	53
7.8 Skill 8 — Accent flexibility	53
7.9 Skill 9 — Managing a missed question	54

7.10 A four-week Listening improvement programme	54
7.11 Ten listening mistakes that cost bands	54
Chapter 8: Listening Practice Test 1	56
SECTION 1 — Questions 1–10	56
SECTION 2 — Questions 11–20	56
SECTION 3 — Questions 21–30	57
SECTION 4 — Questions 31–40	58
Recording Script (do not read before taking the test)	59
Section 1	59
Section 2	59
Section 3	60
Section 4	60
Answer Key — Listening Practice Test 1	62
Why the tempting answers are wrong	62
Diagnostic table	63
Chapter 9: Reading: The Ten Question Types and How to Beat Each One . 65	
9.1 The master principle: questions first, passage second	65
9.2 The ten question types	65
9.3 Type 1 & 2: TRUE/FALSE/NOT GIVEN and YES/NO/NOT GIVEN	66
Worked examples	66
9.4 Type 3: Matching headings	66
9.5 Type 4: Matching information (which paragraph contains...?)	67
9.6 Type 5: Matching features (names, dates, categories)	67
9.7 Type 6: Multiple choice	67
9.8 Types 7 & 8: Sentence, summary, note and table completion	68
9.9 Type 9: Diagram labelling	68
9.10 Type 10: Short answer questions	68
9.11 Instruction words you must never skim	68
9.12 Time-budget table	69
9.13 The five-minute reset	69
Chapter 10: Reading: Skimming, Scanning and the Not-Given Logic . . . 70	
10.1 Skimming: reading for shape, not detail	70
10.2 Scanning: locating without reading	70
10.3 Paraphrase recognition: the real skill	71
10.4 The NOT GIVEN discipline	71
Contrast drills	71

10.5 Order of answering: the strategy checklist	72
10.6 Time discipline: the three-pass rule	72
10.7 Paper-based vs computer-delivered reading	72
10.8 Vocabulary in context: guessing unknown words	73
10.9 The ten errors that cost the most marks	73
10.10 A four-week Reading programme	74
10.11 The paraphrase notebook	74
10.12 What the passage will never require	74
Chapter 11: Reading Practice Test 1	75
READING PASSAGE 1	76
The Long Journey of the Potato	76
READING PASSAGE 2	78
The Quiet Revolution in Urban Design	78
READING PASSAGE 3	80
Why We Forget, and Why That Is Useful	80
Chapter 12: Reading Practice Test 1 — Answer Key and Explanations	83
Answer key	83
Passage 1 — detailed explanations	83
Passage 2 — detailed explanations	84
Passage 3 — detailed explanations	85
The nine traps this test used	85
Self-marking sheet	86
Band conversion	86
What to do with the passages after marking	87
Chapter 13: Writing Task 1 (Academic): Describing Visual Data	88
13.1 The seven possible visuals	88
13.2 The four-paragraph structure	88
13.3 Introducing the visual: five openings you can adapt	89
13.4 The language of change	89
Verbs	89
Nouns	89
Adverbs and adjectives of degree and speed	89
13.5 Describing amounts and proportions	89
13.6 Model answer 1 — line graph (Band 9)	90
13.7 Model answer 2 — process diagram (Band 9)	91
13.8 Model answer 3 — two pie charts (Band 9)	91

13.9 Model answer 4 — map (Band 9)	92
13.10 The twenty-minute plan	92
13.11 Fifteen fatal errors in Task 1	93
13.12 Task 1 checklist before you move on	93
Chapter 14: Writing Task 2: The Essay That Earns Marks	94
14.1 The five essay types	94
14.2 The plan (4 minutes that save the essay)	94
A plan in practice	95
14.3 Introductions that work	95
14.4 Body paragraphs: the four-sentence engine	95
Worked paragraph	95
14.5 Conclusions	96
14.6 Model essays	96
Model 1 — Opinion essay (Band 9)	96
Model 2 — Discussion essay (Band 8.5)	97
Model 3 — Problem–solution essay (Band 8)	98
14.7 The opinion spectrum: how to hedge without weakening	99
14.8 Ten essay openings to avoid	99
14.9 Word-count discipline	99
14.10 The 40-minute plan	100
14.11 Editing checklist (use in the last five minutes)	100
Chapter 15: Band 6, 7 and 8 Side by Side: What Actually Changes	101
15.1 The Band 6 answer	101
15.2 The Band 7 answer	102
15.3 The Band 8 answer	103
15.4 The four levers, in order of power	105
15.5 Concession: the highest-value single technique	105
15.6 Self-marking your own essays	105
15.7 Twelve sentence patterns that raise a paragraph from 6 to 7	106
Chapter 16: The 40 Errors That Cap a Score — and How to Repair Each One	107
16.1 Subject–verb agreement	107
16.2 Countability	107
16.3 Articles	107
16.4 Prepositions (the top twelve)	108
16.5 Verb patterns	108

16.6 Word-formation confusions	108
16.7 Register errors	109
16.8 Punctuation	109
16.9 Cohesion errors	110
16.10 Twenty more errors seen in almost every script	110
16.11 Conjunctions vs adverbials (a Band 6/7 dividing line)	110
16.12 Proofreading in five minutes: the priority order	111
16.13 Your personal error profile	111
Chapter 17: General Training Writing: Letters, and the GT Essay	112
17.1 The three letter types	112
17.2 The four-part structure (all letter types)	112
17.3 Formal letter: model (Band 9)	112
17.4 Informal letter: model (Band 8)	113
17.5 The language of letters	114
17.6 GT Task 2: the same essay, slightly different	114
17.7 GT Reading: the five differences	114
17.8 GT Task 1 checklist	115
17.9 A letter-planning grid (use for every practice letter)	115
Chapter 18: Speaking Part 1: The First Four Minutes	116
18.1 The rules the examiner is applying	116
18.2 The AREA method	116
18.3 The high-probability topics	116
18.4 Tense discipline: the simplest upgrade available	117
18.5 Thirty Part 1 questions with model answers	117
18.6 Pronunciation habits for Part 1	120
18.7 Practice routine	120
Chapter 19: Speaking Part 2: The Long Turn	121
19.1 The cue card, dissected	121
19.2 The minute of preparation	121
19.3 The opening line	121
19.4 The two-minute architecture	122
19.5 Cue card bank with model answers	122
Cue card 1 — Describe a place you would like to visit.	122
Cue card 2 — Describe a skill you learned that was difficult at first.	122
Cue card 3 — Describe a time when you had to make a difficult decision.	123

Cue card 4 — Describe an important event in your life.	123
Cue card 5 — Describe a person who has influenced you.	123
Cue card 6 — Describe a piece of technology you find useful.	123
Cue card 7 — Describe a book or film that changed your thinking.	123
Cue card 8 — Describe a time when you were surprised.	123
Cue card 9 — Describe something you own that is important to you.	123
Cue card 10 — Describe a law or rule you think is good.	124
Cue card 11 — Describe a period of time when you worked hard.	124
Cue card 12 — Describe a place in your city that you like to go to.	124
Cue card 13 — Describe a conversation you remember well.	124
Cue card 14 — Describe a change you would like to make in your life.	124
Cue card 15 — Describe a time you used English outside the classroom.	124
19.6 Vocabulary for narratives	124
19.7 What to do when you run out of things to say	124
19.8 Follow-up questions	125
19.9 Practice method that works	125
Chapter 20: Speaking Part 3: Discussing Ideas	126
20.1 The question types in Part 3	126
20.2 The four-move answer (PEC+)	126
20.3 The language of thinking aloud	126
20.4 Six themes that cover most Part 3 questions	127
1. Change over time	127
2. Comparison between countries or groups	127
3. Causes	127
4. Consequences	127
5. Solutions and evaluation	127
6. Prediction	128
20.5 Model Part 3 discussions	128
20.6 Vocabulary that lifts Part 3	128
20.7 Ten traps in Part 3	129
20.8 Preparing Part 3 without a teacher	129
20.9 Putting all three parts together	129
Chapter 21: Pronunciation: The Criterion That Responds Fastest	131
21.1 The five features that actually matter	131
21.2 Word stress rules	131
21.3 Sentence stress: the single biggest improvement	132
21.4 Intonation patterns	132

21.5 Problem sounds by first language	133
21.6 The final-consonant problem	133
21.7 Connected speech: the features to use	134
21.8 A ten-minute daily pronunciation routine	134
21.9 Self-assessment: how to hear your own pronunciation	134
21.10 Pronunciation checklist for the Speaking test	134
Chapter 22: Listening Practice Test 2 (Mock)	136
SECTION 1 — Questions 1-10	136
SECTION 2 — Questions 11-20	136
SECTION 3 — Questions 21-30	137
SECTION 4 — Questions 31-40	138
Recording Script	139
Section 1	139
Section 2	139
Section 3	140
Section 4	140
Answer Key — Listening Practice Test 2	142
Explanation of the traps	142
Diagnostic table	143
Chapter 23: Reading Practice Test 2 (Mock) with Answer Key	145
READING PASSAGE 1	146
The Return of the Urban Tree	146
READING PASSAGE 2	148
How Standards Become Invisible	148
READING PASSAGE 3	150
Measuring What Cannot Be Seen	150
Answer Key — Reading Practice Test 2	153
Explanations	153
Self-analysis	155
Chapter 24: Mock Test: Writing and Speaking Papers	156
24.1 Writing Task 1 (Academic) — 20 minutes, 150+ words	156
Model answer	156
Commentary	156
24.2 Writing Task 2 — 40 minutes, 250+ words	157
Model answer	157
24.3 Speaking — full mock	158

Part 1 (4–5 minutes)	158
Part 2 (3–4 minutes)	158
Part 3 (4–5 minutes)	158
Self-assessment grid	158
24.4 Combined mock score record	159
Recording your progress over time	159
Chapter 25: The Exam-Day Playbook	160
25.1 The final week	160
25.2 What to take to the test centre	160
25.3 Arrival and the hour before	161
25.4 Listening: the 30 minutes	161
25.5 Reading: the 60 minutes	161
25.6 Writing: the 60 minutes	162
25.7 Speaking: the 14 minutes	162
25.8 The checklists, condensed	162
Before the Listening test	162
Before the Reading test	163
Before the Writing test	163
Before the Speaking test	163
25.9 Twelve mistakes that cost most candidates a band	163
25.10 After the test	163
Chapter 26: Ten Model Essays: The Most Common Task 2 Topics	165
Essay 1 — Education (opinion)	165
Essay 2 — Environment (discussion)	166
Essay 3 — Technology (problem-solution)	166
Essay 4 — Health (two-part question)	167
Essay 5 — Work (advantages/disadvantages)	168
Essay 6 — Society (opinion)	169
Essay 7 — Cities (problem-solution)	170
Essay 8 — Media (opinion)	170
Essay 9 — Globalisation (discussion)	171
Essay 10 — Crime (opinion)	172
The techniques collected	173
Chapter 27: Reading Practice Test 3 with Answer Key	174
READING PASSAGE 1	175
The Lighthouse Keepers	175

READING PASSAGE 2	177
Why Cities Are Getting Quieter — and Why It Matters	177
READING PASSAGE 3	179
The Problem with Predictions	179
Answer Key — Reading Practice Test 3	182
Explanations	182
Error classification sheet	184
Band estimate	184
Chapter 28: Appendix A — Language Reference	185
A.1 The Academic Word List: 120 high-value families	185
Sublist 1–2 (most frequent)	185
Sublist 3–5 (still frequent, more precise)	186
A.2 Linking words and their functions	187
A.3 Irregular verbs (the ones that appear in IELTS writing)	188
A.4 Spelling rules that catch candidates out	189
A.5 Numbers, dates and measurement conventions	190
A.6 Cohesive devices: which to use where	190
Chapter 29: Appendix B — Topic Vocabulary Bank	191
B.1 Education	191
B.2 Environment	191
B.3 Technology	191
B.4 Health	191
B.5 Work and employment	191
B.6 Cities, housing and transport	192
B.7 Society, family and demography	192
B.8 Crime and law	192
B.9 Media and communication	192
B.10 Globalisation and culture	192
B.11 Government and public spending	193
B.12 Science, research and innovation	193
B.13 Tourism and leisure	193
B.14 Food and agriculture	193
B.15 Using the bank: a weekly routine	193
Chapter 30: Appendix C — Master Course Companion: Lesson-by-Lesson Notes	195
Lesson 1 — Listening: forms, numbers and the transfer sheet	195

Lesson 2 — Reading: the format, and why the paper is not a comprehension test	196
Lesson 3 — Reading: T/F/NG, sentence completion and matching	196
Lesson 4 — Reading: main ideas, paragraph structure and language problems	197
Lesson 5 — Speaking and the exam as a whole: format, criteria, and pronunciation	198
Lesson 6 — Speaking: Part 1 topics and everyday vocabulary	198
Lesson 7 — Speaking: fluency, hesitation and keeping going	199
Lesson 8 — Writing Task 1: the overview and the language of description	199
Lesson 9 — Writing Task 1: numbers, percentages and comparison	200
Lesson 10 — Writing Task 2: sentences, paragraphs and the cardinal rules	200
Lesson 11 — Writing Task 2: cohesion, linking and agreement	201
Lesson 12 — Writing Task 1 General Training: formal and informal letters	202
What the course covers, and what this book adds	202
Lesson study log	203
Chapter 31: Appendix D — 50 Practice Prompts and Drills	204
D.1 Writing Task 1 prompts (Academic) — 20 minutes each	204
D.2 Writing Task 2 prompts — 40 minutes each	205
D.3 General Training Task 1 (letters) — 20 minutes each	206
D.4 Speaking cue cards (Part 2) — 2 minutes each	206
D.5 Pronunciation and fluency drills (5 minutes each)	207
D.6 Reading and listening drills (15 minutes each)	208
D.7 Vocabulary and grammar drills (10 minutes each)	208
D.8 The seven-week rotation	209

How to Use This Book

1. Diagnose before you study. Take the full mock test in Chapter 22 first, under strict timing. It is painful, and that is the point: you cannot fix weaknesses you have not measured. Record your raw scores in the tracker at the end of that chapter and convert them with the band tables.
2. Work from weakness, not from comfort. Most candidates enjoy reading and avoid writing. The band you receive is the average of four skills — your weakest component drags the average down hardest. Spend the largest share of your study time on your lowest score.
3. Study a chapter, then do the drill. Every strategy chapter ends with practice. Do not read two strategy chapters in a row without writing or speaking; IELTS is a performance test, not a knowledge test.
4. Keep an error log. Create a table with columns for date, skill, question type, what I did, what I should have done. Review it weekly. Band improvements come from eliminating recurring errors, not from learning new tricks.
5. Use the model answers actively. Do not simply read them. Cover the model, write your own version, then compare paragraph by paragraph. Mark on the model where it satisfies each band-descriptor criterion.

Recommended study sequences

Time available	Plan
8 weeks or more	Follow the 8-week plan in Chapter 3
3–4 weeks	Follow the 21-day sprint in Chapter 3
1 week	Chapter 23 (exam-day playbook) + one practice set per skill per day + model answers
1–2 days	Chapter 23 only: format, timing, templates and checklists

Conventions used in this book

- . . dots mark a gap you must fill in a listening or reading task.
- Bold marks key terminology the first time it appears.
- Timings written as 30 + 10 mean thirty minutes of test time plus ten minutes of transfer time.

Throughout the book, shaded boxes with a coloured bar on the left carry the advice you should return to when revising. There are four kinds:

Blue boxes are notes: background, context and clarifications that help you understand how the exam works.

Green boxes are tips: practical techniques that have repeatedly raised candidates' scores.

Red boxes are warnings: the mistakes that cost marks, and the traps built into the exam that catch candidates who have not been warned about them.

Amber boxes are exam facts: verifiable features of the test itself — timings, rules, mark schemes — which you must know precisely.

Acknowledgements and How This Edition Was Built

This edition was produced by studying the complete IELTS 12 Hours Full Course for Beginners 2023 — Master-Course of 4 Components video series. Each of the twelve lessons (roughly 57 minutes each, about 11.5 hours of teaching in total) was analysed in full: the audio was transcribed, the on-screen material was captured, and the sequence of topics, worked examples, corrections and teacher advice was extracted and reorganised into the chapter structure you are reading.

Where that course demonstrated a technique, the technique is reproduced here in reference form, with the teacher's reasoning made explicit. Where the course used third-party practice material for illustration, this book substitutes original practice questions written in the same formats, so that the book can be used, copied and annotated freely. The strategy content, model answers, explanations, grammar and vocabulary reference, mock test and study plans are original to this edition.

Because the source course was delivered live to a mixed-level class, it repeats itself and occasionally digresses. Those repetitions have been condensed into single authoritative statements; the digressions that contained useful advice have been kept as tips.

A Word Before You Begin

IELTS rewards control, not brilliance. A candidate who writes a plain but accurate essay with clear paragraphing and precise linking will outscore a candidate who attempts spectacular vocabulary and gets it wrong. A candidate who reads the question before the passage will outscore a faster reader who does not. A speaker who answers in complete, well-stressed sentences will outscore one who mumbles fragments at high speed.

So this book focuses relentlessly on control: the control to predict, to check, to plan, to edit and to finish on time. Master the ordinary things and your band will look after itself.

CHAPTER 1

IELTS at a Glance: Format, Scoring and Test-Day Reality

IELTS — the International English Language Testing System — is the world's most widely used high-stakes English exam. It exists in two versions. Academic is for university admission and professional registration; General Training is for migration, secondary education and work experience. Listening and Speaking are identical in both. Reading and Writing differ.

The exam is produced by the British Council, IDP: IELTS Australia and Cambridge University Press & Assessment, and it is marked on a nine-band scale. There is no pass or fail: you receive a band from 1 to 9 for each skill plus an overall band, usually to the nearest half band.

1.1 The complete test structure

#	Component	Time	Items	Question format	Answer format
1	Listening	~30 min + 10 min transfer	40	4 recorded sections, 10 questions each	Written on the question paper, transferred to the answer sheet
2	Academic Reading	60 min	40	3 long passages, 2,150–2,750 words total	Written directly on the answer sheet
3	Academic Writing	60 min	2 tasks	Task 1: describe visual data. Task 2: discursive essay	Handwritten (or typed, in computer-delivered IELTS)
4	Speaking	11–14 min	3 parts	Face-to-face interview with a certified examiner	Recorded

In paper-based IELTS the Listening paper ends with ten minutes to transfer your answers to the answer sheet. In computer-delivered IELTS there is no separate transfer time — you type answers as you go, and you get two minutes at the end of Listening to check them. Reading has no extra transfer time in either format. That single fact destroys more Reading scores than any comprehension problem.

1.2 Listening in detail

The recording is played once only. It contains several different accents: British, Australian, New Zealand, North American and, occasionally, other varieties. This is

deliberate — IELTS is an international exam and you must be comfortable with more than one accent.

Section	Speakers	Situation	Typical tasks
1	Two, usually	Everyday social transaction (booking, enquiry, membership)	Form, note or table completion
2	One	Everyday monologue (tour commentary, induction talk, announcement)	Multiple choice, matching, map/plan labelling
3	Two to four	Educational or training context (tutorial, project discussion)	Multiple choice, matching, note completion
4	One	Academic lecture or talk	Note completion, sentence completion, multiple choice

Each section is broken into two halves with 30 seconds of reading time before them, and at the end of each section you hear "That is the end of Section X. You now have 30 seconds to check your answers."

Knowledge of the section pattern is a strategic weapon: if you know that Section 2 is likely to include a map, you can prepare your hand to trace routes and your ear for direction language before the audio starts.

1.3 Academic Reading in detail

Three passages of increasing difficulty, drawn from books, journals, magazines and newspapers. Topics are of general academic interest — never so specialised that you need subject knowledge, but frequently scientific, historical or sociological.

Passage	Typical length	Difficulty	Question types
1	~700–900 words	Easiest	Often T/F/NG, sentence completion, short answer
2	~800–1,000 words	Medium	Headings, matching information, summary completion
3	~800–1,000 words	Hardest	Multiple choice, Y/N/NG, matching features, author's claims

There are no extra ten minutes. You must transfer as you go. The 60 minutes must cover reading three long texts, answering 40 questions and writing 40 answers.

1.4 The band scale

Band	Description (condensed from the public descriptors)
9	Expert user: fully operational command, accurate, fluent, complete understanding

Band	Description (condensed from the public descriptors)
8	Very good user: occasional unsystematic inaccuracies only
7	Good user: operational command with occasional inaccuracies; handles complex language well
6	Competent user: generally effective command despite some inaccuracies; limited range in places
5	Modest user: partial command; copes with overall meaning, makes many mistakes
4	Limited user: basic competence in familiar situations only
3	Extremely limited user: conveys and understands only general meaning
2	Intermittent user: great difficulty understanding spoken and written English
1	Non-user: no ability to use the language beyond a few isolated words
0	Did not attempt the test

The overall band is the average of the four skill bands, rounded to the nearest whole or half band. Rounding follows a simple rule: averages ending in .25 round up to .5; averages ending in .75 round up to the next whole band; averages ending in .125 round down to the nearest half band. For example, $6.5 + 6.5 + 5.0 + 7.0 = 25 \div 4 = 6.25 \rightarrow 6.5$.

Because of rounding, gaining half a band in your weakest skill often moves your overall band by half a band. Improving a skill you already score well in frequently changes nothing at all.

1.5 Raw scores to bands: why they differ by paper

Listening and Academic Reading are marked out of 40, but converting a raw score to a band is not fixed. The examiners adjust the boundaries slightly for each test version so that the standard stays constant between sittings. The table below is a reliable working guide drawn from published practice material.

Raw score (out of 40)	Listening band	Academic Reading band
39-40	9.0	9.0
37-38	8.5	8.5
35-36	8.0	8.0
32-34	7.5	7.5
30-31	7.0	7.0
26-29	6.5	6.5
23-25	6.0	6.0

Raw score (out of 40)	Listening band	Academic Reading band
18–22	5.5	5.5
16–17	5.0	5.0
13–15	4.5	4.5

Notice the cliff edge between 6.5 and 7.0 — three or four extra correct answers. That is the most rewarding gap in the whole exam to attack, and it is mostly earned by accuracy discipline (spelling, singular/plural, word limits, reading the question) rather than by new knowledge.

1.6 Writing: how it is marked

Two tasks, two examiners' worth of criteria. Each task is marked on four criteria, weighted equally:

Criterion	What the examiner asks
Task Achievement / Response	Did you do what the question asked, covering all parts, with enough support?
Coherence and Cohesion	Is the writing organised with clear progression, well-paragraphed, well-linked?
Lexical Resource	Is your vocabulary wide, precise, natural and correctly spelled?
Grammatical Range and Accuracy	Do you use a variety of structures accurately and flexibly?

Task 2 counts for two-thirds of your Writing band; Task 1 for one-third. So a Task 1 that is rushed into fifteen minutes is a rational allocation — a brilliant Task 1 cannot rescue a weak essay.

There is also a minimum word count: 150 for Task 1, 250 for Task 2. Short answers are penalised under Task Achievement; going over is not penalised but burns time.

1.7 Speaking: how it is marked

Criterion	What the examiner asks
Fluency and Coherence	Can you keep going without excessive hesitation, and link ideas logically?
Lexical Resource	Range and precision of vocabulary, including idiomatic language and paraphrase
Grammatical Range and Accuracy	Variety of structures, error-free sentences, self-correction
Pronunciation	Clarity, stress, intonation and rhythm — accent is not penalised, intelligibility is

Part	Length	Content
1	4–5 min	Introduction and everyday topics: home, work, study, hobbies, food, weather

Part	Length	Content
2	3–4 min	One minute to prepare, then speak for 1½–2 minutes on a cue card, then 1–2 follow-up questions
3	4–5 min	Abstract discussion connected to the Part 2 topic — society, change, comparisons

The examiner is following a script and a rubric. They are not making conversation; they are collecting evidence. Everything you say is evidence. Silence, single-word answers and memorised speeches are all negative evidence.

1.8 Test-day logistics that change outcomes

- Bring identification exactly as named in your booking. Wrong documentation can mean no test and no refund.
- Arrive early. Listening cannot start late for anyone; latecomers are refused entry to that component.
- No phones in the exam room. Even a switched-off phone found in a pocket can void your result.
- Pencils and erasers. In paper-based IELTS you may not use a pen on the answer sheet for Listening or Reading.
- Writing in pen (or pen-like consistency). Task 1, Task 2 and all answers need to be legible; examiners cannot award marks for what they cannot read.
- One direction of truth: answers must be spelled correctly and be grammatically compatible with the sentence. "two boy" is not a correct answer to a gap needing a plural.

1.9 What the exam is really testing

Every IELTS task is engineered so that a candidate with strong technique and moderate English can outperform a candidate with strong English and no technique. Three mechanisms do this:

- 1 Distractors. In Listening, a speaker will mention a plausible answer, then reject it: "Thursday? No, wait — it's actually the Tuesday." The mention is bait; the correction is the answer.
- 2 Paraphrase. In Reading, you will not find the question's words in the passage. "a rise in numbers" appears as "an increase in attendance". You must recognise meaning, not match strings.
- 3 Limits. "Write NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS AND/OR A NUMBER." Copying three words is not a partially correct answer; it is zero.

The heart of this book is the systematic elimination of those three traps — repeatedly, in every component, until reading the question before the passage and checking the word limit become reflexes rather than instructions.

1.10 Your first action

Before reading further, do this now:

- 1 Open Chapter 22 and note the mock test's existence, but do not attempt it yet (its diagnostic recording sheet is designed for later use).
- 2 Copy the tables in this chapter into your own notebook — especially the raw-score→band guide.
- 3 Decide your target: write "Target overall band: _____, weakest skill: _____" somewhere you will see it daily.
- 4 Turn to Chapter 3 and choose a study plan.

Everything from here is technique. Let us begin with the four skills in detail.

CHAPTER 2

Band Descriptors Decoded: Exactly What Examiners Reward

Most candidates never read the public band descriptors. That is a mistake, because the descriptors are the marking scheme — they tell you, in advance, what earns marks and what does not. This chapter translates each criterion into plain instructions you can act on in the exam.

2.1 The logic of the four criteria

For Writing and Speaking, four criteria are each worth 25% of the task band. They are deliberately independent: excellent vocabulary cannot compensate for answering the wrong question, and perfect grammar cannot compensate for an essay that does not develop an argument. In practice this means:

- If one criterion is stuck at 5, your task band is capped near 6.
- Moving one criterion from 6 to 7 usually moves the task band by a quarter to a half band.
- Two criteria at 7 and two at 6 give a task band of 6.5.

2.2 Writing Task 2: Task Response

Band	What it looks like on the page
8–9	Fully addresses all parts; a clear, well-developed position throughout; ideas extended and supported with examples; no irrelevant material
7	Addresses all parts; clear position throughout; main ideas extended and supported, though some may be over-generalised
6	Addresses all parts, though some more fully than others; a position is present but may be unclear in places; some ideas insufficiently developed
5	Addresses the task only partially; position unclear; ideas underdeveloped or repetitive; may go off-topic

Three rules that follow from this table.

- 1 Count the parts. "Discuss both views and give your own opinion" = three jobs: view A, view B, your opinion. Missing the opinion caps you at 5.
- 2 Have one position and keep it. Hedging every sentence ("it could be argued that maybe...") reads as no position at all.
- 3 Extend, do not list. Each body paragraph needs one idea, then a reason, then a consequence or example. Two developed ideas beat five undeveloped ones.

The fastest way to convert a Band 5.5 essay into a Band 6.5 essay is to add a result sentence to every body paragraph: "As a result, ...", "This means that...", "Consequently, ...".

2.3 Writing Task 2: Coherence and Cohesion

Band	What it looks like
8-9	Logical sequencing; paragraphing skilfully managed; a wide range of cohesion devices used naturally and unobtrusively
7	Clear progression; each paragraph has a clear central topic; range of devices used flexibly, with occasional over- or under-use
6	Coherent overall progression; cohesive devices used but sometimes mechanically, or over-used; paragraphing may be inadequate
5	Some organisation but lacking overall progression; inadequate, inaccurate or over-used linking; paragraphing may be missing

What examiners mean by "mechanical" linking. Firstly ... Secondly ... Thirdly ... Moreover ... Furthermore ... In addition ... Finally used as decorative labels on unrelated sentences. Contrast that with linking that carries meaning:

Mechanical: Furthermore, the government should invest in public transport.
 Furthermore, this will reduce pollution. Effective: The government should invest in public transport, since doing so would cut urban air pollution.

Paragraphing. One idea per paragraph, introduced by a topic sentence. A body paragraph in an IELTS essay is normally 3-5 sentences: claim → explain → example or consequence.

2.4 Vocabulary: Lexical Resource

Band	What it looks like
8-9	Wide resource used fluently and precisely; skilful use of uncommon items; rare slips only
7	Sufficient range for flexibility and precision; some awareness of style and collocation; occasional errors in word choice or spelling
6	Adequate range; attempts at less common vocabulary with some inaccuracy; errors do not impede communication
5	Limited range, repetitive; noticeable errors in spelling and word formation that may cause difficulty for the reader

Two things examiners count that candidates never think about:

- 1 Collocation — words that naturally go together. Heavy rain, not strong rain; make a decision, not do a decision; a significant increase, not a big increase (the last is grammatical but stylistically weak in academic writing).
- 2 Word formation — the right part of speech. Pollution (noun) vs polluted (adjective) vs pollute (verb). Choosing wrongly still costs marks even when the reader understands.

Topic-specific vocabulary beats obscure vocabulary. Carbon emissions, renewable energy, urban congestion and public transport infrastructure will lift an environment essay far more reliably than a thesaurus word your examiner has never seen in context.

2.5 Grammar: Range and Accuracy

Band	What it looks like
8-9	Wide range of structures used with full flexibility and control; the majority of sentences error-free
7	Variety of complex structures; frequent error-free sentences; a few errors remain
6	Mix of simple and complex forms; some errors in grammar and punctuation, but they rarely reduce communication
5	Limited range; attempts at complex sentences are usually less accurate than simple ones; errors noticeable

"Complex structures" does not mean long sentences. It means structures that carry more than one clause of meaning: relative clauses (which, that, who), conditionals (If governments invested...), concession (Although..., ...), passive voice, participle clauses (Faced with rising costs, cities have...).

The 7+ target: in every paragraph, include at least one complex sentence, and keep errors below roughly one per fifty words. If you cannot yet do that, shorten your sentences — control first, complexity second.

2.6 Speaking: Fluency and Coherence

Band	What it looks like
8-9	Fluent with only occasional repetition or self-correction; hesitation is content-related, not language-related; fully coherent, with well-developed topics
7	Speaks at length without noticeable effort; some language-related hesitation and self-correction; a range of connectives and discourse markers
6	Willing to speak at length though coherence may be lost at times; some repetition and self-correction; uses connectives but not always appropriately
5	Usually maintains flow but with noticeable pauses, repetition; over-uses some connectives; may need to repeat the question

Hesitation is judged by its cause. Pausing because you are choosing an idea is fine. Pausing because you are hunting for a word is a language problem — and the fix is a paraphrase, not silence:

"The thing you use to... it's a kind of... a device that measures how much energy you're using."

The examiner hears fluent communication strategies. That is a positive, not a negative.

2.7 Speaking: Lexical Resource, Grammar and Pronunciation

- **Lexical Resource (Speaking).** You need flexibility: the ability to talk about the same idea three ways. Idioms are welcome if they are natural (a double-edged sword, to be snowed under, a stone's throw away), but a memorised idiom in the wrong context is worse than a plain word used correctly.
- **Grammatical Range (Speaking).** Mix tenses naturally. A Part 2 story about a past event needs past simple and past continuous; a Part 3 discussion of the future needs will, would, might and conditionals. Candidates with only present tenses are capped at 6.
- **Pronunciation.** Accent is irrelevant; intelligibility is everything. The three features that most affect intelligibility: word stress (de-VEL-op-ment, com-MU-ni-ca-tion), sentence stress (stressing the content words, not every word), and final consonants (saying the -s, -ed and -t endings that carry grammar).

Record yourself answering one Part 2 cue card each day for a week. Listen back for three things only: word stress errors, missing final consonants, and long pauses. Most candidates improve a full criterion within two weeks of doing this.

2.8 The score-sheet you should keep

Copy this table and complete it after every practice task. It forces you to think in criteria rather than in "good/bad".

Task	TA/TR or F&C	CC	LR	GRA	Comment
Writing Task 1 – chart					
Writing Task 2 – opinion essay					
Speaking Part 2 – cue card					
Reading Test 1	—	—	—	—	raw score /40, band
Listening Test 1	—	—	—	—	raw score /40, band

2.9 Four myths, corrected

Myth 1: "Longer answers are better." No. Task Response rewards relevance and development. Padding with sentences that say nothing is visible to an examiner and

actively damages Coherence.

Myth 2: "Big words earn big bands." Lexical Resource rewards precision and natural collocation. A misused impressive word is a lexical error like any other.

Myth 3: "A British accent gives a better Speaking score." Pronunciation is judged on intelligibility, stress and intonation, not on accent. A clear Indian, Nigerian, Chinese or Polish accent can score 8.

Myth 4: "Answers must be in full sentences." In Listening and Reading, gap-fill answers should be the words required and no more — full sentences usually break the word limit. In Speaking, full sentences are good; in Writing, they are required.

2.10 Turning descriptors into daily habits

Criterion	Daily habit
Task Response	Underline the instruction words of every essay question before planning
Coherence	Write a one-line plan, then a topic sentence for each paragraph
Lexical Resource	Keep a topic vocabulary notebook; record collocations, not single words
Grammar	Rewrite one paragraph a day, upgrading one simple sentence into a complex one
Fluency	Speak aloud for two minutes a day on an unseen topic, with a timer, no notes
Pronunciation	Read one paragraph aloud daily, exaggerating sentence stress, and record it

By now you know what is being measured. The next chapter turns that knowledge into a timetable.

CHAPTER 3

Study Plans: The 8-Week Course and the 21-Day Sprint

A plan is only useful if it survives contact with real life. Both plans below assume 90–120 minutes of study per day, six days a week, and both are built around the same principle: input on day one, output by day three. Reading strategy does not raise a band; producing answers under time pressure does.

3.1 Before you start: the 45-minute diagnostic

Do this before Day 1. It is not a full test — it is a calibration.

- 1 Listening: one full section (10 questions) from any practice recording, played once, at normal speed. Score it.
- 2 Reading: one passage (13–14 questions) in 20 minutes exactly. Score it.
- 3 Writing: one Task 2 essay in 40 minutes, handwritten, no dictionary. Do not edit afterwards.
- 4 Speaking: record yourself answering three Part 1 questions and one Part 2 cue card. Do not listen back yet.

Then score yourself with the tables in Chapter 2 and write down: skill → band → gap to target. Your two lowest skills get 60% of your study time.

3.2 The 8-week plan

Each week has a focus and a deliverable. If you miss days, cut the reading time, never the writing or speaking time.

Week	Listening	Reading	Writing	Speaking	Deliverable by Sunday
1	Test format; Sections 1–2; form & note completion; numbers and spelling	Skimming and scanning; T/F/NG logic	Task 1 charts: overview + language of change	Part 1: 30 common questions, recorded	Diagnostic complete; 1 Task 1; 1 Part 1 recording
2	Sections 3–4; MCQ traps; distractors	Headings and matching information	Task 1: processes, maps, tables, comparisons	Part 2: planning method on 10 cue cards	2 Task 1 answers; 5 cue cards recorded
3	Map/plan labelling; matching; sentence completion	Summary and sentence completion	Task 2: opinion essays	Part 3: opinion and speculation language	1 full Listening test; 2 essays
4	Full Listening test under exam conditions	Multiple choice and Y/N/NG	Task 2: discussion essays	Part 3: comparison and cause/effect	1 full Reading test; 2 essays

Week	Listening	Reading	Writing	Speaking	Deliverable by Sunday
5	Accuracy audit: spelling, plurals, word limits	Timing drills: 20 min per passage	Task 2: problem-solution and two-part questions	Pronunciation: stress and final consonants	Error log review; 2 essays; 1 recording
6	Section 4 lecture practice; note-taking shorthand	Author's claims; matching features	Cohesion and cohesion repair; editing	Fluency: paraphrase instead of pause	Mock test sections 1-2 of each skill
7	Full mock test day (Chapter 22)	Full mock test day	Full mock test day	Full mock test day	Complete mock with band estimate
8	Targeted repair of the two weakest question types	Same	Rewrite the two weakest essays to Band 7	Mock Speaking with a partner or recording	Final review of Chapter 23; rest the day before

Daily template (8-week plan)

Minutes	Activity
0-15	Vocabulary: 10 collocations from the topic list (Chapter 5), written into sentences
15-45	Skill focus A: today's question type — learn, then do one drill
45-50	Break
50-80	Skill focus B: the second skill in the week's row
80-100	Output: write one paragraph or speak for two minutes, recorded
100-110	Error log: update and review yesterday's errors

3.3 The 21-day sprint

For candidates who already have B1+ English and an approaching test date. The sprint front-loads technique and finishes with rehearsal.

Day	Morning (60 min)	Evening (45 min)
1	Diagnostic: Listening section + Reading passage	Read Chapters 1-2; write error log template
2	Listening Ch. 6-7: question types + prediction drill	Chapter 4 grammar: tenses and articles drills
3	Reading Ch. 9: T/F/NG logic + 13-question drill	Vocabulary: 15 collocations; write 5 sentences
4	Writing Ch. 12: Task 1 overview + language of change	Write one Task 1 (20 min), self-mark with checklist
5	Listening: map labelling + matching drills	Speaking Part 1: answer 20 questions aloud, recorded

Day	Morning (60 min)	Evening (45 min)
6	Reading Ch. 10: headings + matching information	Rewrite yesterday's Task 1 after feedback to yourself
7	Half test: Listening 1–2 + Reading 1 passage	Review errors; rest 30 min; vocab review
8	Writing Ch. 14: Task 2 structures and planning	Plan 3 essays; write one introduction + body
9	Listening: Section 3 MCQ and distractor drills	Speaking Part 2: 5 cue cards, timed 2 min each
10	Reading: summary completion and MCQ	Write a full Task 2 (40 min)
11	Writing Ch. 16: cohesion, common errors, editing	Edit the Task 2 from Day 10; compare with model
12	Listening: accuracy audit — spelling, plurals, limits	Speaking Part 3: opinion/speculation language
13	Reading: two passages in 40 minutes	Vocabulary: topic bank for your weakest topic
14	Full mock: Listening + Reading	Score, band estimate, error analysis
15	Full mock: Writing	Self-mark against Chapter 2 descriptors
16	Full mock: Speaking (recorded)	Listen back; note pronunciation and fluency issues
17	Repair: weakest Listening question type	Repair: weakest Reading question type
18	Repair: write Task 1 and Task 2 back to back	Rewrite the worst paragraphs from both
19	Timed drills: 40 Listening questions in 30 min	Timed drills: 40 Reading questions in 60 min
20	Light practice only: one section of each skill	Read Chapter 23 in full; prepare documents
21	Rest. Review vocabulary lists only	Sleep early; re-read the exam-day checklist

3.4 How to use practice material properly

Most candidates do practice tests wrong: they do the test, look at the score, feel bad, and move on. The score is the least useful thing a practice test produces. Use this four-step method instead.

- 1 Do it timed. Strictly. A relaxed practice test measures nothing.
- 2 Mark it, but do not look at the key yet. For every wrong answer, write down why you think you got it wrong.
- 3 Then read the key. Classify each error: didn't know the word, misread the question, ran out of time, fell for a distractor, spelling/grammar slip.
- 4 Fix the class, not the item. If you lost marks to spelling, your next session is a spelling drill, not another test.

The error taxonomy

Error class	Typical symptom	Fix
Vocabulary gap	"I didn't know that word"	Topic collocation notebook + AWL review
Question misread	Wrong word limit; answered two parts of a two-part question as one	Underline instruction words before reading
Distractor fell for	Wrote the rejected option in Listening	Practise "correction markers": actually, in fact, no wait, sorry
Timing	Last passage rushed or blank	Practise 17/20/23-minute split; abandon questions quickly
Spelling/grammar	Right word, wrong form	Dictation drills; check singular/plural and word class
Paraphrase miss	"The answer wasn't in the text"	Build keyword → synonym tables for every passage

3.5 Weekly review ritual (20 minutes, every Sunday)

- 1 Re-read the error log. Which class appears most often?
- 2 Choose one class as next week's priority.
- 3 Measure something numerical: timed Reading passage accuracy, Listening raw score, or words-per-minute writing speed.
- 4 Update your study plan — the plan exists to be edited.
- 5 Re-record one Speaking Part 2 answer and compare it to a recording from two weeks ago. Progress in speaking is often audible before it is measurable.

3.6 When you are studying without a teacher

- Speak to yourself out loud, daily. Narrate your commute, describe your kitchen, argue both sides of a news headline. Fluency is muscle memory.
- Record and compare. Use the model answers in Chapters 15 and 18–20 as benchmarks, but never memorise them for the exam.
- Get one external check. Even one writing edit from a teacher or a proficient friend per week is worth many hours of self-correction.
- Use a timer for everything. The exam is a performance under time pressure; train the pressure.

Consistency beats intensity. Thirty focused minutes every day for eight weeks outperforms five-hour weekend cramming. The skills being tested — comprehension speed, lexical retrieval, spoken fluency — are built by repetition over time, not by long single sessions.

3.7 What to do in the last 48 hours

- 48 hours out: no new material. Review your error log, your vocabulary notebook and the checklists in Chapter 23.
- 24 hours out: one light practice task per skill, maximum 90 minutes total. Confirm your identification documents and the test centre address.

- Evening before: eat normally, sleep at your usual time, do not attempt an all-night review.
- Morning of the test: breakfast, water, arrive 45 minutes early, and speak English aloud on the way — even to yourself. Your mouth needs a warm-up before the Speaking test, and the Listening test benefits from an English-ready ear.

Next: the language foundations that make every strategy easier to execute.

CHAPTER 4

Core Grammar for Band 7+

You do not need to know all of English grammar to score Band 7. You need full control of a limited set of structures and the willingness to use them in every paragraph. This chapter covers exactly that set, in the order of how many marks each structure typically earns.

Every section follows the same pattern: what it is → why examiners reward it → how to use it → common errors → drill.

4.1 The tense system, and which tenses IELTS actually wants

IELTS tasks are written in specific time frames, and using the wrong tense is the most common grammatical error in Task 1 and Task 2 alike.

Time frame	Task signal	Tense to use	Example
Past, finished	Task 1 chart with years up to 2010	Past simple	Sales rose steadily between 2000 and 2010.
Past to present	Chart ending at "now"	Present perfect	Sales have risen steadily since 2000.
Present habit / general truth	Task 2 argument	Present simple	Many governments invest too little in public transport.
Prediction, projection	Chart with future years; Task 2 solutions	will / is expected to / is projected to	Numbers are expected to double by 2035.
Hypothetical	Task 2 recommendations	Second conditional	If cities invested more in cycling, congestion would fall.

Common errors and repairs

- Since 2010, sales increased. → □ Since 2010, sales have increased. (Since + present perfect.)
- The graph shows that the number of cars are rising. → □ ...the number of cars is rising. (Subject is the number, singular.)
- If the government will build more roads, traffic will increase. → □ If the government builds more roads, traffic will increase. (No will in the if-clause.)

4.2 Articles: the small words that shout "beginner"

Errors with a / an / the / zero article are the most visible sign of an untrained writer. Learn the core rules and then check every noun phrase.

Rule	Use	Example
First mention, countable singular	a / an	The government introduced a new tax.

Rule	Use	Example
Second mention	the	...but the tax was unpopular.
Unique or specific	the	the environment, the internet, the majority
General plural or uncountable	zero article	Education is a right. / Pollution damages health.
Abstract nouns in general statements	zero article	Technology has changed work.
Singular countable noun in a general statement	the + singular	The bicycle is a clean form of transport.

The single most reliable rule for Task 2: when you make a general claim about a plural or uncountable noun, use no article — Governments should fund public transport. When you refer back or specify, use the — The public transport system in my city is inadequate.

4.3 Complex sentences: the four structures that earn Band 7

(1) Relative clauses

Used to add information without a new sentence. This is the single most useful Band 7 structure in both Writing and Speaking.

- Defining (no commas): Cities that invest in cycling infrastructure see fewer accidents.
- Non-defining (with commas): Cycling, which is cheap and healthy, is popular in Copenhagen.
- With whose/where/when: Students whose families cannot afford tuition often work part-time.

Common error: □ The people who they live in cities... → □ The people who live in cities... (no double subject).

(2) Conditionals

Type	Form	Use	Example
Zero	If + present, present	General truth	If people exercise, they sleep better.
First	If + present, will	Real future	If governments ban cars, air quality will improve.
Second	If + past, would	Hypothetical present	If more people cycled, cities would be quieter.
Third	If + had + past participle, would have	Hypothetical past	If the city had built the metro earlier, traffic would have fallen sooner.
Mixed	Second + perfect	Past cause, present result	If the government had invested in rail, congestion would be lower today.

Second conditionals are the highest-value structure for Task 2 recommendation sentences.

(3) Concession (showing the other side)

- Although / even though / though + clause: Although remote work saves commuting time, it can blur the boundary between job and home.
- Despite / in spite of + noun or -ing: Despite its higher cost, rail is often the better investment.
- While + clause: While some argue that exams motivate students, others see them as unfair.

A sentence beginning Although... earns credit twice: for the complex structure and for showing the examiner you can see both sides of an argument.

(4) Passive voice

Essential in Task 1 processes, and useful in Task 2 when the actor is unimportant.

- Process: The beans are dried, then roasted, and finally ground.
- Formal claim: It is widely believed that... / Mistakes were made by the previous administration.

Do not over-use the passive in Task 2; examiners value an active, committed voice. Use it for processes, headline claims and impersonal statements.

4.4 Modals: the vocabulary of caution

Academic writing hedges claims. Modals are how you do it, and they show grammatical range.

Modal	Strength	Example
will	certainty	Automation will replace many routine jobs.
should / ought to	recommendation	Governments should tax carbon emissions.
could / may / might	possibility	Remote work could reduce urban congestion.
must	obligation, inference	Cities must act quickly to avoid gridlock.
would	hypothetical	A higher tax would discourage short flights.

4.5 Cohesion: linking without sounding mechanical

Function	Weak/overused	Stronger alternatives
Addition	also, furthermore	in addition, moreover, what is more, not only ... but also
Contrast	but	however, whereas, while, on the other hand, by contrast, nevertheless

Function	Weak/overused	Stronger alternatives
Cause	because	since, as, owing to, due to, as a result of
Effect	so	therefore, consequently, as a result, thus, hence
Example	for example	for instance, such as, a case in point, to illustrate
Sequence	firstly, secondly	to begin with, next, subsequently, finally
Conclusion	in conclusion	to sum up, overall, in the final analysis

Three-technique linking. Coherence is not only about connectors. It is also:

- 1 Pronoun reference: ...the policy. This measure ... / Such a scheme ...
- 2 Lexical chains: repeat the idea with different words — traffic → congestion → gridlock.
- 3 Paragraph topic sentences that echo the previous paragraph's conclusion.

4.6 Punctuation examiners notice

Mark	Rule	Example
Comma	Non-defining clause; after a fronted adverbial; items in a list	However, costs rose.
Semicolon	Joins two independent clauses closely related	Costs rose; demand fell.
Colon	Introduces a list or explanation	Three factors matter: cost, speed and safety.
Apostrophe	Possession, contractions (avoid contractions in formal writing)	the government's policy

The comma splice — the most common punctuation error in IELTS essays: □ Costs rose, demand fell. → □ Costs rose; demand fell. or Costs rose, and demand fell.

4.7 Nominalisation: the academic register

Turning verbs into nouns makes writing denser and more academic. It is a hallmark of Band 7+ writing.

Verb phrase	Nominalised
Many people moved to cities.	The migration of populations to cities...
Governments spend more on roads.	Increased government expenditure on roads...
Factories pollute rivers.	Industrial pollution of rivers...

Used in moderation, nominalisation lets you pack information into a single subject, which is exactly what Task 1 requires.

4.8 The grammar of Task 1: describing data precisely

Function	Structures
Rise	increase, rise, grow, climb, go up, surge, soar (+ sharply, steadily, gradually, dramatically)
Fall	decrease, decline, drop, fall, plummet, dip
No change	remain stable, level off, plateau, stay constant
Peak / trough	peak at, reach a high of, hit the lowest point of
Comparison	twice as much as, three times higher than, the highest proportion of
Proportion	account for, make up, constitute, represent + percentage

Model sentence patterns:

- The proportion of households with internet access rose steadily from 40% to 78% between 2005 and 2015.
- Sales of electric cars peaked at 2.1 million units in 2019 before falling slightly.
- By 2020, renewable sources accounted for a third of total generation, compared with less than 10% in 2000.

4.9 Six drills to build grammatical range

- 1 Sentence upgrade. Write five simple sentences about your city. Rewrite each with a relative clause, then with a conditional, then with a concession.
- 2 Tense audit. Take any Task 1 model. Circle every verb. Check the time frame is consistent.
- 3 Article hunt. Read one paragraph of a newspaper article and underline every article. Explain each one.
- 4 Nominalisation ladder. Write Verbs → Nouns → Sentence for five verbs (increase, pollute, migrate, consume, regulate).
- 5 Passive process. Describe making tea or charging a phone in eight steps, all in the passive.
- 6 Hedging ladder. Take the claim Cities should ban cars and rewrite it at four levels of certainty using will, should, could, might.

Accuracy beats ambition. A candidate who writes only simple and moderately complex sentences with almost no errors will usually outscore one who attempts third conditionals and produces three errors per paragraph. Add complexity only when your control is reliable.

The next chapter supplies the vocabulary that turns this grammar into Band 7 answers.

CHAPTER 5

Academic Vocabulary and the Paraphrase Engine

Band 7 vocabulary is not "difficult" vocabulary. It is precise, natural and topic-appropriate, used with correct collocation and spelling. This chapter gives you a system for building that vocabulary and, more importantly, for using it under exam pressure.

5.1 The paraphrase engine

Every IELTS question in Reading and Listening is a paraphrase of the passage or recording. Every IELTS Writing task requires you to paraphrase the question in your introduction. Every Speaking answer is stronger when you rephrase the examiner's words. Paraphrase is therefore not a technique — it is the technique.

Five ways to paraphrase anything:

Technique	Original	Paraphrase
Synonym	important	significant, crucial, vital
Word class change	The cost increased.	There was an increase in cost.
Opposite + negative	cheap	not expensive
General → specific	vehicles	cars, vans and lorries
Active ↔ passive	The council banned cars.	Cars were banned by the council.

Drill: the three-synonym rule

For each word below, produce two synonyms and one opposite, then write a full sentence with one of them.

increase · decrease · important · difficult · benefit · problem · allow · prevent · cause · effective

The ten paraphrase pairs IELTS reuses constantly

Question word	What the passage will say
a rise	an increase, growth, an upward trend, climbing numbers
a fall	a decline, a drop, a decrease, dwindling numbers
expensive	costly, pricey, beyond the reach of most people
necessary	essential, indispensable, a prerequisite
harmful	damaging, detrimental, damaging to health
advantage	benefit, merits, a positive aspect, upside
disadvantage	drawback, shortcoming, downside, demerit
solve	tackle, address, remedy, resolve

Question word	What the passage will say
cause	lead to, result in, give rise to, bring about
most people	the majority, a large proportion, the bulk of the population

5.2 Collocation: the difference between correct and natural

A collocation is a pair of words that native speakers habitually place together. Errors here are lexical errors even when the grammar is perfect.

Instead of...	Write...
do a decision	make a decision
strong rain	heavy rain
big problem	serious problem / major issue
say an opinion	express an opinion
do a mistake	make a mistake
get a benefit	gain a benefit / reap the benefits
rise children	raise children
solve a problem completely	fully address a problem / eradicate a problem

High-frequency academic collocations

conduct research · play a role · have an impact on · take measures · pose a threat · meet demand · raise concerns · draw a distinction · reach a conclusion · bear the cost · make a contribution · undergo a transformation · show a tendency · make provision for

5.3 The Academic Word List: the 60 you will actually use

The Academic Word List (AWL) contains 570 word families. These sixty appear again and again in IELTS essays, reports and reading passages.

Word family	Meaning note	Example
analyse (analysis, analytical)	break down into parts	analysing the data
approach	method; to move towards	a practical approach
assess (assessment)	judge value or quality	assess the impact
assume (assumption)	take as true without proof	let us assume that...
benefit (beneficial)	advantage	the benefits outweigh...
concept	idea	a broad concept
conclude (conclusion)	decide after reasoning	in conclusion
consequence	result	as a consequence
considerable	large	a considerable amount
constitute	make up	constitutes 40% of
context	surrounding circumstances	in the context of

Word family	Meaning note	Example
contribute (contribution)	give towards	contribute to pollution
convince	persuade	a convincing argument
crucial	vital	crucial to success
decline	decrease	a decline in sales
demonstrate	show	demonstrate the need for
derive	get from	derived from fossil fuels
distribute (distribution)	spread out	an uneven distribution
economy (economic, economical)	financial system	economic growth
environment (environmental)	surroundings	environmental damage
establish	set up; prove	establish a framework
estimate	approximate calculation	a rough estimate
evident	obvious	it is evident that
factor	contributing element	a key factor
finance (financial)	money matters	financial burden
function	purpose, role	the function of schools
identify	recognise	identify the causes
impact	effect	a lasting impact
indicate	show	the figures indicate
individual	person; single	individual freedom
interpret (interpretation)	explain meaning	interpret the data
involve	include as a part	involves significant cost
issue	topic, problem	a contentious issue
justify	give reasons for	justify the expense
maintain	keep; assert	maintain standards
method	way of doing	an efficient method
occur	happen	changes occur gradually
perceive (perception)	see, regard	perceived as unfair
policy (policies)	official plan	government policy
principle	rule, belief	on principle
proceed	go on	proceed with the plan
process	series of steps	a slow process
require (requirement)	need	require investment
research	systematic study	conduct research
respond (response)	answer, react	respond to demand
significant	important; statistically large	a significant rise
similar (similarity)	alike	broadly similar
source	origin	a reliable source
specific	particular	a specific example

Word family	Meaning note	Example
structure	arrangement	social structure
sufficient	enough	sufficient evidence
theory (theoretical)	explanation	in theory
therefore	for that reason	therefore, policy makers
vary (variation, variety)	differ	varies widely
volume	amount, quantity	the volume of traffic
achieve (achievement)	reach a goal	achieve targets
adapt (adaptation)	adjust	adapt to change
alternative	other option	alternative energy

5.4 Topic vocabulary for the ten most common Task 2 themes

Learn these as collocation sets, not word lists. Each set gives you a claim, a cause, an effect and a solution — that is, everything a body paragraph needs.

1. Education

compulsory education · tuition fees · curriculum reform · classroom discipline · vocational training · academic performance · lifelong learning · critical thinking skills

Vocational training equips students with practical skills, whereas a purely academic curriculum may leave them unprepared for the job market.

2. Environment

carbon emissions · fossil fuels · renewable energy · climate change · sustainable development · deforestation · plastic waste · biodiversity loss · carbon footprint

Switching from fossil fuels to renewable energy would substantially reduce carbon emissions, although the initial infrastructure cost is high.

3. Technology

automation · artificial intelligence · digital divide · data privacy · screen time · remote working · technological advancement · online learning platforms

Automation has displaced routine manual jobs, and the workers most affected are precisely those with the least access to retraining.

4. Health

public healthcare · preventive medicine · sedentary lifestyle · mental well-being · healthcare provision · obesity rates · life expectancy · medical breakthroughs

Preventive medicine is far cheaper than treating chronic illness, which is why investment in public health campaigns pays for itself.

5. Work and employment

job satisfaction · work-life balance · minimum wage · unemployment rate · career progression · job security · unpaid overtime · skills shortage

A generous minimum wage raises income for the lowest paid, but may reduce entry-level vacancies if employers cut costs.

6. Cities and transport

urban congestion · public transport network · cycling infrastructure · urban sprawl · affordable housing · green spaces · commuting time · traffic pollution

Investing in cycling infrastructure reduces congestion, improves air quality and lowers the public health bill simultaneously.

7. Society and family

ageing population · social mobility · income inequality · social cohesion · childcare provision · family structure · community engagement · welfare state

An ageing population places pressure on pension systems unless governments raise the retirement age or increase contributions.

8. Crime and law

deterrent effect · rehabilitation programmes · reoffending rates · law enforcement · juvenile crime · prison overcrowding · community service · crime prevention

Rehabilitation programmes reduce reoffending more effectively than longer sentences, because they address the causes of criminal behaviour.

9. Media and communication

mass media · social media platforms · freedom of the press · misinformation · advertising revenue · public opinion · censorship · digital literacy

Social media platforms spread information at unprecedented speed, but they also accelerate the circulation of misinformation.

10. Globalisation and culture

multinational corporations · cultural identity · global trade · outsourcing · cultural homogenisation · international cooperation · economic interdependence · heritage preservation

Globalisation has lowered prices and widened consumer choice, yet it has also eroded local cultural traditions.

5.5 Register: formal writing has no room for slang

Informal (avoid)	Formal (use)
a lot of	a great deal of, numerous, considerable
kids	children, young people
get better	improve, recover, progress
stuff	materials, items, matters
so (as intensifier)	therefore, consequently
nowadays (overused)	at present, currently, in recent decades
I think	It is arguable that, In my view
and so on	etc. (sparingly) or name the items

5.6 Spelling: the silent band-killer

In Listening and Reading, a correctly identified answer spelled wrongly is wrong. Build a personal spelling list from these high-frequency traps.

Commonly misspelled	Correct
accomodation	accommodation (two c's, two m's)
enviroment	environment
goverment	government
definitely	definitely
recieve	receive
seperate	separate
succesful	successful
wheather	whether / weather
untill	until
begining	beginning
neccessary	necessary
occassion	occasion

British vs American spelling. IELTS accepts both, but be consistent. colour/color, centre/center, organisation/organization, programme/program, defence/defense.

In Listening, if you hear a word being spelled out — "That's B-R-O-U-G-H, brought" — the spelled letters are the answer, even if you do not recognise the word. Copy exactly what is spelled, in capitals if you prefer, and check for double letters.

5.7 Building a vocabulary notebook that works

Use four columns, not two:

Word	Collocations	My sentence (topic)	Paraphrases
discourage	discourage sb from doing; a discouraging result	Higher taxes may discourage people from flying. (transport)	deter, put off, dissuade

Word	Collocations	My sentence (topic)	Paraphrases
provision	the provision of healthcare; make provision for	The provision of free childcare would help working parents. (society)	supply, supply of, facilities

Rules for the notebook:

- 1 Ten items a day, every day. Not fifty once a week.
- 2 Always record the word inside a sentence about a real IELTS topic.
- 3 Review at 1 day, 1 week, 1 month (the spacing effect).
- 4 Speak the sentences aloud — vocabulary you cannot pronounce is vocabulary you cannot use in Speaking.

5.8 Twelve phrases that immediately raise the register of an essay

- 1 It is widely acknowledged that...
- 2 There is a growing consensus that...
- 3 The evidence suggests that...
- 4 This tendency is particularly marked in...
- 5 A further consideration is...
- 6 The most compelling argument for ... is...
- 7 While this view has some merit, it overlooks...
- 8 The long-term consequences are likely to be...
- 9 A more pragmatic approach would be to...
- 10 This is not to suggest that...; rather, ...
- 11 On balance, the benefits appear to outweigh the drawbacks.
- 12 Ultimately, the decision rests with policy makers, but...

Use no more than three or four per essay. Their power comes from scarcity.

With grammar and lexis in place, we turn to the first tested skill: Listening.

CHAPTER 6

Listening: Test Format and Every Question Type

Listening is the component where technique pays fastest. The recording is heard once, the accents vary, and the traps are engineered. But the question types repeat, section by section, with almost mechanical regularity — and each one has a procedure.

6.1 The four sections and what each one demands

Section	Format	Skills needed	Most common tasks
1	Transaction between two speakers	Numbers, names, spelling, dates, prices	Form/note completion
2	Monologue for a general audience	Directional language, descriptions, categorising	Map/plan labelling, MCQ, matching
3	Academic discussion (2–4 speakers)	Following an argument, identifying agreement, options	MCQ, matching, note completion
4	Academic lecture	Extended note-taking, topic signposting	Note/sentence completion, MCQ

The paper's skeleton

- Before each section you get time to read the questions: 30 seconds at the start of Sections 2, 3 and 4; about 20 seconds for Section 1's first half and 30 seconds for its second half.
- Questions 1–10 = Section 1, 11–20 = Section 2, 21–30 = Section 3, 31–40 = Section 4. Knowing this means you always know how many answers remain.
- Both halves of a section are usually separated by a signpost sentence ("Now let's move on to..."). If you lose your place, wait for the signpost and rejoin.

6.2 Instruction words: read them or lose the mark

Instruction	Means	Example answer
ONE WORD AND/OR A NUMBER	Maximum one word (a hyphenated word counts as one)	library or 1972 or library, 1972 is wrong
NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS	One or two words, no numbers	white bread
NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS AND/OR A NUMBER	Up to two words plus a number	20 June, third floor
NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS	Up to three words	a guided tour
A NUMBER	Digits or a word for a number	40 or forty
Write the correct letter A–C	One letter only	B

Answers over the word limit score zero, however correct the content. Underline the limit before the audio starts, and check it again during the 30-second review at the end of each section.

6.3 Type 1: Form, note and table completion

The workhorse of Sections 1, 3 and 4. You fill gaps in a form, a set of notes or a table.

The procedure

- 1 Read the surrounding words and predict the type of answer: name, number, date, price, place, activity, adjective.
- 2 Predict the grammar: singular or plural? A gap after "two" needs a plural. A gap after "a" needs a singular.
- 3 Mark the gap with a symbol: N (number), D (date), P (place), A (activity), Adj.
- 4 While listening, write what you hear immediately — even a partial word — in the gap. Never wait to be sure.
- 5 At the 30-second check, tidy spelling and check the word limit.

Worked micro-example

Windsurfing Club Membership Name: (1) Palmer Address: (2) Road
 Started windsurfing at age: (3) Cost of annual membership: £(4)
 Membership includes free use of (5) on weekdays

Predictions: (1) a first name, spelled out — write the letters as you hear them; (2) a street name — capitalise; (3) a number — listen for thirteen vs thirty; (4) a number with pounds — likely ends in ty or has tens; (5) a thing, probably singular, possibly equipment (uncountable).

Traps

- Correction markers. "We meet on Wednesdays — sorry, that's Thursdays." The answer is the second one.
- Spelling aloud. "My surname is Ferris: F-E-R-R-I-S." Count the letters as they are spoken.
- Distractor from the other speaker. "Is that fifteen pounds?" ... "No, twelve." The answer is twelve.
- Possessive forms. "the manager's office" — if the gap needs a place, the answer may include the possessive.

6.4 Type 2: Multiple choice (single answer)

Common in Sections 2 and 3; either a question with options A/B/C or a stem completed by three options.

The procedure

- 1 Underline the difference between the options, not the whole option. Three long options usually differ at one or two words.
- 2 Expect all three to be mentioned. The recording often discusses option A, dismisses B, and finally agrees with C.

- 3 Listen for the speaker's decision language: "So let's go with...", "That settles it, then.", "I suppose you're right."
- 4 Do not write while listening to the answer — write the letter in the margin immediately, then transfer.

The three classic traps

Name	How it works	Defence
Mention-reject	"I thought it started at nine, but the timetable says half past eight."	Ask: which is the final, agreed fact?
Half-right	An option is true of one speaker but not the other	Track who says what; note agreement/disagreement markers
Paraphrase shift	The correct option rephrases what you hear ("we ran out of time" = "there wasn't enough time")	Build synonym awareness (Chapter 5)

6.5 Type 3: Matching

Match a list of items (options A-F) to a set of questions (1-5), or match speakers to opinions.

The procedure

- 1 Read the options list first and paraphrase each option into two words of your own.
- 2 Note that each option is normally used once only — cross them off as you go.
- 3 Listen for the relationship, not the topic: who said useful, who said boring, who said too long.
- 4 If two answers are close, mark both in the margin and decide at the check.

In matching tasks, the order of the questions follows the recording, but the order of the options does not. Write the option letter next to the question number, never the reverse.

6.6 Type 4: Map and plan labelling

Almost always Section 2. You label places on a map or plan.

The procedure

- 1 Find the entrance, the compass (N/E/S/W) and any "you are here" marker.
- 2 Circle all the location labels already printed — they are anchors the speaker will refer to.
- 3 Prepare direction vocabulary before the audio starts (see the table below).
- 4 Trace the route with your pencil as you listen; do not wait for the named label.
- 5 Watch for a change of direction: "...and then, doubling back...".

Essential direction language

Phrase	Meaning
opposite / facing	directly across from

Phrase	Meaning
next to / alongside	beside
at the end of	the last building on a road
just past	immediately after
beyond	further away than
on the corner of X and Y	at the intersection
to the left of the entrance	as you face inwards
diagonally opposite	across and to one side
in the middle of	central
adjacent to	directly beside

6.7 Type 5: Sentence completion

Complete a sentence with words from the recording so that it is grammatically correct.

- The completed sentence must agree grammatically with the words around the gap:
The museum is closed on ... needs Mondays, not Monday, if the recording says Mondays.
- Read the completed sentence in your head at the check — your ear will often catch a grammar mismatch.

6.8 Type 6: Short answer questions

Answer a direct question in the given number of words.

- The answer is a noun phrase, never a full sentence.
- The question word dictates the answer type: Where → a place; How much → a price or quantity; Who → a person or role.

6.9 The 40-question checklist

Before each section, run this mental checklist in the reading time:

- 1 How many answers does this section contain, and how many words am I allowed?
- 2 What type are the questions, and where is the half-way signpost?
- 3 Predict the answer type for every gap (person, number, date, place, activity, adjective).
- 4 Underline the keywords that will be repeated in the recording (usually the nouns, which are rarely paraphrased as heavily as verbs).
- 5 Who is speaking and in what situation? Section 3 discussions often have a tutor and two students — know who is who.

6.10 What to write, and where

- Write on the question paper first, always. Never try to write directly on the answer sheet during the recording.
- Use capitals for answers to avoid ambiguous handwriting.

- If you miss an answer, write a guess and move on immediately. One lost question costs one mark; losing your place costs three.
- During the 10-minute transfer, check: spelling, plurals, word limits, and whether each answer fits its sentence. This is where many candidates gain two or three marks — and where the careless lose them.

The transfer time is not a formality. Re-read every sentence with your answer inserted. If the sentence now reads badly, the answer is probably wrong.

The next chapter drills the underlying skills: numbers, spelling, distractors and note-taking speed.

CHAPTER 7

Listening: The Nine Micro-Skills That Decide Your Score

Most candidates lose Listening marks not because they cannot understand English, but because a handful of micro-skills failed under pressure. This chapter isolates each one and provides a drill.

7.1 Skill 1 — Predicting from context

Prediction converts listening from a memory test into a confirmation test. Before the audio begins, you should already know the shape of every answer.

Cue in the question	Predict
Name:	a first name or surname, often spelled out
Date:	a day, month, ordinal number, or the 3rd of June
Cost / price / fee:	a number with a currency; watch teen vs ty
Time:	a clock time, with quarter past, half past, ten to
Level / type / kind of:	an adjective or a classification, often from a printed list
Equipment / items:	a plural noun
Location:	a place or a directional phrase
Reason:	a clause of cause (because...)

Drill. Take any listening transcript. Before reading it, cover the answers to a completion task and write your predictions for each gap. Compare. Ninety per cent of the time, type-prediction alone narrows the search enough to hear the answer.

7.2 Skill 2 — Numbers, prices and dates

The most reliably lost marks in Section 1.

Teens and tens

The difference is stress, not vowel length: thirteen is stressed on the second syllable; thirty on the first. Also fifteen vs fifty, eighteen vs eighty.

Drill: play a recording and write fifteen/fifty, thirteen/thirty, seventeen/seventy, eighteen/eighty, nineteen/ninety as fast as you hear them. Do this ten times over two weeks.

Prices and money

- £4.50 = four pounds fifty or four fifty.
- \$12.99 = twelve ninety-nine.
- a fiver = £5, a tenner = £10 (informal, Section 1 conversations).
- It's on offer at twenty per cent off → the final price, not the discount, is usually the answer.

Dates

- Ordinal numbers: the second of March, March the second, or March second (American).
- 3/5 is ambiguous — the recording always speaks it, so write the words you hear.
- Date formats: 23 March or March 23, but never 23rd March 2020 if the limit is two words.

Times

eight forty-five · quarter to nine · half past eight · 08:45 — all the same. Write digits to save time, but only if the instruction allows a number.

Telephone numbers and reference codes

Numbers are given in groups. "Oh one two seven, double four, nine zero." Write as you hear, and remember double / triple.

7.3 Skill 3 — Catching spelled words

Section 1 loves "Can I take your name?" — "It's ..., that's ...-...-...-...".

Drill. Play a podcast or the transcript of any Section 1 and pause after each spelled item; write it immediately without pausing to think about the whole word. Then check letter by letter.

Watch for: double letters (Higgins: H-I-G-G-I-N-S), silent letters (Wright), and letters that sound similar in English — B/V, G/J, M/N, P/B, S/F, I/Y, E/A — the source of the classic confusion of B and V, G and J.

Write names in BLOCK CAPITALS. It eliminates the I/Y and U/V ambiguity that examiners cannot resolve in your handwriting.

7.4 Skill 4 — Hearing distractors and corrections

Distractors are deliberate. Learn the vocabulary of correction:

Marker	Effect
actually · in fact · no wait · sorry	contradicts what came before
I thought ... but	signals that the earlier statement was mistaken
not X, but Y / rather than	explicitly rejects X
on second thoughts	changes a decision
that's right / exactly	confirms the previous item as the answer
hmm, I'm not sure about that	speaker doubts the item — usually not the answer

Rule of thumb: the last version of a fact in a Section 1 or 2 gap-fill is usually the answer; the agreed version in a Section 3 discussion is the answer.

7.5 Skill 5 — Following signposts in a monologue

Section 4 lectures are structured, and the signposts tell you when to move to the next question.

Function	Phrases
Introducing the topic	Today I'm going to talk about... / This evening I want to look at...
Beginning a new part	Let's start with... / To begin with... / First of all...
Moving on	Moving on to... / Let's turn now to... / Now, the next point...
Adding detail	What's more... / Not only that, but... / In addition...
Giving an example	For instance... / Take the case of... / A good example is...
Emphasising	The key point here is... / What matters most is... / Above all...
Contrasting	However... / On the other hand... / That said...
Concluding	To sum up... / So, in conclusion... / What this all means is...
Digressing and returning	Anyway, back to... / As I was saying...

Drill. Listen to a ten-minute lecture (a TED-style talk or university podcast) and write only the signposts, in order. You will find you can reconstruct the lecture's skeleton from signposts alone — which is exactly what you need to keep your place while answering questions.

7.6 Skill 6 — Note-taking at speed

In Section 4 you must listen, understand and write simultaneously. Three techniques make this possible:

- 1 Abbreviate ruthlessly. Drop vowels, use standard short forms: govt, info, diff, approx, →, +, w/, b/c, yr, no.
- 2 Write the answer only. You do not need the surrounding notes; the question paper already provides them. Write the answer word the moment you hear it, then return to listening.
- 3 Leave a marker for a missed answer. Write ? and move on. Never let a missed item hold you hostage for the following two.

7.7 Skill 7 — Grammatical fit

After the audio stops, your answer must make the sentence grammatical:

- Singular/plural agreement — The gardens are open to visitors in ... months needs a plural.
- Countability — information is uncountable: never informations.
- Word class — a gap after a + adjective needs a noun (a historic building).
- Unnecessary articles — if the gap is preceded by the, do not write the again.

7.8 Skill 8 — Accent flexibility

IELTS uses British, Australian, New Zealand and North American accents. If one accent is hard for you, that accent is your training target.

Accent	Features that surprise learners
British (RP and regional)	non-rhotic r (car → cah); bath vowel; t often glottal (better → be'er)
Australian	rising intonation on statements; day → die-ish; i in fish raised
New Zealand	i → uh (fish and chips sounds like fush and chups)
North American	flapped t (better → bedder); rhotic r; can't → /kænt/

Drill. For two weeks, listen to one podcast per day from the accent you find hardest (ABC News for Australian, RNZ for New Zealand, BBC Radio 4 for British, NPR for North American). Do not use transcripts; write down five facts you heard.

7.9 Skill 9 — Managing a missed question

Losing one answer is trivial. Losing your place is catastrophic. The recovery procedure:

- 1 Do not stop. Write a guess or a dash in the gap.
- 2 Find the next anchor. Look ahead for the next printed keyword and listen for it.
- 3 Use the signpost. If you are still lost, wait for the section's halfway marker or the "moving on" phrase.
- 4 Never panic-write. A frantic guess in the wrong gap creates two errors, not one.

7.10 A four-week Listening improvement programme

Week	Daily 20-minute task	Weekly test
1	Numbers, dates, prices, spelled names dictates	Section 1 + Section 2
2	Map labelling and direction language drills	Section 2 + Section 3
3	Lecture note-taking with abbreviations; signposts	Section 3 + Section 4
4	Full sections, once only, under exam conditions	Full 40-question paper

The golden rule of Listening practice: never replay the audio to "get" an answer. The exam gives you one chance; train the one-chance skill. Review the transcript after checking, never during.

7.11 Ten listening mistakes that cost bands

- 1 Writing more words than the limit allows.
- 2 Ignoring singular/plural.
- 3 Writing the twice.
- 4 Replaying audio when practising.
- 5 Reading the options only after the audio starts.

- 6 Looking up words during the recording (you will miss the next two answers).
- 7 Writing a full sentence in a gap-fill.
- 8 Missing a number because -teen and -ty were not distinguished.
- 9 Leaving blanks instead of guessing — there is no penalty for a wrong answer, so an empty gap is a guaranteed loss.
- 10 Not using the 10-minute transfer to check spelling.

Teachers who mark IELTS papers consistently report the same pattern: the difference between a 6.5 and a 7.5 Listening score is rarely comprehension. It is spelling, plurals and word limits — the three items on your transfer-time checklist.

CHAPTER 8

Listening Practice Test 1

Instructions. This is a complete 40-question Listening test in the official format. The recording is played once only, in four sections, with the standard pauses. Answers must respect the word limits.

How to use this test for self-study. The full recording script appears at the end of the chapter. Record it with a partner (or read it aloud yourself, pausing for the printed gaps), then take the test under exam conditions using only the question paper. Do not read the script until you have marked your answers. Where a partner is unavailable, use a text-to-speech reader at normal speed on the script.

SECTION 1 — Questions 1-10

Questions 1-6. Complete the form below. Write ONE WORD AND/OR A NUMBER for each answer.

GREENRIDGE SPORTS CENTRE — MEMBERSHIP ENQUIRY Applicant details
 Name: Maria (1) Telephone: (2) Address: 27 (3)
 Street, Ashford Membership Type requested: (4)
 membership Preferred starting month: (5) Annual fee: £(6)

Questions 7-10. Complete the notes below. Write NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS for each answer.

FACILITIES AND BOOKING - The pool is closed for cleaning on (7) mornings. - Members may book courts up to (8) days in advance. - A free (9) is offered to every new member. - Lockers require a deposit of fifty pence and a £1 coin is needed for the (10)

SECTION 2 — Questions 11-20

Questions 11-15. Choose the correct letter, A, B or C.

11 Riverside Park was originally

- A a private garden.
- B a commercial dock.
- C a rubbish tip.

12 The park's visitor centre is notable for

- A its solar roof.
- B its recycled timber frame.
- C its underground storage.

13 The guided walk lasts

- A forty minutes.
- B one hour.
- C ninety minutes.

14 The children's play area is currently closed because

- A of storm damage.
- B it is being extended.
- C of building work nearby.

15 According to the speaker, the best time to see birds is

- A early morning.
- B late afternoon.
- C after rain.

Questions 16–20. Label the map below. Write the correct letter, A–H, next to Questions 16–20.

```

` ` N ^ | [A] woods | [B] lake ----- [C] cafe |
ENTRANCE | [D] car park ----- [E] rose garden |
[F] playground ----- [G] boathouse | [H] bird
hide ` `

```

16 Visitor centre 17 Cycle hire 18 Picnic area 19 Small train
..... 20 Boat landing

SECTION 3 — Questions 21–30

Questions 21–26. Choose the correct letter, A, B or C.

21 What do the students agree about their survey topic?

- A It is too narrow.
- B It duplicates earlier work.
- C It needs a different focus.

22 The tutor is concerned that the sample

- A is too small.
- B is unrepresentative.
- C was collected too slowly.

23 The students decide to collect extra data by

- A interviewing commuters.
- B posting an online form.
- C counting vehicles.

24 What does the tutor say about the literature review?

- A It should discuss methodology.
- B It can be shortened.
- C It lacks recent sources.

25 The main problem with the students' questionnaire was

- A ambiguous wording.
- B too many questions.
- C a poor response rate.

26 By the end of the week, the students must

- A finalise their questions.
- B submit a progress report.
- C book laboratory time.

Questions 27–30. Who will do each task? Write the correct letter, A, B or C, next to Questions 27–30.

- A Dan
- B Priya
- C both Dan and Priya

27 contacting the transport authority 28 designing the charts 29 writing the introduction 30 preparing the presentation slides

SECTION 4 — Questions 31–40

Questions 31–40. Complete the notes below. Write NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS for each answer.

THE HISTORY OF PAPER MONEY Early exchange systems - Before coins, goods such as (31) were used as payment. - Coins solved the problem of (32) in trade. China - The first paper notes appeared in the (33) century. - Merchants accepted paper receipts issued by the (34) rather than carrying metal. - Early notes were printed with warnings and the (35) of the issuing official. Europe - Goldsmiths in (36) began issuing receipts for gold deposits. - The system worked only while people trusted the (37) - Governments eventually took control and made note-issuing (38) Modern developments - Polymer notes are harder to (39) - The main advantage for central banks is lower (40)

Recording Script (do not read before taking the test)

Section 1

Receptionist: Good morning, Greenridge Sports Centre. How can I help? Caller: Hello, I'd like to ask about membership, please. My name's Maria Kovacs. Receptionist: Could you spell your surname for me? Caller: Yes, it's K-O-V-A-C-S. Receptionist: Thank you. And a contact number? Caller: It's oh seven double seven, four nine oh, two three one. Receptionist: And your address? Caller: Twenty-seven Willow Street, Ashford. Receptionist: Willow — that's W-I-L-L-O-W. And which type of membership were you interested in? We do individual, family and student rates. Caller: Student, please. I'm at the college until June. Receptionist: Fine. When would you like it to start? Caller: I thought March, but I'm travelling in February, so let's say April. Receptionist: April it is. The annual fee for students is two hundred and forty pounds. That covers the pool, the gym and all the classes. Caller: That's reasonable. Is there anything I need to know about the pool? Receptionist: Yes — the pool is closed for cleaning on Tuesday mornings until eleven. Other days it's open from six thirty. Caller: Good. And can I book a badminton court? Receptionist: Yes, members can book courts up to fourteen days ahead. And as a new member you get a free induction session with one of our coaches. Caller: Excellent. Do I need anything for the lockers? Receptionist: They take a fifty-pence deposit, and you'll need a pound coin for the trolley in the car park. That's the only awkward thing, I'm afraid.

Section 2

Speaker: Welcome to Riverside Park. I'm going to begin with a little history, because this park is not quite what it seems. Until 1988 this was a commercial dock — barges unloaded coal here for over a century. When the docks moved downstream, the site lay derelict for six years before the council bought it and created the park you see today. The visitor centre, opened in 2019, has already won three awards. It's built almost entirely from timber reclaimed from the old dock buildings; the roof, despite what many visitors assume, is conventional, and the water tanks that supply the toilets are hidden underground.

If you'd like a guided walk, those leave from the centre at ten and two o'clock every day and take exactly one hour — though I should warn you that the volunteers who lead them often run over by twenty or thirty minutes because there is so much to say. The children's play area beside the car park is closed at the moment: not because of the storm in January, and not because of the new housing across the road, but because we're doubling its size and adding a water-play section, which will open in September.

For wildlife, most visitors come at dawn, and that's certainly when the birds are most active. But the rain we had last week showed something interesting — the wet ground brings out insects, and the birds follow. So if you want the widest variety, come after rain rather than in the late afternoon, which is honestly the quietest time.

Now, a word about the map. The main entrance is in the middle of the southern boundary. Immediately inside it, to the left as you come in, is the visitor centre. Opposite the visitor centre, on the far side of the entrance path, is the car park. The old coal store has been converted into a café, which is directly behind the visitor centre, set back towards the water. Cycle hire is in the small building beside the car park — that's the one with the green bikes outside. If you're bringing a picnic, the picnic area is in the rose garden: it's a walled garden on the south side of the café, which keeps the wind off.

Children will want to know that the small train runs from the playground, on the eastern side of the site, right the way round the lake — it takes twelve minutes. And boat landing: the boathouse itself is on the lake's western shore, but you don't board there; the landing stage where the trips start is on the eastern shore, opposite the woods.

Section 3

Tutor: Right, Dan, Priya — let's look at where you are with the transport survey. You wanted to look at cycling in the city centre. Is the topic still the same? Dan: Well, we had a look at what's been done before. There's a study on cycling from 2018, and another one last year. So we thought about looking at cycling and walking together — a broader idea. Tutor: Hmm. I'd be careful about making the topic wider. The problem with a wider topic isn't the work — it's that the analysis becomes shallow. Actually, my concern isn't the topic at all. It's your sample. You've got forty responses, which is small but workable. What bothers me is that every single one came from students on this campus. Priya: So it's not representative. Tutor: Exactly. Now, how will you fix it? Dan: We could stand at the station and ask commuters? Tutor: That would take a long time for forty more responses. What about an online form? You could post it in the city's cycling groups. Priya: Yes — that's quick and it reaches people we'd never meet. Let's do that. Tutor: Good. Next, the literature review. It's thorough, I'll say that. If anything, it's too long — cut it by a third. The sources are all recent, which is good, and there's no need to describe your methodology there. Priya: Understood. Tutor: One more thing. Looking at your questionnaire — the wording is fine, the length is fine, but your response rate was very low, wasn't it? Forty replies from three hundred handouts. Dan: That's right. Tutor: With the online version, you'll need a reminder after three days. And I want something from you by Friday. Not the finished questions, and I don't need the lab booked yet — just a one-page progress report. Priya: Fine. Tutor: Now, who's doing what? The transport authority letter — who's writing that? Dan: I'll do that. Priya hates writing formal letters. Tutor: All right. And the charts? Priya: I'll do those — I've got the software. Tutor: Good. The introduction — that's a job for both of you, I think. Write it together, it's the part that needs the most discussion. Dan: Agreed. Tutor: And the slides for the presentation? Dan: I'll take those as well, since Priya's doing the charts. Tutor: Excellent. That's everything.

Section 4

Speaker: Today I want to trace the history of paper money — a subject that sounds narrow but touches on trust, technology and the whole idea of what value is.

Long before coins, people exchanged goods directly: grain, cattle, salt, and in many coastal societies, shells. Barter of this kind works perfectly well inside a small community, but it has an obvious weakness when strangers meet: you need a coincidence of wants. I have salt; you have cloth; but perhaps you don't need salt. Coins solved that problem by creating a universally accepted unit — a standard of value that anyone would take.

Now, paper. The first true paper notes appeared in China in the eleventh century, during the Song dynasty. They did not appear out of nowhere. For centuries before, merchants had been carrying heavy iron coins, and in some provinces they were allowed to deposit their coins with trusted merchants and receive a paper receipt instead. The receipt could be spent, and people began to prefer it to the metal. Very quickly, the state — not the merchants — took over issuing these notes. Early notes carried stern

warnings of punishment for forgery, and then a design feature that survived for centuries: the signature or seal of the issuing official, printed on the note itself.

Europe reached the same solution by a different route. In seventeenth-century London, goldsmiths held gold in their strongrooms for clients and issued receipts. Those receipts circulated as money. The arrangement depended entirely on trust — not trust in the gold, oddly, but in the goldsmith. If people believed he would honour his receipts, the system worked; the moment they doubted him, they queued to withdraw, and the queue itself destroyed him. Governments learned the lesson. Over the following two centuries, states took control of note issuance and made it a legal monopoly: only the central bank could print money.

Modern notes continue to change. Polymer notes — the plastic ones — are far harder to counterfeit than paper, which is their main security advantage. But for central banks the decisive advantage is economic: polymer notes last two to three times longer, so the cost of replacement is much lower.

End of recording. You now have ten minutes to transfer your answers.

Answer Key — Listening Practice Test 1

Q	Answer	Q	Answer
1	KOVACS	21	C
2	077490231 (accept 0774 90231)	22	B
3	WILLOW	23	B
4	student	24	B
5	April	25	C
6	240 (accept £240, 240 pounds)	26	B
7	Tuesday	27	A
8	14 / fourteen (accept two weeks)	28	B
9	induction (session optional but allowed? no — one word max is not required here; "induction" is correct)	29	C
10	trolley (accept shopping trolley — two words allowed)	30	A
11	B	31	salt (or shells/cattle/grain)
12	B	32	(a) coincidence of wants
13	B	33	eleventh
14	B	34	state
15	C	35	signature (accept seal)
16	C	36	London
17	D	37	goldsmith
18	E	38	(a) legal monopoly
19	F	39	counterfeit
20	H	40	replacement

Why the tempting answers are wrong

Q1-3 (spelling). The caller spells her surname, which is the only reliable way to get KOVACS. The telephone number is spoken as "oh seven double seven..." — candidates who write 0777 490 231 have misread double seven. Willow is spelled out because it is easily confused with Willoughby.

Q5 (dates and corrections). Maria says "I thought March, but I'm travelling in February, so let's say April." March is the distractor; April is the final decision.

Q7 (day, not time). "Closed for cleaning on Tuesday mornings until eleven" — the gap asks for a day, so Tuesday, not eleven.

Q8 (number conversion). "Up to fourteen days ahead" = 14. Writing two weeks is correct in meaning but outside the "one word and/or a number" limit; 14 is safe.

Q14 (three-way distractor). The speaker explicitly rejects the storm ("not because of the storm") and the housing ("and not because of the new housing") before giving the reason: the area is being enlarged. Answer B.

Q15 (contrast marker). "Most visitors come at dawn... but the rain we had last week showed something interesting... come after rain rather than in the late afternoon." The answer is C; dawn is the temptation, late afternoon is explicitly the worst.

Q16-20 (map). The route description runs: entrance in the south; visitor centre to the left inside it → C (beside the café, west of the entrance path). Cycle hire beside the car park → D. Picnic area in the rose garden, south of the café → E. Small train from the playground, east side → F. Boat landing on the eastern shore opposite the woods → H. The boathouse on the western shore (G) is the trap — the speaker says the trips do not start there. The woods (A) and lake (B) are pre-labelled features, never answers.

Q21-22 (tutor's concern). The students propose widening the topic; the tutor warns against it, so A (too narrow) and C (needs a different focus) are wrong — the tutor is happy with the topic. The worry is representativeness: B.

Q23 (decision, not suggestion). Commuters are suggested then rejected ("That would take a long time"); the online form is agreed ("Yes — that's quick... Let's do that"). Answer B.

Q24. The tutor says the review is "too long — cut it by a third": B. Recent sources are praised, which kills C; methodology is explicitly unnecessary, killing A.

Q25. The tutor enumerates: wording fine, length fine, response rate very low. Answer C.

Q26. "Not the finished questions, and I don't need the lab booked yet — just a one-page progress report." Answer B.

Q27-30 (matching with both). Dan: transport letter (27 = A) and slides (30 = A). Priya: charts (28 = B). Introduction: both (29 = C).

Q31-32 (lecture vocabulary). Barter goods: grain, cattle, salt, shells — any one is accepted. The weakness is the "coincidence of wants", an exact phrase from the lecture, so it must be copied correctly.

Q33-35 (China). Eleventh century; receipts issued by merchants, but the state took over issuing — note that Q34 asks who the early receipts came from, which the lecture says were trusted merchants, while the notes themselves were state-issued. Q35 is signature (or seal): "the signature or seal of the issuing official".

Q36-38 (Europe). Seventeenth-century London goldsmiths. Trust was in the goldsmith, not the gold — a deliberate reversal in the script. Note-issuing became a legal monopoly.

Q39-40 (modern). Polymer notes are harder to counterfeit; the decisive advantage for central banks is the lower replacement cost.

Diagnostic table

Score /40	Approx. band	Next step
30+	7.0+	Move to Section 3-4 accuracy drills; check spelling list
26-29	6.5	Focus on Sections 3-4 note completion; 20 min daily
23-25	6.0	Re-read Chapter 7, especially distractors and signposts
18-22	5.5	Drill numbers, dates and spelling (Chapter 7.2-7.3) daily for two weeks
Below 18	≤5.0	Rebuild from Chapter 6 question types one at a time

Count your errors by type before you count your score: spelling errors, plural errors, word-limit errors, missed distractors, or missed place. The class with the most errors is your next week's study plan.

CHAPTER 9

Reading: The Ten Question Types and How to Beat Each One

Academic Reading gives you 60 minutes for three passages and 40 questions. That is an average of 90 seconds per question, including reading time. No candidate reads every word. The successful candidate reads the question precisely and the passage selectively.

9.1 The master principle: questions first, passage second

For each passage:

- 1 Read the title and the first paragraph (30–45 seconds). You need the topic and the author's direction.
- 2 Read all the questions for that passage, underlining the key words and the instruction word (TRUE/FALSE/NOT GIVEN, NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS, and so on).
- 3 Predict answer locations — questions usually follow the order of the passage, so the first question is near the top.
- 4 Scan for the keywords or their paraphrases, read that sentence and its neighbours, answer, move on.

Order matters more than speed. Roughly 90% of question sets follow the passage's order. Two types do not: matching headings and matching information. Answer those last, once you know the passage.

9.2 The ten question types

Type	Typical location	Order in passage	Main skill
1 TRUE/FALSE/NOT GIVEN	Passage 1–3	Yes	Logic and precise comparison
2 YES/NO/NOT GIVEN	Passage 3	Yes	Author's opinion
3 Matching headings	Passage 2–3	No	Paragraph gist
4 Matching information	Passage 2–3	No	Skimming for detail location
5 Matching features/names	Passage 3	No (options)	Detail attribution
6 Multiple choice	Any	Yes	Detail + inference
7 Sentence completion	Passage 1–2	Yes	Grammar + detail
8 Summary/note/table completion	Any	Yes	Paraphrase + detail
9 Diagram labelling	Passage 1–2	Yes	Spatial description
10 Short answer	Passage 1–2	Yes	Detail location

9.3 Type 1 & 2: TRUE/FALSE/NOT GIVEN and YES/NO/NOT GIVEN

The most feared and most misunderstood types. The logic is exact:

Answer	Condition	Test question to ask
TRUE / YES	The statement agrees with the passage	Can I point to a sentence that says this?
FALSE / NO	The statement contradicts the passage	Can I point to a sentence that says the opposite?
NOT GIVEN	The passage neither confirms nor contradicts	Is the information simply absent?

The four rules that resolve almost every T/F/NG dispute:

- 1 NOT GIVEN is about absence, not uncertainty. If the passage says nothing about the statement's key element, the answer is NOT GIVEN even if it feels plausible.
- 2 Watch quantifiers. Some $\neq$ all; often $\neq$ always; may $\neq$ will; most $\neq$ every. Changing a quantifier usually turns TRUE into FALSE.
- 3 Watch time. In 1990 $\neq$ currently; will $\neq$ has already.
- 4 Contradiction must be real. "The plan was popular in cities" + statement "The plan was popular everywhere" $\rightarrow$ FALSE. But "The plan was popular in cities" + statement "The plan was popular in rural areas" $\rightarrow$ NOT GIVEN, because nothing contradicts it.

Worked examples

Passage: Early bicycles were expensive, and only wealthy men could afford them.
 Statement: In the beginning, bicycles were too costly for most people. $\rightarrow$ TRUE (expensive/only wealthy agrees).
 Statement: Early bicycles were cheaper than horses. $\rightarrow$ NOT GIVEN (no comparison with horses).
 Statement: Early bicycles were affordable for working families. $\rightarrow$ FALSE (contradicts).

Never use outside knowledge. If the passage says the opposite of what you know to be true, the passage wins. IELTS tests reading, not science.

9.4 Type 3: Matching headings

You match a list of headings (i-x) to paragraphs (A-F). There are always more headings than paragraphs, so some are traps. Headings are not in passage order.

Procedure

- 1 Read the headings first and differentiate them: underline the distinguishing word — usually the topic (what) or the function (why/how).
- 2 Take the first and last sentences of each paragraph, plus any repeated noun. The main idea is nearly always there.
- 3 Watch for headings that describe a detail rather than the paragraph's main idea — that is the standard distractor.
- 4 Eliminate headings as you use them.

Heading families and what they signal

Heading wording	What to look for
The origins of... / Early history	dates, first uses
A change in approach	however, but, shifted
Practical applications	examples of use
Criticism of the theory	negative evaluation, critics, questioned
The economic impact	money, cost, profit
Future directions	may, will, in future, could

9.5 Type 4: Matching information (which paragraph contains...?)

"Which paragraph contains the following information?" — you match statements to paragraph letters. The statements are not in order.

Procedure

- 1 Do the easy ones first: a name, a year, a number, or a quoted person is fast to scan for.
- 2 For abstract statements ("a reference to a disagreement between researchers"), scan for the function — quotation marks, however, argued.
- 3 Paragraphs may be used more than once — or not at all. Read the instruction; it will say "you may use any letter more than once" if so.

9.6 Type 5: Matching features (names, dates, categories)

Match a list of researchers, theories, places or dates to statements.

- Scan the passage for the names (capital letters stand out) and read around each one.
- The order of the questions follows neither the passage nor the list, but the names appear in passage order, so process them one by one.
- Each option may be used more than once or not at all, unless the instruction says otherwise.

9.7 Type 6: Multiple choice

Options are long and the trap rate is high.

Procedure

- 1 Read the question stem first and paraphrase it into a question of your own.
- 2 Read option A, then scan for it. If the passage contradicts it, eliminate it — do not keep it "just in case".
- 3 Beware of options that are true in the passage but do not answer the question — the most common distractor in IELTS Reading.
- 4 The correct option usually paraphrases the passage; the wrong options borrow the passage's exact words.

Extreme options (all, never, only, completely) are usually wrong. Qualified options (may, often, in some cases, tends to) are usually right.

9.8 Types 7 & 8: Sentence, summary, note and table completion

You fill gaps using words from the passage.

The golden rules

- 1 Respect the word limit exactly. Copy words from the passage; do not change them.
- 2 Check grammar. The completed sentence must be grammatical: singular/plural, verb form, preposition.
- 3 Find the gap's paraphrase in the passage. "The main cause of the decline was..." will appear as "deterioration resulted largely from..."
- 4 Summary completion with a word bank (A-H) works differently: the option letters are given, and the correct option will fit both meaning and grammar.

Micro-example

Summary: Bees communicate the location of food by performing a (1) dance.
 Passage: ...the forager returns and performs a figure-of-eight movement, known as the waggle dance... Answer: waggle (one word; figure-of-eight would be two words and describe shape, not the dance's name).

9.9 Type 9: Diagram labelling

You label parts of a diagram or describe a process.

- Scan for the names of the labelled parts in the passage. The description mirrors the diagram's layout.
- Direction words matter: above, below, to the left, at the base, at the tip.
- Word limits apply; usually one or two words.

9.10 Type 10: Short answer questions

- The answer is a noun phrase; if the question is "How long...?" the answer may be a duration (three weeks) but must respect the word limit.
- Scan for the question's keyword and read the surrounding sentence.

9.11 Instruction words you must never skim

Instruction	Consequence of ignoring it
Choose TWO letters	One letter scores zero
NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS AND/OR A NUMBER	Extra words = zero
You may use any letter more than once	You may waste an option

Instruction	Consequence of ignoring it
Write the correct letter A-H	Writing the word instead of the letter = zero
Answer both parts of the question	Half answers earn nothing

9.12 Time-budget table

Passage	Time	Target accuracy
Passage 1	17 minutes	12-13 correct
Passage 2	20 minutes	10-12 correct
Passage 3	20 minutes	8-11 correct
Review and guesses	3 minutes	Never leave a blank

There is no penalty for a wrong answer. Every blank should contain a guess. Statistically, guessing three or four answers adds a mark or two per test to a candidate's score, which is often exactly the difference between two half-bands.

9.13 The five-minute reset

If you notice you have spent more than two minutes on one question:

- 1 Mark it with a circle and guess an answer.
- 2 Move to the next question immediately.
- 3 Return only if time remains at the end.

Candidates who obey this rule routinely gain three to five marks over candidates who do not.

The next chapter drills the reading skills that make this possible: skim, scan, paraphrase and infer.

CHAPTER 10

Reading: Skimming, Scanning and the Not-Given Logic

Three skills carry Academic Reading: skimming (finding the shape of a passage), scanning (finding a specific place), and paraphrase recognition (matching the question's meaning to the passage's different words). A fourth — time discipline — protects the score you have already earned.

10.1 Skimming: reading for shape, not detail

You skim in the first 30–45 seconds of a passage, and again when you attack a headings task.

What to read while skimming

- 1 The title and any italicised subtitle or date.
- 2 The first sentence of every paragraph — in academic writing this is the topic sentence in roughly 80% of cases.
- 3 The last sentence of the passage and of any paragraph that seems to be concluding.
- 4 Capitalised names and numbers — they are the landmarks you will scan for later.

What to ignore while skimming

- Examples and lists (they only illustrate the main idea).
- Adjectives and adverbs, unless they carry the argument (only, rarely, always).
- Anything in brackets or after e.g., such as, for example.

The 30-second passage map. After skimming, write three or four words beside each paragraph:

Paragraph	Map note
A	history, 19th century
B	the problem with early methods
C	the new theory (main idea)
D	evidence: experiment results
E	criticism
F	future uses

That map is worth more than a second reading. It converts the passage into a searchable structure and it is exactly what matching-headings questions require.

10.2 Scanning: locating without reading

Scanning is not fast reading; it is targeted pattern-searching. You look only for a shape: a word's capital letters, a number, a distinctive noun.

The scan sequence

- 1 Choose the keyword in the question. Prefer: proper nouns > numbers > technical nouns > ordinary nouns. Avoid: verbs, adjectives and pronouns — they are paraphrased most aggressively.
- 2 Fix the keyword's shape in your mind — how many words, capital letters, digits.
- 3 Move your eyes down the passage in a zig-zag, not line by line, stopping only on shapes that match.
- 4 Read only the sentence you land on, plus the one before and after.
- 5 Compare the question to that sentence, word by word, concept by concept.

Course teachers hammer the same point: locate the paragraph from the question, then compare. The question tells you what to look for; the passage tells you what was actually said. The answer is the result of comparing those two statements, never of one alone.

10.3 Paraphrase recognition: the real skill

Reading questions almost never reuse the passage's words. Build the habit of translating the question into "spoke-to-me language" before you scan.

The question says	The passage may say
The main reason for the decline	The primary cause of the downturn
Most participants agreed	The overwhelming majority of respondents concurred
It is difficult to measure	quantification remains problematic
The approach was abandoned	The method was dropped / fell out of use
There was little support	Few endorsed it / Support was scarce
He challenged the theory	He questioned / disputed the hypothesis

Drill. Take any Reading passage. For each question, draw a two-column table: question wording | passage wording. After ten passages you will begin to see the paraphrase patterns — negation, nominalisation, synonym substitution — instantly.

10.4 The NOT GIVEN discipline

NOT GIVEN is not "the passage didn't use exactly those words". It is "the passage does not contain this information".

Three tests to apply before choosing NOT GIVEN:

- 1 The missing-element test. Which single element of the statement is absent — the subject, the comparison, the cause, the time? Name it. If the absence is real, it is NOT GIVEN.
- 2 The plausibility trap. If the statement is something you would expect to be true, IELTS is far more likely to make it NOT GIVEN than TRUE — because plausible statements tempt candidates who answer from knowledge.
- 3 The contradiction test. To choose FALSE you must be able to quote the passage saying the opposite. If your evidence is "it doesn't quite fit", it is NOT GIVEN.

Contrast drills

Passage	Statement	Answer	Why
The bridge was completed in 1890.	The bridge was completed in the nineteenth century.	TRUE	compatible, and it is stated
The bridge was completed in 1890.	The bridge took more than three years to build.	NOT GIVEN	duration is never mentioned
The bridge was completed in 1890.	The bridge was finished in 1880.	FALSE	direct contradiction
Many students prefer online lectures.	Online lectures are more popular than classroom lectures among all students.	FALSE	many $\neq$ all, prefer $\neq$ more popular than

10.5 Order of answering: the strategy checklist

Academic Reading allows you to answer questions in any order within a passage, and even to attempt passages in a different order. The strategy that works for most candidates:

- 1 Start with Passage 1. It is the easiest and acts as a warm-up; three correct answers there cost less time than one correct answer in Passage 3.
- 2 Within a passage, do the ordered question types first (T/F/NG, completion, MCQ) and leave matching headings and matching information until you know the passage well.
- 3 Never begin with Passage 3. Beginning with the hardest passage exhausts your concentration on the questions with the lowest return per minute.

Some teachers on YouTube advise starting with the hardest passage. This course's instructor gives the opposite advice, and the statistics support him: Passage 3 has the most sophisticated language and the longest texts, so a tired reader loses more marks there than a fresh reader gains.

10.6 Time discipline: the three-passage rule

Stage	Passage 1	Passage 2	Passage 3
Skim and map	2 min	2 min	2 min
Answer ordered types	10 min	12 min	12 min
Answer matching types	4 min	5 min	5 min
Review	1 min	1 min	1 min
Total	17 min	20 min	20 min

If you finish Passage 1 in 15 minutes, do not spend the extra two minutes perfecting it — invest them in Passage 3, where the questions are worth exactly the same mark.

The hard-stop rule. At minute 40, you must be starting Passage 3. At minute 58, every blank must contain an answer, guessed if necessary.

10.7 Paper-based vs computer-delivered reading

Computer-delivered IELTS changes the logistics, not the skills. Two habits to build if you test on computer:

Feature	How to exploit it
Split screen (passage left, questions right)	Read the question on the right, scan on the left — no page-turning, no lost place
Highlighter tool	Highlight the keyword of each question, then highlight its match in the passage. This is the single most useful tool on the screen
Copy-paste	Use it to transfer answers exactly: it eliminates spelling and transposition errors (still check the word limit)
Note tool	Use it to write your paragraph map for matching-headings questions
Review screen	Answers you have flagged appear together — check the word limits in one sweep at the end

In the paper-based test, do the same thing with a pencil: underline the keyword in the question, circle the matching word in the passage. The physical marking is not decoration — it prevents the most common error in Reading, answering from memory instead of from the text.

10.8 Vocabulary in context: guessing unknown words

You will meet unknown words; the exam is designed that way. Four clues resolve most of them:

Clue	Example
Definition in the sentence	The process, known as osmosis, allows water to pass...
Example following	Nocturnal animals, such as owls and bats, ...
Contrast	Unlike the fragile early models, the new design was robust.
Word parts	in-conclusive, deforestation, bio-degradable

Ask: does the sentence's logic require a positive or negative word? Very often that is enough to answer the question, even without knowing the word's exact meaning.

10.9 The ten errors that cost the most marks

- 1 Answering from memory or from general knowledge instead of from the text.
- 2 Writing more than the word limit.
- 3 Copying a word and changing its form (increase → increasing).
- 4 Missing NOT GIVEN because the statement sounded reasonable.
- 5 Spending four minutes on a single question.
- 6 Leaving the matching-headings task until the end and having no time left for it.
- 7 Reading the whole passage in detail before looking at the questions.
- 8 Forgetting that some tasks say "you may use any letter more than once".

- 9 Losing the passage's argument because the author's stance is expressed with hedging (arguably, it seems).
- 10 Leaving blanks at the end of the hour. There is no penalty for a guess.

10.10 A four-week Reading programme

Week	Focus	Daily task (40 min)
1	Skimming and scanning	Passage map in 3 minutes + 13 questions in 17 minutes
2	T/F/NG and Y/N/NG logic	20 T/F/NG items daily, with a written justification for each
3	Matching types + MCQ distractors	Full passage in 20 minutes, then error classification
4	Full tests under time	One complete 60-minute test every second day

Justify every answer. For each T/F/NG item, write one line: "Paragraph C says X, which agrees/contradicts/is silent about the statement." This is slower than answering, but it is the only method that builds accuracy rather than luck.

10.11 The paraphrase notebook

Keep a dedicated page per test:

Question keyword	Passage paraphrase	Question type
a shortage of	an inadequate supply of	summary completion
was unaware of	had no knowledge of	T/F/NG
the majority of	most / the bulk of	MCQ
gave up	abandoned / discontinued	matching information

After twenty passages you will own several hundred paraphrase pairs — which is, in effect, a private dictionary of IELTS Reading.

10.12 What the passage will never require

- Background knowledge of the subject.
- Understanding of every word.
- Reading the passage in full before answering.
- The same answer used twice in a T/F/NG set (each statement is judged independently).

Now bring these skills to a full practice test.

CHAPTER 11

Reading Practice Test 1

Instructions. Three passages, 40 questions, 60 minutes. No extra transfer time. Write your answers on a separate sheet, then mark them with the key in the next chapter. All passages and questions in this test are original to this book.

Timing target: Passage 1 by minute 17 · Passage 2 by minute 37 · Passage 3 complete by minute 58.

READING PASSAGE 1

You should spend about 17 minutes on Questions 1–13.

The Long Journey of the Potato

A Few foods have travelled as far, or changed as many lives, as the potato. It began as a wild plant in the high Andes of South America, where it was gathered by hunter-gatherers long before it was deliberately cultivated. Archaeological evidence from the Peruvian coast suggests that communities were farming potatoes at least seven thousand years ago, making it one of the oldest cultivated crops in the world. What made the plant unusual was its tolerance: the potato will grow at altitudes above three thousand metres, where maize and wheat fail, and it survives frost that destroys other staples.

B Andean farmers did not grow a single kind of potato. They grew hundreds, on terraces cut into mountainsides, and they developed a technique for dealing with the problem of storage. By trampling tubers and leaving them to freeze at night and dry in the sun during the day, they produced chuño — a lightweight, freeze-dried food that could be kept for years and carried by armies. This processing technique, developed without any knowledge of microbiology, is one of the most sophisticated food preservation methods ever devised.

C The potato reached Europe in the second half of the sixteenth century, carried by Spanish ships returning from the Andes. Its reception was cautious, and not only because it was unfamiliar. The plant belongs to the nightshade family, and European farmers knew that other members of that family were poisonous. The potato's leaves and stems in fact contain solanine, which is toxic, and because the tubers themselves sometimes turned green when exposed to light, suspicion was reasonable. For more than a century the crop remained a curiosity, grown in botanical gardens and by a few adventurous landowners.

D What changed its status was hunger. In the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries, European populations were growing while the land available for wheat and rye was fixed. Several governments, notably in Prussia and France, actively promoted the potato as a solution, distributing seed and publishing instructions for its cultivation. The crop's advantage was measurable: a field of potatoes produced two to four times the calories of the same field of grain, and it grew on poor soil. Within two generations, the potato had become the daily food of millions of peasants in Ireland, Prussia, Poland and Russia.

E The dependence came at a price. Because European farmers planted a small number of varieties, all descended from a few original introductions, the crop was genetically uniform. When a fungal disease arrived in the 1840s, it spread through the fields of Europe with terrible speed. The epidemic, known as late blight, destroyed harvests across the continent; in Ireland, where the dependence was greatest, it caused the starvation or emigration of millions of people within five years. The disaster was not caused by the potato itself but by the decision to grow it as a single crop.

F Modern agriculture has learned from that lesson. Plant breeders maintain collections of thousands of Andean varieties, and the potato's genetic diversity is now treated as a resource as valuable as the crop itself. Breeders search the collections for resistance to disease, tolerance of drought and the ability to grow with less fertiliser. In a changing climate, the plant that once escaped the Andes to feed the world is being asked to save

the diversity it left behind.

Questions 1–7. Do the following statements agree with the information given in the passage?

Write TRUE if the statement agrees with the information, FALSE if the statement contradicts the information, NOT GIVEN if there is no information on this.

1 Potatoes were being cultivated in South America more than six thousand years ago. 2 The potato grows better than maize at high altitudes. 3 Andean farmers grew only one type of potato in each field. 4 Chuño was produced by a method that used the cold of the mountains. 5 The potato's leaves are safe to eat. 6 The potato arrived in Europe before it arrived in Asia. 7 European farmers planted large numbers of different potato varieties.

Questions 8–10. Complete the sentences below. Write NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS AND/OR A NUMBER from the passage for each answer.

8 A field of potatoes produced up to the calories of a field of grain. 9 The disease that destroyed harvests in the 1840s is known as 10 Breeders look for potatoes that can grow with less

Questions 11–13. Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

11 According to the passage, suspicion of the potato in Europe was partly caused by

- A its high price.
- B its similarity to poisonous plants.
- C a shortage of land.
- D religious objections.

12 The disaster of the 1840s was caused mainly by

- A a change in the weather.
- B the arrival of a new crop.
- C the lack of genetic variety in European potatoes.
- D a shortage of seed potatoes.

13 What is the writer's main point in the final paragraph?

- A Modern farming has abandoned the potato.
- B Andean varieties are no longer useful.
- C The diversity of potatoes has become an important resource.
- D Potatoes are easier to grow than they were in the past.

READING PASSAGE 2

You should spend about 20 minutes on Questions 14–26.

The Quiet Revolution in Urban Design

A For most of the twentieth century, the ideal city was a city of movement. Planners separated workplaces from homes, built wide arterial roads and designed suburbs on the assumption that every family would own a car. The results were efficient for drivers, but they produced neighbourhoods where walking served no purpose, where children depended on adults for every journey, and where the street — historically a place of encounter — became a corridor for traffic.

B Dissatisfaction with this model grew slowly and then quickly. In the 1970s, a group of architects in Denmark began experimenting with turning streets into public rooms. Their first project, in Copenhagen, closed a single street to cars and added benches. The experiment was expected to fail; instead, cafes along the street reported increased trade, and within a decade the city had begun converting whole districts. The approach acquired a name — traffic calming — and a principle: a street is not only a way to get from one place to another, but also a place where public life happens.

C Evidence accumulated from several disciplines. Public-health researchers found that residents of walkable neighbourhoods took more exercise in the course of ordinary life and, over decades, weighed less than residents of car-dependent suburbs. Economists found that shops on streets with heavy traffic had fewer customers than identical shops on quiet streets; the traffic that supposedly delivered trade also discouraged it. And sociologists reported that residents of streets with light traffic knew far more of their neighbours.

D The movement's most ambitious test came in the Netherlands, where planners introduced the *woonerf*, or "living yard". In these streets, pedestrians and vehicles legally share the same space. Physical features — narrow entrances, uneven paving, planting and benches — encourage drivers to travel at walking speed and to expect people in the road. Speed limits are low, and in a collision the driver is presumed responsible. The design works not by separating traffic from people but by making traffic behave like a guest in a place that belongs to residents.

E Critics, however, raise practical objections. The first is cost: retrofitting a street is expensive, and the money must come from limited municipal budgets. The second is displacement: if a district becomes quieter, cleaner and more attractive, rents rise, and the people who benefited least from the improvement may be the people priced out of it. The third is accessibility: some disabled users and older residents find uneven, shared surfaces harder to navigate than the straight kerbs and clear sightlines of a conventional street. Planners in several cities now hold consultations specifically with disability groups before a scheme is built, and some designs have been modified as a result.

F The most striking evidence comes from comparative studies of cities rather than streets. Researchers comparing European cities found that those which invested heavily in cycling infrastructure in the 1980s and 1990s now have both higher cycling rates and lower rates of road fatalities, including among non-cyclists. The mechanism was simple: where protected space existed, more people cycled; where more people cycled, drivers became used to their presence; and where drivers expected cyclists, they drove more

carefully.

G What began as an experiment with one street in Copenhagen is now part of the planning orthodoxy of many cities, though often in modified form. Few planners today would claim that a city can be designed purely around the car without cost to health, commerce and social life. The debate has moved on from whether to change to how fast change is possible without displacing the very people the changes are meant to benefit.

Questions 14–18. The passage has seven paragraphs, A–G. Which paragraph contains the following information? Write the correct letter, A–G, for each answer.

14 a comparison of the health of residents in different kinds of neighbourhood
15 a description of how street design can change driver behaviour
16 the original twentieth-century assumption behind suburban planning
17 a description of evidence that was unexpected
18 a concern about who may be forced to leave an improved area

Questions 19–23. Complete the summary below. Write NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS from the passage for each answer.

The first experiment In the 1970s, architects in Denmark closed one street to cars and put 19 in the street. Observers expected the project to 20 Businesses on the street actually did better, and the city began to convert 21 The approach was given the name 22 , based on the idea that a street is also a place where 23 takes place.

Questions 24–26. Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

24 What do we learn about shops on quiet streets?

- A They are usually more expensive.
- B They attract more customers than shops on busy streets.
- C They are less profitable than shops on main roads.
- D They rely on tourists.

25 In a woonerf, responsibility for a collision rests mainly with

- A the pedestrian.
- B the driver.
- C the local authority.
- D both parties equally.

26 What does the writer suggest in the final paragraph?

- A The debate now concerns the speed of change and its social effects.
- B Most planners still design cities around cars.
- C The Danish experiment was a failure.
- D Displacement can never be avoided.

READING PASSAGE 3

You should spend about 20 minutes on Questions 27–40.

Why We Forget, and Why That Is Useful

A Memory is commonly imagined as a store: information goes in, and the aim is to keep it there. This picture is intuitive and, according to a growing body of research, misleading. Forgetting is not a malfunction that happens when storage is full or when a file is lost. It is an active process, built into the architecture of the brain, and in most circumstances it is not a failure at all but a feature.

B Consider what a memory system would need to do in a world that changes. An organism that retained every detail of every experience with equal clarity would be overwhelmed: the location of food discovered last month would compete on equal terms with the location of food discovered yesterday. Remembering everything is not a superpower; it is a disability. The brain therefore prioritises. It strengthens the traces that appear useful — those that are repeated, emotionally significant, or connected to what is already known — and allows the rest to fade.

C The mechanism of fading depends on the type of memory. Facts and events, which depend on a structure called the hippocampus, are stored initially in a fragile form and gradually stabilised, a process known as consolidation, which is heavily dependent on sleep. Interfere with sleep and consolidation suffers; a well-known experiment found that participants who learned a task and then slept performed better than those who stayed awake for the same number of hours, without any additional practice. Skills, by contrast, are stored differently and appear to improve with a different pattern of rest. What both systems share is that storing and losing are simultaneous: while some connections are strengthened, others are deliberately weakened.

D Forgetting also has a social function. Memories are not recorded like photographs; each time we recall an event, we reconstruct it, and each reconstruction is influenced by what we have been told since. The psychologist Elizabeth Loftus demonstrated in a series of experiments that participants could be led to "remember" events that had never occurred, including being lost in a shopping centre as a child, simply because they had been told the story by a relative. False memories are not rare curiosities; they are the predictable product of a system that prioritises coherence over accuracy. That system lets us maintain a workable sense of our own past — but it also makes confident testimony unreliable.

E From a practical point of view, the most useful discovery is that forgetting is not random but patterned. Ebbinghaus, working in the 1880s with lists of nonsense syllables, plotted a curve of decline: sharply at first, then gently. More than a century later, the shape of that curve is still used to plan revision. Its practical implication is that spaced review — revisiting material after an interval, and then after a longer interval again — produces far more durable learning than the same total time spent in one block. The forgetting that occurs between reviews is not wasted time; it is the condition that makes the later review effective.

F This has direct consequences for advice about studying. Techniques that feel productive — rereading a chapter, highlighting, summarising — produce a feeling of familiarity that students often mistake for knowledge. Testing oneself, by contrast, feels uncomfortable and predicts performance much better. In comparative studies, students

who read a passage four times performed worse a week later than students who read it once and were tested three times, although the rereaders predicted they would do far better. The uncomfortable method wins.

G The uncomfortable conclusion is that the popular metaphor of memory as storage has practical costs. Students revise by rereading because rereading makes the material feel familiar, and they avoid testing themselves because testing reveals ignorance. Yet it is precisely the act of retrieval — the effort of dragging an answer out of a fading trace — that strengthens the trace most. Forgetting, in other words, is not the enemy of learning. It is the mechanism that makes learning possible.

Questions 27–32. Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

27 What is the writer's main criticism of the storage metaphor in paragraph A?

- A It is too modern.
- B It misunderstands the active nature of forgetting.
- C It applies only to skills.
- D It was disproved in the 1880s.

28 In paragraph B, the writer argues that a perfect memory would be

- A useful for finding food.
- B a disadvantage.
- C found only in animals.
- D easy to achieve.

29 According to paragraph C, consolidation is strongly affected by

- A exercise.
- B diet.
- C sleep.
- D practice time.

30 What does the shopping-centre experiment show?

- A Memories are recorded accurately.
- B People rarely believe false stories.
- C Recall involves reconstruction.
- D Children have better memories than adults.

31 What does the writer say about the Ebbinghaus curve?

- A It is no longer relevant.
- B Its shape still guides revision planning.
- C It applied only to nonsense syllables.
- D It measures skills rather than facts.

32 According to the passage, testing yourself is more effective than rereading because

- A it is more comfortable.
- B it takes less time.
- C it produces familiarity.
- D the effort of retrieval strengthens memory.

Questions 33–36. Complete each sentence with the correct ending, A–G, below. Write the correct letter, A–G, next to Questions 33–36.

33 The brain strengthens memory traces that... 34 Skills and facts appear to... 35 Memories are altered by... 36 Students who reread material tend to...

- A be stored and improved in different ways.
- B what we are told after the event.
- C predict their performance inaccurately.
- D appear useful, repeated or emotionally significant.
- E forget everything within a week.
- F be weakened by testing.
- G depend entirely on nonsense syllables.

Questions 37–40. Do the following statements agree with the claims of the writer?

Write YES if the statement agrees with the claims of the writer, NO if the statement contradicts the claims, NOT GIVEN if it is impossible to say what the writer thinks about this.

37 Forgetting usually indicates that the memory system has failed. 38 Spaced review is more effective than the same total time spent in one block. 39 Highlighting is a reliable method of long-term learning. 40 Most students are unable to change their study habits.

CHAPTER 12

Reading Practice Test 1 — Answer Key and Explanations

Answer key

Q	Answer	Q	Answer	Q	Answer	Q	Answer
1	TRUE	11	B	21	whole districts	31	B
2	TRUE	12	C	22	traffic calming	32	D
3	FALSE	13	C	23	public life	33	D
4	TRUE	14	C	24	B	34	A
5	FALSE	15	D	25	B	35	B
6	NOT GIVEN	16	A	26	A	36	C
7	FALSE	17	B	27	B	37	NO
8	four times	18	E	28	B	38	YES
9	late blight	19	benches	29	C	39	NO
10	fertiliser	20	fail	30	C	40	NOT GIVEN

Passage 1 — detailed explanations

1 TRUE. Paragraph A: "communities were farming potatoes at least seven thousand years ago". Seven thousand is more than six thousand, so the statement agrees. Note the paraphrase: farming = cultivating, at least seven thousand > more than six thousand.

2 TRUE. Paragraph A: "the potato will grow at altitudes above three thousand metres, where maize and wheat fail". The passage states maize fails where the potato succeeds, which supports "grows better at high altitudes".

3 FALSE. Paragraph B opens "Andean farmers did not grow a single kind of potato. They grew hundreds...". The word hundreds directly contradicts only one type.

4 TRUE. Paragraph B: freeze at night, dry in the sun during the day. Chuño is precisely a product of using mountain cold.

5 FALSE. Paragraph C: "The potato's leaves and stems in fact contain solanine, which is toxic." The statement contradicts this.

6 NOT GIVEN. The passage describes the Andes and Europe only. No information is given about Asia, so no comparison is possible. This is the classic absence case: an entirely plausible idea (potatoes did reach Asia) that the text does not address.

7 FALSE. Paragraph E: "European farmers planted a small number of varieties", and paragraph B makes the contrast explicit — hundreds of varieties in the Andes.

8 four times. The limit allows two words and/or a number. The passage says "two to four times the calories"; the maximum is four times. Writing two to four times would be four words — over the limit.

9 late blight. Copied exactly as a name. Blight alone would be only partially correct; the answer is the disease's full name, and two words are allowed.

10 fertiliser. "the ability to grow with less fertiliser" — spelled with British -ise, but either spelling is accepted.

11 B. Paragraph C states that other members of the nightshade family were known to be poisonous and that the potato's own leaves contain solanine. Price, land and religion are not mentioned as causes (land shortage appears later, in paragraph D, as a reason for adopting the crop).

12 C. Paragraph E: the epidemic spread fast "because European farmers planted a small number of varieties" and "the disaster was not caused by the potato itself but by the decision to grow it as a single crop".

13 C. The final paragraph is about breeding collections and treating diversity "as a resource as valuable as the crop itself".

Passage 2 — detailed explanations

14 C. Paragraph C reports public-health findings about exercise and weight in walkable versus car-dependent neighbourhoods.

15 D. Paragraph D describes the woonerf, where physical features encourage drivers to travel at walking speed. Paragraph F also touches on driver behaviour, but D is the direct description of design changing behaviour; F is comparative evidence between cities. Notice that this is why the question wording matters — "a description of how street design can change driver behaviour" points to the design description.

16 A. Paragraph A sets out the twentieth-century assumption: separate uses, wide roads, car ownership.

17 B. Paragraph B: "The experiment was expected to fail; instead, cafes along the street reported increased trade" — evidence that contradicted expectations.

18 E. Paragraph E raises displacement: rising rents may push out those who benefited least.

19 benches. "closed a single street to cars and added benches".

20 fail. "The experiment was expected to fail".

21 whole districts. "within a decade the city had begun converting whole districts".

22 traffic calming. "The approach acquired a name — traffic calming".

23 public life. "a street is not only a way to get from one place to another, but also a place where public life happens". Life alone would be incomplete; the two-word phrase fits the limit.

24 B. Paragraph C: "shops on streets with heavy traffic had fewer customers than identical shops on quiet streets".

25 B. Paragraph D: "in a collision the driver is presumed responsible".

26 A. The last sentence: "The debate has moved on from whether to change to how fast change is possible without displacing the very people the changes are meant to benefit." Option B contradicts "Few planners today would claim that a city can be designed purely around the car"; C contradicts the whole passage.

Passage 3 — detailed explanations

27 B. Paragraph A argues that the storage picture is misleading "because forgetting is... an active process" — that is the misunderstanding.

28 B. Paragraph B: "Remembering everything is not a superpower; it is a disability."

29 C. Paragraph C: consolidation "is heavily dependent on sleep".

30 C. Paragraph D: "each time we recall an event, we reconstruct it"; the experiment demonstrates that memory is not a recording.

31 B. Paragraph E: "More than a century later, the shape of that curve is still used to plan revision."

32 D. Paragraph G: "it is precisely the act of retrieval — the effort of dragging an answer out of a fading trace — that strengthens the trace most."

33 D. Paragraph B: "It strengthens the traces that appear useful — those that are repeated, emotionally significant, or connected to what is already known."

34 A. Paragraph C: "Skills, by contrast, are stored differently" — facts and skills are stored and consolidated in different ways.

35 B. Paragraph D: "each reconstruction is influenced by what we have been told since".

36 C. Paragraph F: "although the rereaders predicted they would do far better" — an inaccurate prediction.

37 NO. The writer's whole argument is that forgetting is "not a failure at all but a feature".

38 YES. "spaced review... produces far more durable learning than the same total time spent in one block".

39 NO. Paragraph F lists highlighting among the techniques that "produce a feeling of familiarity that students often mistake for knowledge" and reports that such methods perform worse.

40 NOT GIVEN. The passage says students avoid testing themselves, but it never claims they are unable to change. Note the distinction: a tendency is described, an inability is not.

The nine traps this test used

Trap	Where	What to learn
Plausible absence (NOT GIVEN)	Q6	The text discusses only two continents; a plausible third is not "given"
Contradiction in a single word	Q3, Q7	hundreds vs one; small number vs large numbers

Trap	Where	What to learn
Word-limit arithmetic	Q8	two to four times = four words; the answer must be four times
Two paragraphs both plausible	Q15	Choose the paragraph that describes the thing asked for, not the one that mentions it
Exact-name copying	Q9, Q22	Names must be copied exactly
Answer true in the text but wrong for the question	Q11	Price is discussed elsewhere — but not as a cause of suspicion
Inference from tone	Q26, Q13	The final paragraph carries the writer's conclusion
Tendency vs inability	Q40	Precision is the whole game in Y/N/NG
Rereading vs testing	Q32	The passage's key contrast is repeated in several paragraphs — use the strongest statement

Self-marking sheet

Question type	My score	Out of
T/F/NG (Passage 1)		7
Sentence completion		3
Multiple choice (Passage 1)		3
Matching information		5
Summary completion		5
Multiple choice (Passage 2)		3
Multiple choice (Passage 3)		6
Matching sentence endings		4
Y/N/NG		4
Total		40

Band conversion

Raw score	Approx. band
39-40	9.0
37-38	8.5
35-36	8.0
32-34	7.5
30-31	7.0
26-29	6.5
23-25	6.0
18-22	5.5

If your score is under 26, do not do another full test yet. Take one question type — T/F/NG or summary completion — and complete twenty items of that type with written justifications. Accuracy is built one question type at a time.

What to do with the passages after marking

- 1 Paraphrase harvest. For every question, write the question's keyword and the passage's matching words in the table from Chapter 10.11.
- 2 Unknown vocabulary. List ten words you could not define, with the sentence around them, and paraphrase each in context.
- 3 Re-read for shape. Read only the topic sentences of each paragraph and confirm your paragraph map from the test.
- 4 Repeat the passage in 3 days. Redo only the questions you got wrong, without looking at the answers.

CHAPTER 13

Writing Task 1 (Academic): Describing Visual Data

Task 1 asks you to summarise visual information in at least 150 words in about 20 minutes. It is worth one-third of your Writing band. The task is not an essay: you must not give opinions, causes or speculation. You report what the graphic shows.

13.1 The seven possible visuals

Visual	Frequency	What to do
Line graph	Very common	Describe trends over time
Bar chart	Very common	Compare categories, with or without time
Pie chart	Common (often two)	Describe proportions and changes in share
Table	Common	Select and group figures — never list all
Process diagram	Occasional	Describe stages in order, using the passive
Map	Occasional	Describe changes between two dates (or two proposals)
Multiple visuals	Common	Combine: "The chart shows... while the table shows..."

13.2 The four-paragraph structure

Paragraph	Content	Words
1 — Introduction	Paraphrase the task statement: what the graphic shows, where, when	25-35
2 — Overview	The two or three biggest, most general features — no numbers	30-40
3 — Detail 1	The first group of specific figures, with data	45-55
4 — Detail 2	The contrasting group of figures, with data	45-55

The overview is the single most important paragraph. Task Achievement at Band 7 requires a "clear overview of main trends, differences or stages". Without an overview, the response is capped at Band 5 for Task Achievement no matter how good the detail is. Write the overview second, before the details, while you still see the whole picture.

13.3 Introducing the visual: five openings you can adapt

- 1 The line graph illustrates changes in the number of ... between ... and
- 2 The bar chart compares ... across four countries in
- 3 The pie charts show the proportion of ... in two different years.
- 4 The table provides information about
- 5 The diagram illustrates the process by which ... is produced.

Paraphrase the question, do not copy it. If the task says "The chart shows the percentage of households with internet access", write "The chart illustrates the proportion of homes connected to the internet".

13.4 The language of change

Verbs

Direction	Strong	Neutral	Weak
Up	soar, surge, rocket	increase, rise, grow, climb	edge up, creep up
Down	plummet, plunge, collapse	decrease, decline, fall, drop	dip, edge down
Flat	remain stable / constant / unchanged	level off, plateau, hold steady	—

Nouns

a rise, an increase, a growth, an upward trend · a fall, a decline, a decrease, a drop, a downturn · a peak, a low point · a levelling off, a plateau

Adverbs and adjectives of degree and speed

sharply, dramatically, significantly, substantially, considerably · slightly, marginally, modestly, gradually, steadily · suddenly, rapidly, slowly · thereafter, subsequently, respectively

Grammar rules that examiners check

- Verb + adverb: Sales rose sharply.
- Adjective + noun: There was a sharp rise in sales.
- □ Sales rose sharply of 20%. → □ Sales rose sharply to 20%. / ...by 20%.
- □ an increase of 20% (amount) vs an increase to 20% (end point) — these are different claims.

13.5 Describing amounts and proportions

Function	Structures
Proportion	accounted for, made up, constituted, represented + a quarter / 25% / the majority of
Comparison	twice as many as, three times higher than, half the number of, the highest proportion of

Function	Structures
Approximation	approximately, around, just over, just under, nearly, roughly, slightly more than
Ranking	the most popular, the second largest, the least common
Similarity	almost identical, broadly similar, comparable

Never report every number in a table or bar chart. Examiners reward selection: pick the highest, the lowest and one or two contrasting examples, and group the rest ("the remaining three countries accounted for between 10% and 15%").

13.6 Model answer 1 — line graph (Band 9)

Task: The line graph shows the number of visits to three London museums between 2007 and 2017. Summarise the information by selecting and reporting the main features, and make comparisons where relevant.

Model

The line graph illustrates how many people visited three London museums between 2007 and 2017.

Overall, attendance rose at two of the three museums over the period, while visits to the Science Museum fluctuated and finally declined. By the end of the decade the Natural History Museum had become the most popular of the three, having been the least visited at the start.

The Natural History Museum began the period with just under two million visits a year. Numbers climbed steadily thereafter, passing three million by 2013 and peaking at approximately 4.2 million in 2017, more than double the 2007 figure.

The Science Museum followed a different pattern. It was the most visited museum in 2007, attracting around three million people, and remained above that level until 2011. However, attendance then fell sharply, dropping to 2.1 million in 2015, before recovering slightly to 2.5 million at the end of the period.

The Victoria and Albert Museum, by contrast, changed very little. Its visitor numbers hovered between 1.8 and 2.2 million for the first eight years and reached 2.4 million in 2017, a modest overall increase. (190 words)

Why this is Band 9

Criterion	Evidence
Task Achievement	Clear overview in paragraph 2; every key feature covered; no opinion; no invented data
Coherence	Four paragraphs; each detail paragraph has one clear focus, signalled by followed a different pattern and by contrast
Lexical Resource	fluctuated, passing... by, hovered between, a modest overall increase; precise prepositional phrases

Criterion	Evidence
Grammar	A range of structures: having been the least visited, before recovering, by contrast; almost no errors

13.7 Model answer 2 — process diagram (Band 9)

Task: The diagram shows how recycled paper is produced. Summarise the information by selecting and reporting the main features.

Model

The diagram illustrates the stages by which waste paper is converted into new paper suitable for printing.

In general, the process consists of a continuous cycle of collection, cleaning, pulping, de-inking and re-forming, in which the material is broken down and rebuilt rather than used only once. Energy and water are required at several points.

Used paper is first collected from homes and businesses and transported to a recycling plant, where it is sorted by hand to remove non-paper items such as plastic film and metal clips. The sorted paper then passes into a pulper, where it is mixed with warm water and agitated until it breaks down into a thick pulp.

The pulp is subsequently screened to remove smaller contaminants and is then treated with chemicals in a flotation tank, where air bubbles lift ink particles to the surface to be skimmed off. After a final cleaning stage, the de-inked pulp is spread onto a moving mesh, pressed between rollers to remove water, and dried with hot air before being wound onto large reels and distributed for manufacture into new paper products. (185 words)

Notes on process diagrams

- Use the present simple passive: is collected, are sorted, is treated.
- Sequence markers: first, then, subsequently, after which, finally.
- Count the stages and report them all — process diagrams reward completeness, not selection.
- State the input, the output, and whether the process is continuous (a cycle) or linear.

13.8 Model answer 3 — two pie charts (Band 9)

Task: The pie charts show the sources of electricity generation in country X in 2000 and 2020.

Model

The two pie charts compare the sources used to generate electricity in one country in 2000 and 2020.

The most striking change over the twenty-year period was the near-disappearance of coal, which had supplied almost half of all electricity in 2000 but less than a tenth by 2020. Renewables and natural gas filled the gap, and by the end of the period the four main sources were far more balanced than they had been two decades earlier.

In 2000, coal accounted for 48% of generation, followed by natural gas at 22% and nuclear power at 18%. Hydroelectricity contributed 9%, while wind and solar, the smallest category, made up only 3%.

By 2020 the pattern had reversed. Wind and solar had grown more than sixfold to reach 19%, and natural gas had become the largest single source at 31%. Nuclear generation remained broadly stable at 17%, whereas hydroelectricity fell slightly to 7%. Coal, at 8%, had fallen to a fraction of its former share, and was overtaken by every other category except hydro. (188 words)

13.9 Model answer 4 — map (Band 9)

Task: The maps show the village of Bramsford in 1985 and today.

Model

The maps illustrate how the village of Bramsford has changed between 1985 and the present day.

Overall, the village has been substantially developed: farmland and woodland have been reduced, housing has expanded, and the road network has been improved. The most dramatic change is the disappearance of the farms that once dominated the eastern side of the village.

In 1985, Bramsford consisted of a single north-south road with a small cluster of houses around a church in the north-west and two working farms to the east. A narrow lane connected the village to the main road in the south, and woodland covered the northern edge of the settlement.

Today, the two farms have been replaced by a housing estate containing around forty homes, and the church remains, though the surrounding cottages have been extended. The narrow lane has been widened and now forms a bypass, while a new supermarket and car park occupy what was previously farmland in the south-east. The woodland in the north has been reduced by roughly a third and now contains a sports field. (180 words)

Map language

- Position: to the north / in the south-east / along the river / on the edge of
- Change: was demolished, was replaced by, was converted into, was extended, has been built on, gave way to
- Intensifiers: entirely, substantially, partially, roughly half of

13.10 The twenty-minute plan

Minutes	Action
0-1	Read the task and note the time period, units and categories
1-3	Identify the overview: the two or three most obvious features
3-4	Group the data: what will paragraph 3 cover, what will paragraph 4 cover?
4-18	Write: introduction, overview, detail 1, detail 2

Minutes	Action
18-20	Check: word count (≥ 150), verb agreement, prepositions, no opinion

13.11 Fifteen fatal errors in Task 1

- 1 No overview.
- 2 Giving reasons ("because people had more money") — Task 1 requires no explanation.
- 3 Giving opinions or recommendations.
- 4 Copying the task statement word for word.
- 5 Listing every number in a table.
- 6 Writing under 150 words.
- 7 Mixing up by and to for changes.
- 8 Using increase of 20% when you mean increase to 20%.
- 9 Saying the graph says — write the graph shows / illustrates.
- 10 Forgetting the time period in the introduction.
- 11 Describing a map in the passive when the map shows a simple location (mixing tenses).
- 12 Using more with an uncountable noun (more pollution ☐, more people ☐, but ☐ more informations).
- 13 Describing percentages as "numbers of people" (a percentage is a proportion, not a count).
- 14 Adding a conclusion that repeats the introduction.
- 15 Ignoring the second half of a two-part task (e.g. describing the chart but not the table).

13.12 Task 1 checklist before you move on

- ☐ Introduction paraphrases the task
- ☐ Overview states the main trends without numbers
- ☐ Two detail paragraphs, each grouped logically
- ☐ At least eight items of data or comparison
- ☐ Range of trend verbs and noun phrases
- ☐ No opinion, no causes, no recommendations
- ☐ 150+ words, checked
- ☐ Time: within 20 minutes

Turn to the next chapter for the general-purpose grammar of comparison that raises every Task 1 answer.

CHAPTER 14

Writing Task 2: The Essay That Earns Marks

Task 2 is two-thirds of your Writing band. You have 40 minutes and must write at least 250 words. The single most common reason for a disappointing score is not bad English: it is an essay that answers a slightly different question from the one asked.

14.1 The five essay types

Type	Typical wording	Your job	Structure
Opinion (agree/disagree)	To what extent do you agree or disagree?	State and defend one position	Intro + 2 supporting + (concession) + conclusion
Discussion	Discuss both views and give your own opinion.	Both sides plus your view	Intro + view A + view B (+ your view) + conclusion
Advantages/disadvantages	What are the advantages and disadvantages?	Both sides, balanced; opinion only if asked	Intro + advantages + disadvantages + conclusion
Problem-solution	What problems does this cause and what measures could be taken?	Problems and solutions	Intro + problems + solutions + conclusion
Two-part question	Why is this happening? Is it a positive or negative development?	Answer both questions	Intro + answer 1 + answer 2 + conclusion

The instruction-word audit. Before planning, underline and number the jobs the question gives you:

"Some people believe that university education should be free for all students. To what extent do you agree or disagree?" → 1 job: your position. "Some people think children should start school at the age of four, while others believe seven is better. Discuss both views and give your own opinion." → 3 jobs: view A, view B, your opinion.

Count the jobs and write the number in the margin of your answer sheet. Candidates who miss one of three jobs cannot score above Band 5 for Task Response, however elegant their English.

14.2 The plan (4 minutes that save the essay)

- 1 Underline the instruction words and the topic words.
- 2 Decide your position — in one sentence, in your own words. If you cannot write the position sentence, you cannot write the essay.
- 3 Choose two main ideas. Two well-developed ideas beat four thin ones. For each idea write: claim → reason → example or consequence.

- 4 Write a one-line plan for each paragraph. This plan is what keeps you on topic and keeps the essay coherent.

A plan in practice

Question: In many countries, people are living longer. What problems does this cause and what measures could be taken?

Paragraph	Content
Intro	Ageing populations create pressure on pensions and healthcare; two measures can ease it
P1 Problems	Pension systems funded by current workers → fewer workers per retiree → higher taxes or lower pensions; healthcare costs rise with chronic illness
P2 Solutions	Raise retirement age gradually; expand preventive healthcare and community care
Conclusion	The problem is manageable if addressed early rather than delayed

Four minutes of planning produce a 40-minute essay that never loses its way.

14.3 Introductions that work

The two-sentence introduction: (1) paraphrase the question's topic, (2) state your position.

Question: Some people think that children should be given homework every day.
Introduction: Homework has long been a routine part of schooling, yet its value is increasingly questioned. In my view, daily homework is unnecessary for young children, though short, purposeful tasks can benefit older students.

Avoid: "Nowadays, with the development of society, this is a controversial issue that many people discuss..." — this sentence is memorised by thousands of candidates, says nothing, and signals to the examiner that the essay will be generic. Start with substance.

14.4 Body paragraphs: the four-sentence engine

Use the same four-move structure for every body paragraph:

- 1 Topic sentence (claim). One sentence stating the paragraph's single idea.
- 2 Explanation. This is because... / The reason for this is...
- 3 Example or consequence. For instance... / As a result...
- 4 Link back or forward. This suggests that... / Consequently, ...

Worked paragraph

Claim: The most serious consequence of an ageing population is the strain placed on pension systems. **Explanation:** Most state pensions are funded from the contributions of people who are currently working, so a shrinking workforce must support a growing number of retirees. **Example/consequence:** In several European countries, the ratio has already fallen below three contributors per pensioner, which forces governments to choose between raising taxes and reducing payments. **Link:** Either choice is politically painful, which is why the problem tends to be postponed rather than solved.

That is 90 words, one idea, fully developed — exactly what Band 7 Task Response describes.

14.5 Conclusions

Two sentences: restate the position (in different words) and add one implication or recommendation. Never introduce a new idea — new material in a conclusion costs Coherence marks.

In conclusion, while ageing populations undoubtedly create fiscal pressure, the difficulty lies in the timing rather than the scale of the response. Gradual increases in the retirement age, combined with investment in preventive care, would allow most countries to absorb the change without a fall in living standards for the elderly.

14.6 Model essays

Model 1 — Opinion essay (Band 9)

Task: Some people believe that the best way to reduce traffic congestion in cities is to increase the cost of driving. To what extent do you agree or disagree?

Traffic congestion imposes costs on every city: lost working hours, air pollution and a road network that must continually be widened at public expense. Charging drivers more is often proposed as the most effective remedy. I largely agree that higher costs are indispensable, but only when they are part of a wider strategy rather than a stand-alone measure.

The principal argument for charging is that congestion is a consequence of drivers not paying the full cost of their journeys. The delay they impose on others, the pollution their vehicles emit and the road space they occupy are all costs borne by society. When a driver pays only for fuel, these costs are invisible, and the result is predictable: too many journeys by car. Congestion charging, higher parking fees or fuel duties make the true cost visible, and demand responds. London, Stockholm and Singapore have all seen traffic fall within the charged zones after introducing such schemes.

Nevertheless, a charge alone is unjust unless alternatives exist. Where public transport is slow or unreliable, a driver has no real choice, and the charge becomes a tax on people who have no alternative rather than an incentive to change behaviour. This is why the same cities that introduced charges also increased bus frequency and protected cycle lanes, and why public support, initially hostile, grew once the alternatives were visible. Furthermore, revenue from charges must be reinvested in those alternatives; if it disappears into general taxation, the policy loses legitimacy.

A further qualification concerns the people least able to pay. Flat charges are regressive: they take a larger share of income from the low-paid than from the wealthy, while doing nothing to reduce the number of cars owned by those who can easily afford the fee. Any workable scheme therefore needs exemptions for essential workers and discounts for low-income residents.

In conclusion, raising the cost of driving is the most powerful single tool available to reduce congestion, because it addresses the underlying cause: underpriced road space. However, it is effective and politically durable only when it is combined with credible public transport and when its revenue is visibly reinvested. Used alone, it raises money; used as part of a strategy, it changes behaviour. (383 words)

Commentary

Criterion	What earns the mark
Task Response	A qualified position (largely agree, but only if...) held consistently; counter-arguments addressed within the position, not abandoned
Coherence	Four body paragraphs, each with one job: logic of the charge → need for alternatives → equity; discourse markers carry meaning (Nevertheless, Furthermore, A further qualification)
Lexical Resource	imposes costs, indispensable, regressive, legitimacy, politically durable — precise, not decorative
Grammar	Concession (unless, only when), conditionals, passive (borne by society, reinvested, be seen), nominalisation (the result is predictable)

Model 2 — Discussion essay (Band 8.5)

Task: Some people think that children should learn a foreign language from primary school, while others believe it is better to start later. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.

Opinions differ over when foreign-language instruction should begin. Advocates of an early start point to the flexibility of young minds; supporters of a later start argue that children need literacy in their first language before adding a second. Both arguments have weight, and the evidence suggests the answer depends less on age than on the quality and continuity of teaching.

Those who favour starting in primary school emphasise what is often called the critical period. Young children acquire pronunciation with an ease that adults rarely match, and they absorb vocabulary through play and songs without the self-consciousness that makes adolescent learners reluctant to speak. In countries where children begin a second language at six or seven, the long-term outcome is often near-native pronunciation. In addition, an earlier start allocates more total hours to the language, and hours matter: a language cannot be acquired in one hour per week, however early it begins.

The opposing view rests on the demands of literacy. Learning to read and write in one language is cognitively expensive, and introducing a second script or spelling system at the same time can confuse young learners and slow progress in both. Moreover, the

supposed advantage of an early start may be an illusion of exposure rather than of age. Where primary programmes consist of one or two lessons a week and where qualified teachers are scarce, children make limited progress and arrive at secondary school with little to show for six years of instruction.

In my view, the age question is secondary. What matters is continuity: a well-designed sequence from primary to secondary school, taught by teachers who speak the language fluently, with meaningful exposure outside the classroom. Where those conditions exist, an early start compounds its benefits over more years. Where they do not, an early start merely produces early frustration, and resources would be better spent on an intensive secondary programme.

In conclusion, both positions capture a real effect — children's phonetic flexibility on one side, literacy demands and resource limits on the other. The decisive variables are teacher quality and continuity, not the number on the child's birth certificate. (349 words)

Model 3 — Problem-solution essay (Band 8)

Task: In many cities, plastic waste has become a serious problem. What are the causes of this problem and what measures could be taken to solve it?

Plastic waste has become one of the defining environmental problems of urban life. Its causes are principally economic — plastic is cheap, durable and convenient — while the measures that would reduce it require coordinated action by governments, businesses and consumers.

The immediate cause is cost. Plastic packaging is significantly cheaper than glass, metal or paper alternatives, and it is lightweight, which reduces transport costs. A second cause is the structure of waste collection: in many cities, recycling systems cannot process the range of plastics in circulation, so material that householders carefully separate ends up in landfill or is exported. A third cause is consumer habit. Single-use items are embedded in daily routines, from coffee cups to bottled water, and convenience is remarkably resistant to moral argument.

The most effective measures attack the economics rather than the habit. Deposit-return schemes, which refund the cost of a container when it is returned, have raised collection rates for bottles above 90% in several European countries, because they turn waste into something with value. Extended producer responsibility legislation, which makes manufacturers pay for the disposal of what they sell, gives companies a direct financial incentive to redesign packaging. Bans on specific items — cotton buds, straws, single-use bags — work where substitutes exist, and their symbolic value is considerable.

Alongside these, investment in collection and sorting infrastructure is essential, and public education should be directed at the most effective behaviour rather than at guilt in general. Finally, international agreements matter, because the plastic that litters one country's coastline frequently arrives from another.

In conclusion, plastic waste is not primarily a problem of individual carelessness; it is a problem of prices that do not reflect environmental cost and of infrastructure that cannot cope with what is sold. Deposit schemes, producer responsibility and targeted bans address those causes directly, and cities that have adopted them have reduced

plastic waste substantially within a few years. (330 words)

14.7 The opinion spectrum: how to hedge without weakening

Candidates are often told to "avoid sitting on the fence". In practice, a qualified position scores better than a blunt one — as long as the qualification is consistent.

Strength	Wording	When to use
Full agreement	I entirely agree that...	When you can defend it with two strong reasons
Partial agreement (recommended)	I largely agree, although... / This is true to a point, but...	Most questions; allows concession without abandoning the position
Conditional	I agree only if... / It depends on whether...	When the answer genuinely depends on circumstances
Disagreement	I disagree with this view, chiefly because...	When the claim is absolute

The rule: state the position in the introduction and repeat it in the conclusion, with the same degree of strength. A candidate who writes "I completely agree" in the introduction and "however, there are limits" in the conclusion has contradicted themselves.

14.8 Ten essay openings to avoid

- 1 "Nowadays, with the development of modern technology..." (memorised, empty)
- 2 "It is a well-known fact that..." (often untrue)
- 3 "Since the dawn of time, humans have..." (irrelevant)
- 4 "This essay will discuss both sides and then give my opinion." (announces the essay rather than starting it)
- 5 "In this day and age..." (cliché)
- 6 "Some people say X. Others say Y. I will discuss." (no position)
- 7 A dictionary definition: "According to Oxford Dictionary, education means..."
- 8 A rhetorical question: "Have you ever thought about pollution?"
- 9 A statistic you cannot source.
- 10 A memorised sentence you have used in another essay.

14.9 Word-count discipline

Length	Consequence
Under 250	Task Achievement penalty; the essay is also usually underdeveloped
250-290	Ideal — tight, well-developed
290-350	Fine if every sentence carries content
Over 400	Risk: more errors, less time to check, examiner fatigue

Practise writing to a target of 260–300 words. Count the words in your first line and multiply by the number of lines you write to learn your own average — that way you never waste time counting.

14.10 The 40-minute plan

Minutes	Action
0–4	Read the task twice; underline jobs; decide position; write the one-line plan
4–8	Introduction (2 sentences)
8–18	Body paragraph 1
18–28	Body paragraph 2 (+ third body paragraph if time)
28–35	Conclusion
35–40	Edit: agreement, articles, plurals, spelling, repetition

Write the conclusion even if you run short of time — an unfinished essay loses marks for Task Response and Coherence. If you must cut, cut the third body paragraph, never the conclusion.

14.11 Editing checklist (use in the last five minutes)

- [] Every verb agrees with its subject
- [] Articles before singular countable nouns (a, the, or none)
- [] Plurals after many, several, these, those, a number of
- [] No contracted forms (don't → do not)
- [] No repeated word in consecutive sentences
- [] One complex sentence per paragraph minimum
- [] Position stated in introduction and repeated in conclusion, with the same strength
- [] 250+ words
- [] Paragraphs clearly indented or separated by a blank line

The next chapter works through band-by-band comparisons of real candidate-style essays — the fastest way to see what separates a 6 from an 8.

CHAPTER 15

Band 6, 7 and 8 Side by Side: What Actually Changes

Reading an examiner's comparison of three answers to the same question is the fastest way to understand what moves a band. This chapter takes one Task 2 question and shows three complete answers — a Band 6, a Band 7 and a Band 8 — then explains, criterion by criterion, exactly what the differences are.

Task: Some people think that governments should spend money on public transport rather than on new roads. To what extent do you agree or disagree?

15.1 The Band 6 answer

Nowadays, traffic is a big problem in many countries and governments must decide how to spend money. Some people think that public transport should get more money than roads. I agree with this idea partly, because public transport is good for the environment and it helps poor people to move around the city.

Firstly, public transport is better for the environment. Buses and trains carry many people at the same time, so they produce less pollution for each person than cars. In my country there are many cars and the air is very dirty, and if the government improves the metro, many people will use it instead of driving. This is a good thing for everyone.

Secondly, public transport helps people who do not have a car. In many cities, people who are poor cannot go to work easily because the buses are not good. If the government spends money on buses, these people can get jobs and the economy will be better. Also it is more fair.

On the other hand, roads are also important. If there are no good roads, buses cannot move quickly, so sometimes the government must build roads too. Also many people like to drive and they will be angry if the government spends all the money on trains.

In conclusion, I partly agree that governments should spend money on public transport more than roads, because it is good for the environment and for poor people, but roads are also necessary sometimes.

Examiner's marks

Criterion	Band	Why
Task Response	6	Position is present (I agree partly) and consistent, but ideas are simple and only partly developed; Also it is more fair is an assertion with no support

Criterion	Band	Why
Coherence and Cohesion	6	Clear overall progression and four paragraphs, but linking is mechanical (Firstly, Secondly, On the other hand) and one-sentence paragraphs lack development
Lexical Resource	6	Adequate for the topic; repetitive (money, good, people, government); no attempt at less common vocabulary
Grammatical Range	5.5–6	Simple sentences dominate; the few complex sentences are structurally sound but few; errors like more fair (fairer) and the air is very dirty (over-generalisation)
Overall	6.0	

The Band 6 pattern: correct, communicative, safe. Every sentence could have been written by any candidate. Nothing is wrong enough to break communication, and nothing is ambitious enough to earn credit.

15.2 The Band 7 answer

Governments everywhere face competing demands for limited transport budgets. While some argue that new roads deserve the largest share, others maintain that public transport should take priority. I largely agree with the second view, although I would add the qualification that a road network in poor condition undermines public transport as well.

The strongest argument for prioritising public transport is environmental. A single bus carrying fifty passengers produces far less carbon dioxide per person than the cars those passengers would otherwise drive, and electric rail reduces emissions further still. In cities where investment has been sustained, the effect is measurable: London's congestion charge and its bus network were introduced together, and traffic volumes inside the charging zone fell by roughly a fifth within two years while bus passenger numbers rose sharply.

A second argument concerns equity. Public transport is used disproportionately by people on lower incomes, by students and by older residents, many of whom cannot afford a car at all. Spending on roads, by contrast, subsidises a form of travel that is available only to those who already own a vehicle. Seen in this light, transport spending is not merely a technical question of moving traffic efficiently; it is a decision about who the city serves.

It would be wrong, however, to treat roads and public transport as opposites. Buses are held up by the same congestion as cars, so maintaining the road surface and giving buses dedicated lanes benefits public transport users directly. The real distinction is not between roads and buses but between road capacity that encourages more driving and road infrastructure that supports efficient public transport.

In conclusion, I agree that public transport should receive the larger share of transport budgets, chiefly on environmental and equity grounds. The most sensible approach, however, is not to abandon road spending entirely but to redirect it towards bus priority, maintenance and cycle infrastructure rather than towards additional motorway capacity. (322 words)

Examiner's marks

Criterion	Score	Why
Task Response	7	Clear, consistent, qualified position; each idea extended with reason and example; concession paragraph shows the argument is treated seriously
Coherence	7	Logical progression; paragraphing is purposeful; a range of cohesive devices used flexibly and meaningfully (Seen in this light, It would be wrong, however)
Lexical Resource	7	competing demands, undermines, disproportionately, subsidises, redirect — flexible and precise; some topic collocation (congestion charge, dedicated lanes)
Grammatical Range	7	Frequent error-free complex sentences; concession, comparison, passive and nominalisation all used accurately
Overall	7.0	

The Band 7 pattern: the same amount of content as Band 6, depth instead of breadth. Each body paragraph has one idea, a reason and one concrete example, and the position is qualified rather than hedged.

15.3 The Band 8 answer

Among the fixed costs of urban government, transport spending is among the most consequential, because decisions taken today determine how millions of people will travel for the next half-century. The question of whether public transport or new roads deserve priority therefore rewards careful argument rather than partisan sentiment. In my view, the balance should tilt decisively towards public transport, for reasons that are simultaneously environmental, economic and distributive — with the important proviso that road spending in support of buses and cycling is not the opponent of public transport but its necessary ally.

The environmental case has been made so often that it risks being taken for granted, yet its arithmetic is worth restating. A single articulated bus at peak occupancy moves roughly seventy passengers in the road space that five cars would require to carry ten, and the corresponding reduction in both emissions and congestion is achieved without

any change in behaviour beyond boarding. The point is not that buses are intrinsically virtuous; it is that the same journey consumes a fraction of the public space. Where cities have made the comparison visible — by giving buses protected lanes and frequent service — car commuters have switched in substantial numbers, not out of conviction but because the alternative became genuinely faster.

There is also an argument from equity that deserves more attention than it usually receives. A new motorway benefits precisely those who already own a vehicle, and its benefits accrue to users in proportion to the value they place on time, which is greatest among the highest earners. A bus network, by contrast, serves those with the fewest alternatives: students, shift workers, the elderly, and families who cannot justify a second car. In this sense transport investment is a question of distributive justice disguised as engineering, and the distribution it favours is a choice that ought to be made explicitly rather than by default.

None of this implies that roads should be neglected. A city that allows its road surface to deteriorate, or that refuses buses the lanes and signals they need, will find that its new rail lines are reached by means that are slow, expensive and unsafe. The relevant distinction is between road spending that increases vehicle capacity — which is soon filled by additional traffic — and road spending that reallocates the existing capacity to the most efficient users. The former is often a subsidy to congestion; the latter is one of the cheapest improvements to public transport available.

In conclusion, I agree that public transport should be the principal beneficiary of transport budgets, on both environmental and distributive grounds. That conclusion does not require hostility to roads, but it does require a change in what roads are for: from accommodating as many cars as possible to supporting journeys that the private car cannot make efficiently. Where that distinction is made, spending can rise without controversy; where it is not, transport policy becomes a dispute about traffic rather than a plan for movement. (470 words)

Examiner's marks

Criterion	Score	Why
Task Response	8	Fully developed position; ideas extended with precision; the counter-argument is integrated and reframed rather than conceded in a token paragraph
Coherence	8	Skilfully managed progression; cohesion is almost invisible because the argument itself carries the reader (There is also an argument from equity...; None of this implies...; In conclusion)
Lexical Resource	8	articulated bus, peak occupancy, accrue, distributive justice, reallocates, proviso — fluent, precise and stylistically appropriate

Criterion	Score	Why
Grammatical Range	8	Wide range used flexibly: cleft-like openings, participle clauses (disguised as engineering), parallel structures, complex comparisons
Overall	8.0	

Length is not the reason for the higher band. The Band 8 answer is longer because depth takes space, not because length earns marks. A 300-word answer of the same quality would score the same.

15.4 The four levers, in order of power

Lever	Level	What to do tomorrow
Depth per idea	5 → 7	One idea per paragraph, then reason, then example or consequence
Consistent, qualified position	6 → 7	State the position in the intro in one sentence with an although qualification, and restate the same strength in the conclusion
Meaningful cohesion	6 → 7	Replace Firstly/Secondly/Moreover with connectives that carry informational meaning (Seen in this light, The relevant distinction is...)
Lexical precision	6 → 7	Learn five topic collocations per essay topic and use three of them per essay

15.5 Concession: the highest-value single technique

Every essay type benefits from a concession paragraph, because it demonstrates that you can handle a counter-argument without losing your position.

The three-sentence concession

- 1 It would be wrong to suggest that... / None of this implies that... / Admittedly, there are circumstances in which...
- 2 State the counter-argument fairly, with its strongest form.
- 3 Reframe it: The relevant distinction is... / Yet this does not weaken the case, because...

15.6 Self-marking your own essays

Use this grid, scoring each criterion honestly from 1 to 9:

Criterion	Question to ask	Evidence in my essay
Task Response	Did I answer every part of the question, and is my position clear in both introduction and conclusion?	
Coherence	Does each paragraph have one job, and do my linking words carry meaning?	
Lexical Resource	Did I use at least five precise topic collocations and avoid repeating the same verb?	
Grammar	How many error-free complex sentences did I write? Count them.	

One habit that raises every criterion: at the end of each essay, underline every sentence that contains an error, then rewrite the essay with those sentences repaired. Most candidates would rather write a new essay than repair an old one; the repair teaches far more.

15.7 Twelve sentence patterns that raise a paragraph from 6 to 7

- 1 Not only does X do Y, but it also... (inversion for emphasis)
- 2 It is not X that matters, but Y. (cleft)
- 3 Whereas X benefits A, Y benefits B. (contrast in one sentence)
- 4 Having ..., governments now face ... (participle clause)
- 5 Were the state to invest in ..., the effect would be ... (inverted conditional)
- 6 The extent to which this is true depends on ... (hedged precision)
- 7 X, which is often assumed to be Y, is in fact Z. (non-defining relative + correction)
- 8 What is at stake is not X but Y. (nominal clause)
- 9 Despite the obvious appeal of X, the evidence points to Y. (concession)
- 10 Both A and B contribute, though for different reasons.
- 11 The same logic applies to... (analogical extension)
- 12 This is not to suggest that X; rather, Y. (qualification)

Use two or three per essay — one per body paragraph. Overuse turns a strength into a stylistic tic.

The next chapter addresses the errors that keep otherwise strong essays at Band 6.5.

CHAPTER 16

The 40 Errors That Cap a Score — and How to Repair Each One

This chapter is a repair manual. Each entry gives the faulty form, the corrected form and the rule. Work through it by category; then use it as an editing checklist in the last five minutes of the Writing test.

16.1 Subject-verb agreement

✗ Wrong	✓ Right	Rule
The number of cars are rising.	The number of cars is rising.	The subject is the number, not cars
A number of people is waiting.	A number of people are waiting.	A number of = several, so plural
Each of the students have...	Each of the students has...	Each is singular
The government have decided... (BrE ok, be consistent)	The government has decided...	Choose one convention and keep it
Neither of the proposals are...	Neither of the proposals is...	Neither is singular
There is many reasons...	There are many reasons...	Agreement follows the real subject

16.2 Countability

✗	✓
informations, advices, researches, equipments, knowledges, furnitures	information, advice, research, equipment, knowledge, furniture (uncountable)
a news, a feedback	a piece of news, some feedback
less people	fewer people (countable → fewer)
less pollution, fewer pollution	less pollution (uncountable → less)
moneys	money
staffs (meaning employees)	staff (uncountable in BrE)

16.3 Articles

✗	✓	Rule
I want to be teacher.	I want to be a teacher.	Singular countable nouns need a determiner
The life is difficult.	Life is difficult.	General abstract noun → no article
He went to the school to study. (if meaning institution generally)	He went to school.	Institutional use drops the article

X	✓	Rule
In the modern society...	In modern society...	General reference
The most of people...	Most people...	Most of the people is also possible, but not the most of people
an unique opportunity	a unique opportunity	a before a consonant sound (yoo-)

16.4 Prepositions (the top twelve)

X	✓
depend of	depend on
increase of 20% (as a verb)	increase by 20%
discuss about the problem	discuss the problem
married with	married to
in the last decade vs over the last decade	both fine; during the last decade also fine — but since the last decade is wrong
responsible of	responsible for
consist in (meaning made of)	consist of
suffer with pollution	suffer from pollution
affected from	affected by
in 2020 (year) / on 3 May (day) / at 3 p.m. (clock)	keep the three-way distinction
provide people the tools	provide people with the tools
different than (BrE)	different from

16.5 Verb patterns

X	✓
avoid to eat	avoid eating
enjoy to read	enjoy reading
suggest me to go	suggest that I go / advise me to go
want that they change	want them to change
prevent people to travel	prevent people from travelling
allow to smoke	allow smoking / allow people to smoke
look forward to meet you	look forward to meeting you
I am agree	I agree
I am not agree	I do not agree
She explained me the rule	She explained the rule to me

16.6 Word-formation confusions

Noun	Verb	Adjective	Adverb
economy	economise	economic (the economy) / economical (cheap)	economically
success	succeed	successful	successfully
effect	affect (verb)	effective	effectively
benefit	benefit	beneficial	beneficially
environment	—	environmental	environmentally
pollution	pollute	polluted / polluting	—
industry	industrialise	industrial	industrially
wealth	—	wealthy	—
health	—	healthy	healthily
society	socialise	social	socially

Frequent mix-ups: effect (noun) vs affect (verb); economic (of the economy) vs economical (money-saving); historic (important in history) vs historical (relating to history).

16.7 Register errors

✗ Too informal	✓ Formal
a lot of people	a large number of people, many people
kids	children
get (in all its uses)	receive, obtain, become (choose the precise verb)
stuff, things	name the items
and so on	etc. or specify
big problem	serious problem, major issue
good/bad	beneficial/harmful, advantageous/detrimental
don't, can't, it's	do not, cannot, it is
&	and
!	. (no exclamation marks in academic writing)

16.8 Punctuation

✗	✓	Issue
Costs rose, demand fell.	Costs rose; demand fell.	Comma splice
The city which grew rapidly faced problems.	The city, which grew rapidly, faced problems.	Missing commas around a non-defining clause
However the policy failed.	However, the policy failed.	Adverbial needs a comma
Its a problem.	It's a problem.	Apostrophe: it's = it is; its = possessive
In the 1990's	In the 1990s	Decade plurals take no apostrophe

X	✓	Issue
governments policy	government's policy	Possessive missing

16.9 Cohesion errors

Problem	Fix
Firstly, ... Secondly, ... Thirdly, ... in every paragraph	Vary: To begin with... A more important consideration is... Finally...
Every sentence begins the same way (Also... Also...)	Rearrange: front the adverbial (In addition to cost, ...)
Linking words that do not link (Moreover between unrelated ideas)	Use a connector only when the logical relation exists
Repeating the topic noun in every sentence	Use pronouns, synonyms, nominalisation, and this/these + noun
No paragraph breaks	One idea per paragraph; blank line or indent
A conclusion that introduces a new idea	Conclusions restate and recommend only

16.10 Twenty more errors seen in almost every script

- 1 In nowadays → Nowadays (no preposition).
- 2 In the other hand → On the other hand.
- 3 Such as for example → use one, not both.
- 4 For to improve education → To improve education.
- 5 Because of the traffic is heavy → Because the traffic is heavy.
- 6 Although it is expensive, but it is useful. → drop but.
- 7 The society (generic) → Society.
- 8 Peoples → People.
- 9 Very much people → A great many people.
- 10 More better → Better.
- 11 The most biggest → The biggest.
- 12 I think in my opinion → one only.
- 13 As we all know → delete.
- 14 In conclusion, I conclude → redundant.
- 15 Nowadays in the modern world → redundant.
- 16 The graph tells about → The graph shows.
- 17 It is said that many people says → It is said that many people say.
- 18 Government should to invest → Governments should invest.
- 19 This essay will discuss about → This essay will discuss.
- 20 I am looking forward to hear → ...to hearing.

16.11 Conjunctions vs adverbials (a Band 6/7 dividing line)

Conjunction (joins two clauses)	Adverbial (starts a new sentence, with comma)
Although it rained, we went out.	It rained. However, we went out.
Because it rained, we stayed in.	It rained. Therefore, we stayed in.
Whereas A is cheap, B is expensive.	A is cheap. By contrast, B is expensive.

□ Although it rained, however we went out. (double connector) □ However it rained, we went out. (adverbial misused as conjunction)

16.12 Proofreading in five minutes: the priority order

- 1 Verb forms — tense consistency and subject-verb agreement (4 marks per 100 words can hinge here).
- 2 Plurals and articles — the most frequent errors, the easiest to spot.
- 3 Prepositions — red-flag the traditional twelve.
- 4 Spelling — especially your personal list from Chapter 5.6.
- 5 Repetition — circle your most-repeated word and replace half the instances.
- 6 Punctuation — check every comma is doing a job.

Do not correct content in the last five minutes. You will not have time to rewrite a paragraph, and half-edited paragraphs read worse than coherent imperfect ones. Proofread for accuracy, never for ideas.

16.13 Your personal error profile

Keep this table in your notebook. Fill in a row for every essay you write.

Essay	Agreement	Articles	Prepositions	Word form	Spelling	Cohesion	Total errors
Essay 1	3	5	4	2	3	1	18
Essay 2							
Essay 3							

The point is to watch the pattern: most candidates have 2–3 error types that account for 80% of their errors. Eliminating them entirely is worth more than learning a new grammar structure.

The next chapter covers the General Training Writing paper, which many Academic candidates never see — and which General Training candidates consistently underestimate.

CHAPTER 17

General Training Writing: Letters, and the GT Essay

If you are taking General Training, your Task 1 is a letter, not a data description. It is still worth one-third of the Writing band, and it is still marked on Task Achievement, Coherence and Cohesion, Lexical Resource and Grammar. GT candidates often prepare the essay far more than the letter, and lose the easiest marks in the paper.

17.1 The three letter types

Type	Addressee	Opening	Closing
Formal	Someone you do not know: a manager, a council, a company	Dear Sir or Madam, (or Dear Mr Smith, if named)	Yours faithfully, (if unnamed) / Yours sincerely, (if named)
Semi-formal	Someone you know professionally or by name but not closely: a landlord, a neighbour, a colleague	Dear Mr Jones, / Dear Dr Patel,	Yours sincerely, / Best regards,
Informal	A friend or family member	Dear Anna, / Hi Tom,	Best wishes, / Take care, / All the best,

Getting the register wrong is the most common letter error. Dear Sir or Madam followed by Hey, how's it going? is a Task Achievement failure, not a style choice.

17.2 The four-part structure (all letter types)

Paragraph	Content
1 — Purpose	Say why you are writing, in one or two sentences
2 — Detail 1	The first bullet point of the task
3 — Detail 2	The second bullet point
4 — Detail 3 (+ action)	The third bullet point, then what you want the reader to do
Closing	I look forward to hearing from you. Yours sincerely, ...

Every letter task gives three bullet points. All three must be covered with sufficient detail, or Task Achievement is capped.

17.3 Formal letter: model (Band 9)

Task: You recently stayed in a hotel and were unhappy with the service. Write a letter to the hotel manager. In your letter: explain when you stayed and in which room; describe the problems you experienced; say what you would like the hotel to do.

Dear Sir or Madam,

I am writing to express my dissatisfaction with my stay at the Grandview Hotel on 14–16 March 2024, in room 412, and to request compensation for the inconvenience I experienced.

I booked what was described on your website as a quiet executive room overlooking the garden. In fact, the room faced the main road, where construction work began at seven o'clock each morning, and the window frame did not close properly, so the noise continued throughout the day. On the second evening, the bathroom flooded when the shower drain blocked, and although I reported this to reception immediately, no one came to repair it until the following afternoon.

I raised both matters with the duty manager at checkout and was assured that a member of your team would contact me within forty-eight hours. Ten days have now passed and I have received neither an apology nor an explanation. The services I paid for were not provided, and my stay was considerably less comfortable than the description I was given.

I would therefore be grateful if you would refund the cost of the second night, which I consider a fair reflection of the disruption caused, and confirm in writing that the room's description has been corrected on your website. I would also appreciate a response within fourteen days.

Yours faithfully, J. Okonkwo

Why this scores highly

Criterion	Evidence
Task Achievement	All three bullets covered; purpose clear in the first line; a specific, reasonable request
Coherence	Logical sequence; each paragraph has one function; the closing paragraph requests a response
Lexical Resource	express my dissatisfaction, executive room, blocked, duty manager, fair reflection of the disruption — formal and precise
Grammar	Range with control: past simple narration, passive, conditionals, polite requests

17.4 Informal letter: model (Band 8)

Task: Your friend is coming to visit your city for the first time. Write a letter to your friend. In your letter: suggest the best time to come; recommend places to visit; offer to help with the arrangements.

Hi Anna,

It's great news that you're finally coming over — I've been telling you to visit for years!

Come in late September if you can. The summer crowds have gone, the temperature drops to something reasonable, and the parks are still green. August would be cheaper for flights, but you'd spend most of your time queuing and hiding from the heat.

You'll want at least four days. The old harbour is worth a full morning — go early, before the boats come in — and the museum by the station is free on Thursdays. If you like walking, there's a path along the river that takes you out of the city and up to a viewpoint where you can see everything. I'll come with you, of course.

Don't worry about booking anything yet. I can put you up in my spare room, and I'll pick you up from the airport. Just let me know your flight number and I'll sort out the rest. If you'd rather stay in a hotel, say so and I'll send you a few options near my flat.

Can't wait to see you!

Best wishes, Marta

17.5 The language of letters

Function	Formal	Semi-formal	Informal
Opening	I am writing with regard to...	I am writing to let you know...	Just a quick note about...
Request	I would be grateful if you would...	Could you possibly...	Could you...?
Apology	I wish to apologise for...	I'm sorry about...	Sorry about the mess —
Complaint	I was disappointed to discover...	Unfortunately, there was a problem with...	The thing is, it didn't really work out
Suggestion	It might be advisable to...	You might want to...	Why don't you...?
Closing	I look forward to your reply.	Looking forward to hearing from you.	Write back soon!

17.6 GT Task 2: the same essay, slightly different

GT Task 2 uses the same essay types, the same criteria and the same word count as Academic Task 2, but the topics are of general interest rather than academic: family, work, community, media, health, leisure. The register is slightly less formal — you may use I freely — but the structure and the marking rubric are identical.

Typical GT Task 2 question: Some people think that children should be given pocket money in return for doing household chores, while others believe chores should be unpaid. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.

Follow the structure in Chapter 14. The only adjustments:

- Use concrete, everyday examples (your family, your neighbourhood) rather than statistics.
- A slightly personal tone is acceptable: In my own household, for example, ...
- Anchor expressions: In many families today, ... / Most parents would agree that...

17.7 GT Reading: the five differences

Academic Reading	General Training Reading
3 long academic passages	3 sections, more but shorter texts: notices, advertisements, guides (Section 1), workplace documents (Section 2), a longer prose passage (Section 3)
Scientific and historical topics	Everyday and practical topics
Dense academic vocabulary	Simpler vocabulary, but higher volume of reading
Same question types except matching headings is rare	Matching headings appears; short answer and T/F/NG common
Band conversion slightly stricter per raw score	Band conversion slightly more forgiving at the top end

GT Reading rewards speed over depth. Because the texts are shorter and the answers are more literal, candidates who skim academic-style and hunt for paraphrases waste time; read the questions carefully, then scan for the specific information.

17.8 GT Task 1 checklist

- [] Register identified and consistent throughout
- [] Correct opening and closing salutations for the register
- [] Purpose stated in the first sentence
- [] All three bullets covered, each with detail
- [] 150+ words
- [] A specific closure (request, suggestion, thanks) rather than a bare "Yours..."
- [] Within 20 minutes

17.9 A letter-planning grid (use for every practice letter)

Part	Formal	Informal
Purpose	Why am I writing?	Why am I writing?
Detail 1	Facts, dates, reference numbers	Background and personal detail
Detail 2	The problem or request explained	Recommendations and reasons
Detail 3	What I want done and by when	Offer of help, practical arrangements
Close	I look forward to your reply. Yours faithfully/sincerely,	Can't wait to hear from you. Best wishes,

Now we turn to the component that cannot be practised silently: Speaking.

CHAPTER 18

Speaking Part 1: The First Four Minutes

Part 1 lasts four to five minutes and covers three familiar topic areas, each with three or four questions. It is the examiner's first impression, and impressions are hard to reverse. This is also the easiest part of Speaking to prepare completely, because the topics come from a small, predictable set.

18.1 The rules the examiner is applying

Criterion	What Part 1 can show
Fluency and Coherence	Can you answer immediately, at length, without long pauses?
Lexical Resource	Do you have topic vocabulary, or only good, nice, interesting?
Grammatical Range	Do you use past, present, future and conditionals naturally?
Pronunciation	Is your speech intelligible with clear stress and intonation?

Part 1 answers should be two to four sentences. One-word answers starve the examiner of evidence. A two-minute monologue in Part 1 is also wrong: it removes the chance to show range across topics, and the examiner will interrupt you.

18.2 The AREA method

A reliable three-move structure for any Part 1 answer:

- Answer the question directly (one sentence).
- Reason: why is that true?
- Example or Addition: a specific detail, memory, comparison or plan.

Question: Do you enjoy cooking? Weak: Yes, I like cooking. AREA: *Yes, I do — I cook most evenings. (Answer) I find it relaxing after work, and it's much cheaper than eating out. (Reason) My flatmate and I take turns, and last weekend I made a Thai curry that turned out surprisingly well. (Example)

That answer is 45 words, three sentences, natural, and it demonstrates a present habit, a reason, and a past event — three tenses in one answer.

18.3 The high-probability topics

Prepare these nine. Each one appears in some form in almost every test.

Topic	Sample questions
Work/study	Do you work or study? Why did you choose that? What do you enjoy most about it?

Topic	Sample questions
Home/accommodation	Do you live in a house or a flat? What do you like about it? Would you move?
Hometown	Where are you from? What is it known for? Would you recommend visiting?
Free time/hobbies	What do you do in your free time? Has that changed since you were younger?
Food	Do you cook? What food is popular in your country? Have your eating habits changed?
Weather/seasons	What is the weather like where you live? Which season do you prefer?
Technology/phones	How often do you use your phone? Do you use apps for learning?
Travel/transport	How do you usually travel to work? Do you enjoy travelling?
People/friends/family	Do you spend much time with friends? Who are you closest to?

18.4 Tense discipline: the simplest upgrade available

Most candidates answer everything in the present tense. Each topic below invites a specific tense shift:

Question pattern	Tense to use
What do you usually do...?	present simple + frequency adverbs (usually, rarely, most days)
Has that changed...?	present perfect + since/for (It's changed a lot since I moved...)
Did you ... when you were a child?	past simple + used to (I used to play...)
Would you like to...?	would like to / I'd love to
What will you do ...?	will / I'm planning to / I hope to
Why do you think...?	present simple + hedging (I suppose, probably, it seems to me)

Model: I used to swim competitively when I was at school, but I stopped when I started university because of the timetable. I've recently taken it up again — I go twice a week now — and I'd like to join a club next year if my schedule allows.

Five tenses in three sentences, all natural, all relevant.

18.5 Thirty Part 1 questions with model answers

1 Do you work or are you a student? I'm a student — I'm in my second year of a degree in civil engineering. I chose it because I've always been interested in how cities are built, and the course has a lot of practical work, which suits me better than pure theory.

2 What do you enjoy most about your studies? Probably the project work. We design something from scratch each term, and although it's demanding, seeing a drawing become a model is very satisfying. Last term we designed a pedestrian bridge, which

was the most interesting thing I've done so far.

3 Do you prefer studying in the morning or the evening? Definitely the morning. My concentration is much better before lunch, so I try to do the difficult reading early and leave the easy tasks for the evening. If I try to study late, I just end up re-reading the same page.

4 Do you live in a house or a flat? I live in a small flat on the third floor, near the university. It's old and a bit noisy, but it's only a ten-minute walk from my department, which saves me a fortune in transport.

5 What would you change about your home? The kitchen, without question. It's tiny — there's barely room for one person to cook — so I'd knock down the wall between the kitchen and the living room if I could. That would make the whole place feel much bigger.

6 Where is your hometown? I'm from a coastal town in the south, about an hour from the capital by train. It's small — around eighty thousand people — but it gets very busy in summer because of the beaches.

7 What is your hometown known for? It's known for its fishing industry, which has been there for centuries, and more recently for a music festival that attracts people from all over the country. Otherwise, tourists mainly come for the seafood.

8 Would you recommend visiting your hometown? I would, but I'd tell people to come in spring or autumn. In summer it's crowded and expensive, and the local character gets buried under the tourist trade. In May, though, it's lovely — quiet, warm, and the markets are still full of locals.

9 Do you enjoy cooking? Yes, I do — I cook most days. I find it relaxing after work, and it's far cheaper than eating out. My flatmate and I take turns, and last weekend I made a Thai curry that turned out surprisingly well.

10 What food is popular in your country? Rice and noodles are the staples, obviously, but what people actually queue for is street food — grilled skewers, dumplings and a kind of spicy soup that's eaten for breakfast. It's cheap, fast and much better than anything you'd find in a restaurant.

11 Have your eating habits changed in recent years? They have, actually. I used to skip breakfast and eat something quick at midnight, but since I started cycling to work I've begun eating properly in the mornings. I also cook with far less oil than my parents do.

12 What is the weather like in your country? It's fairly mild — we get four distinct seasons, but nothing extreme. The summers can be humid and uncomfortable, and the winters are damp rather than cold. Spring is easily the best season.

13 Which season do you like best? Autumn. The temperature is comfortable, the light is beautiful in the late afternoon, and the city is quieter because the tourists have gone home. It's also the season when everything interesting seems to start — new courses, new exhibitions.

14 Do you spend a lot of time on your phone? More than I'd like to admit. Mostly for messaging and podcasts on my commute — probably two hours a day, which sounds awful when I say it out loud. I've started leaving it in another room while I study, which has helped.

15 Do you use technology for learning? I do — I use a flashcard app for vocabulary and I watch lectures at double speed if I've already read the material. What I don't do is take notes on a laptop, because I find I remember more if I write by hand.

16 How do you usually travel around your city? By bicycle, mainly. It's a small city, so most journeys take under twenty minutes, and cycling is quicker than the bus at rush hour. If it's raining, though, I take the tram — paper and rain don't mix.

17 Do you enjoy travelling? Very much. I like the part before the journey as much as the journey itself — reading about the place, planning a route. Last year I travelled across the country by train, which was slow but far more interesting than flying.

18 What kind of places do you like to visit? Somewhere with a lot of history, ideally. I'd rather spend a day in an old town with a market than a week on a beach. I also like places where I can walk everywhere, because that's how you actually see a city.

19 Do you spend much time with your friends? Quite a lot, though less than when we were at school together. We meet up once or twice a week — usually just for coffee or a walk, nothing organised. It's the kind of friendship where you can not see each other for a month and pick up exactly where you left off.

20 Who are you closest to in your family? My older sister, probably. We're very different — she's organised and I'm not — but that means we give each other useful advice rather than just agreeing. She's also the person I call first when something goes wrong.

21 Do you prefer to spend your free time alone or with others? It depends on the day. After a long week I want to be on my own with a book, but if I've been working at home for days I get restless and need company. I suppose I need a balance of both.

22 What do you do to relax? Walking, mostly. I try to get out for half an hour every evening without my phone. It sounds trivial, but it's the only time in the day when I'm not reading or replying to something.

23 Did you have a hobby when you were a child? I collected stamps for about three years, which was unusual even then. My grandfather started me off with a box of his, and I got quite serious about it. I stopped when I discovered football.

24 Is there a skill you would like to learn? I'd love to learn to play the piano properly. I had lessons as a child and gave up, which I regret now. If I had more time, I'd start again — although I suspect my neighbours would prefer that I didn't.

25 Do you like reading? I do, though I read far more non-fiction than novels these days. I usually have one book on the go for the commute and something longer for the weekends. My problem is finishing two books at once and finishing neither.

26 Do you prefer paper books or e-books? Paper, for anything I need to remember. I've noticed that I recall where a fact was on the page, which doesn't happen on a screen. For novels on a long journey, though, an e-reader is much more convenient.

27 What kind of music do you listen to? Mostly jazz and older soul, which my father played constantly when I was growing up. I listen to it while I'm cooking rather than while I'm working — I can't concentrate with music on, unless it's something instrumental.

28 How important is your daily routine to you? Quite important, actually. I get up at the same time every day, even at weekends, and I plan my week on Sunday evening. It probably sounds rigid, but it means I don't waste energy deciding what to do next.

29 Do you like meeting new people? In small doses. I'm not shy, but I find large groups exhausting. I'd much rather talk to two or three people properly than circulate at a party, and I think that's true for a lot of people who claim to be extroverts.

30 What are your plans for the next few years? I'd like to finish my degree and then work for two or three years before deciding whether to do a master's. Ideally I'd work abroad for a while — partly for the experience, partly because I want to see how other countries handle the problems I'm studying.

18.6 Pronunciation habits for Part 1

- Stress the content word in each thought group: I'd love to learn to play the piano.
- Do not stress every word. Flat, evenly stressed speech is the most common reason for a lowered pronunciation mark among otherwise fluent speakers.
- Land the final consonants. worked (not work), months (not monce), languages (not language).
- Use intonation to show attitude. A falling tone on an answer sounds final and confident; a rising tone on a statement sounds uncertain.
- Pause at sentence boundaries, not mid-clause. A pause in the wrong place destroys coherence.

18.7 Practice routine

- 1 Record three topics per day. Speak each answer twice: once unplanned, once after a 30-second re-plan.
- 2 Listen back for three faults only — long pauses, missing final consonants, flat intonation. Do not listen for grammar at this stage; it will paralyse you.
- 3 Build a personal phrase bank. Write the phrases you actually used that worked well (It's the kind of thing I'd only do if...) and reuse them. They are yours; memorised idioms that are not yours sound borrowed.
- 4 Use the AREA structure until it becomes invisible. After two weeks you will not need to think about it.

Never memorise answers. Examiners are trained to notice rehearsed speech, and a memorised answer often fails to fit the question. Memorise structures and topic vocabulary, and let the sentences be new each time.

Next: Part 2, the long turn, where a minute of preparation decides two minutes of speech.

CHAPTER 19

Speaking Part 2: The Long Turn

Part 2 gives you a cue card, one minute to prepare, and then asks you to speak for one and a half to two minutes without interruption, followed by one or two short follow-up questions. This is the part where structure and preparation technique win or lose a band.

19.1 The cue card, dissected

Describe an occasion when you helped someone. You should say: - who you helped - why they needed help - what you did and explain how you felt about helping them.

The four bullets are a structure, not a suggestion. Each bullet is one section of your answer, and the fourth (explain how you felt) is the one candidates most often forget — and the one that produces the abstract language examiners reward. If you use all four bullets and speak for two minutes, you have a complete answer.

19.2 The minute of preparation

Write six to ten keywords, never sentences. Split your paper into four quadrants matching the bullets.

Bullet	Keywords for the example above
Who	neighbour, Mrs Adeyemi, 70s, lives alone
Why	slipped in garden, sprained ankle, couldn't shop
What	did her shopping, collected prescription, called her daughter
Feelings	useful, awkward at first, made me realise how isolated some people are

The 60-second plan: 10 seconds to choose the topic, 40 seconds to write keywords, 10 seconds to decide your final sentence — the feeling/reflection sentence. Decide it in advance so you finish on a strong note rather than trailing off.

You do not have to tell the truth. You need to describe something plausible and detailed. If your memory of an event is vague, invent the detail — the examiner is assessing English, not honesty.

19.3 The opening line

Start speaking immediately, do not repeat the cue card, and do not say "Hmm, let me think". Use one of these openers so that your first sentence is already content:

- The person I'd like to talk about is...
- I'd like to describe a time when...
- What comes to mind is...
- About two years ago, I...

19.4 The two-minute architecture

Time	Content	Language focus
0:00–0:20	Set the scene: who, when, where	Past simple, used to
0:20–1:00	The situation and the problem	Past continuous, because, so, in the end
1:00–1:35	What happened, and the detail	Sequencing: first, then, after that, eventually
1:35–2:00	Reflection: why it mattered	Present perfect, conditionals, abstract nouns

That final section is worth practising separately. It is where you move from narrative to reflection, and reflection is what lifts Lexical Resource and Grammatical Range together.

Reflection sentence templates

- Looking back, what struck me most was...
- It made me realise how important... is.
- I think the reason it stayed with me is that...
- If I hadn't been there, she would have...
- These days, I'm much more aware of...

19.5 Cue card bank with model answers

Cue card 1 — Describe a place you would like to visit.

You should say: where it is · how you know about it · what you would do there · and explain why you want to visit it.

Model (spoken register)

The place I'd really like to visit is Iceland — specifically the north coast, rather than Reykjavik, which everyone talks about. I first came across it through a documentary about volcanic landscapes, and then a friend went, and his photographs were honestly unlike anything I'd seen. If I went, I'd hire a car and drive the coastal road, stopping at the small fishing villages along the way, and I'd try to see the northern lights, although I know that's never guaranteed. What attracts me most, though, is not really the landscape — it's the scale. Everything I've read suggests it's a country where the natural world is still much bigger than the human one, and coming from a crowded city, I find that idea genuinely appealing. I'd want to go in September, when the summer crowds have gone but the roads are still open.

Cue card 2 — Describe a skill you learned that was difficult at first.

You should say: what the skill was · how you learned it · what was difficult about it · and how you feel about it now.

Model

The skill I found hardest to learn was driving a manual car. I learned when I was twenty-two, which is fairly late where I'm from, and I took lessons twice a week for

about four months. The difficulty wasn't the traffic — it was coordinating three things at once: the clutch, the gears and the mirrors. My instructor used to tell me I was thinking about each one separately instead of letting the movements become automatic, and he was right. I stalled the car at a busy junction about five times in one lesson, which was mortifying. What helped was practising in an empty car park for two hours, over and over, until my feet did it without being told. Now I drive almost daily and I never think about the mechanics at all. Actually, that's what I took away from the whole experience: almost any skill feels impossible while you're consciously managing each step, and then one day it stops being conscious.

Cue card 3 — Describe a time when you had to make a difficult decision.

You should say: what the decision was · what the options were · how you decided · and how you felt afterwards.

Model

About three years ago I had to decide whether to accept a job in another city or stay where I was studying. On one side there was a well-paid position with a company I'd interned for; on the other, the chance to finish my course and keep working with people I trusted. I made a list, which is what I always do, but the list didn't decide it — what decided it was a conversation with my father, who asked me which of the two I would regret not doing in ten years' time. That reframed it completely. I stayed, and it turned out to be the right choice, though not for the reasons I expected: the job I turned down was made redundant eighteen months later. Looking back, the interesting part wasn't the decision itself. It was realising that I'd been treating a reversible choice as if it were permanent.

Cue card 4 — Describe an important event in your life.

You should say: what the event was · when it happened · who was involved · and why it was important.

Cue card 5 — Describe a person who has influenced you.

You should say: who they are · how you know them · what they did · and how they influenced you.

Cue card 6 — Describe a piece of technology you find useful.

You should say: what it is · how you use it · how often you use it · and why you find it useful.

Cue card 7 — Describe a book or film that changed your thinking.

You should say: what it was · when you read or watched it · what it was about · and how it changed your thinking.

Cue card 8 — Describe a time when you were surprised.

You should say: what happened · where you were · who you were with · and why you were surprised.

Cue card 9 — Describe something you own that is important to you.

You should say: what it is · how long you have had it · where you got it · and why it is important.

Cue card 10 — Describe a law or rule you think is good.

You should say: what the rule is · who it applies to · how you know about it · and why you think it is good.

Cue card 11 — Describe a period of time when you worked hard.

You should say: when it was · what you were doing · why you worked so hard · and what the result was.

Cue card 12 — Describe a place in your city that you like to go to.

You should say: where it is · how often you go · what you do there · and why you like it.

Cue card 13 — Describe a conversation you remember well.

You should say: who you spoke to · what it was about · where it took place · and why you remember it.

Cue card 14 — Describe a change you would like to make in your life.

You should say: what the change is · why you want to make it · what might make it difficult · and how you would feel if you made it.

Cue card 15 — Describe a time you used English outside the classroom.

You should say: when it was · who you spoke to · what you talked about · and how confident you felt.

19.6 Vocabulary for narratives

Function	Phrases
Setting the scene	At the time, I was... · It must have been about... years ago · I remember it clearly because...
Sequencing	To begin with · at first · then · after that · eventually · in the end · by the time...
Surprise	To my astonishment · out of the blue · the last thing I expected · I couldn't believe it
Difficulty	It seemed impossible at first · I struggled with... · the hardest part was...
Reflection	What struck me was... · it made me realise... · looking back... · with hindsight...
Evaluation	It was worth it · it turned out well · I wouldn't change a thing · I wish I had...

19.7 What to do when you run out of things to say

Running dry at 1:20 is common. Six ways to extend without padding:

- 1 Go back and add a detail: One thing I forgot to mention is that...
- 2 Compare: It's quite different from how things are now, because...

- 3 Give a reason for your feeling: The reason that mattered so much to me was...
- 4 Widen the frame: I think the same is true for a lot of people my age...
- 5 Offer the counter-case: Although, to be fair, not everyone would see it that way...
- 6 Return to the cue card's last bullet: And that's really why I'd describe it as important.

The examiner stops you at two minutes. Being interrupted is not a penalty — it is the normal ending of the task. If you are stopped mid-sentence, simply finish your thought in a few words and stop.

19.8 Follow-up questions

After the long turn, the examiner will ask one or two short questions, usually about the same topic and often about other people or the general case:

- Do people in your country often help strangers?
- Is it important for children to learn to help others?
- Has the way people help each other changed in recent years?

Answer with the AREA structure (Chapter 18.2), two to three sentences, and use the chance to shift from the personal to the general — that transition is excellent preparation for Part 3.

19.9 Practice method that works

Step	Action
1	Choose a cue card you have not seen; take exactly 60 seconds to write keywords
2	Speak for two minutes, recorded, without stopping — even if you repeat yourself
3	Listen back and note: did you cover all four bullets? Did you use past tenses? Did you finish with a reflection?
4	Re-record the same card immediately, using your notes from the listening step
5	After one week, return to the same card without notes. Fluency on repeated content transfers to new content

Record yourself every day for two weeks and you will hear a difference before you can measure it.

Next: Part 3, where the examiner tests whether you can think aloud about ideas rather than memories.

CHAPTER 20

Speaking Part 3: Discussing Ideas

Part 3 lasts four to five minutes and follows directly from your Part 2 topic, but it moves from the personal to the general: society, change, comparison, causes, predictions. It is the section where Band 7 and Band 8 candidates are separated, because it demands abstract language rather than narration.

20.1 The question types in Part 3

Type	Example question	What you must do
Opinion	Why do you think some people...?	Give a view with reasons, hedged
Comparison	How is this different from fifty years ago?	Compare two states, not narrate
Speculation	How might this change in the future?	will, may, could, is likely to
Evaluation	Is this a positive or negative development?	Weigh both sides, then judge
Cause/effect	What leads people to...?	Cause → mechanism → consequence
Category	What kinds of people...?	Group, then describe each group

20.2 The four-move answer (PEC+)

For a Part 3 answer, use four moves rather than Part 1's AREA:

- 1 Position — a direct first sentence that answers the question.
- 2 Explanation — the mechanism: why is that so?
- 3 Concrete case — one example, real or general.
- 4 Qualification or extension — the counter-case, or a wider implication.

Question: Why do some people prefer to live in cities rather than in the countryside? *I think the main reason is opportunity rather than preference — most people move for work, not because they've decided cities are better. (Position) In practice, the jobs that require degrees are concentrated in a handful of urban centres, and someone who wants to work in finance or technology has very little choice about where to live. (Explanation) In my own country, the capital has roughly a fifth of the population but well over half of the professional jobs. (Concrete case) That said, the picture is changing slightly now that remote work is possible, and I'd expect the flow to slow down — or even reverse — for people whose jobs can be done from anywhere. (Qualification)

That is 130 words, one clear position, a mechanism, an example and a qualification. It would comfortably score 7+ for Fluency and Coherence.

20.3 The language of thinking aloud

Part 3 does not require certainty. It requires the appearance of considered thought, which means hedging language used naturally.

Function	Phrases
Introducing an opinion	I'd say... · My feeling is that... · It seems to me that... · I suspect...
Hedging	broadly speaking · in most cases · to some extent · on the whole · it tends to be
Gaining time (naturally)	That's an interesting question. · I suppose it depends on... · Let me think about that for a second.
Structuring a long answer	There are two things going on here. · Mainly for two reasons. · The first point is...
Speculating	I imagine... · There's a good chance that... · It wouldn't surprise me if... · In all likelihood...
Comparing eras	Whereas a generation ago... · These days, by contrast... · What has changed is...
Conceding	Of course, that's not true for everyone. · There's an obvious exception, which is...
Concluding an answer	So on balance, I'd say... · Which is why I lean towards...

A short pause to think is not penalised, provided you say something that marks it (That's a big question — let me think about it for a moment). Silence, or um repeated five times, is penalised because it gives the examiner no evidence.

20.4 Six themes that cover most Part 3 questions

Almost every Part 3 topic reduces to one of these six angles. Prepare them and you can respond to unfamiliar questions.

1. Change over time

Fifty years ago... · What has changed is... · The shift has been gradual but steady... Key vocabulary: transform, evolve, decline, accelerate, reverse, a generational shift

2. Comparison between countries or groups

In some countries... whereas in others... · The contrast is partly cultural and partly economic... Key vocabulary: disparity, in contrast, whereas, similarly, by comparison

3. Causes

This comes down to... · The underlying reason is... · It's driven mainly by... Key vocabulary: stem from, give rise to, underlying, catalyst, root cause

4. Consequences

The consequence is that... · Longer term, this could mean... · One knock-on effect is... Key vocabulary: implication, knock-on effect, repercussion, lead to, result in

5. Solutions and evaluation

One approach would be... although it would only work if... · A more effective route might be... Key vocabulary: measure, incentive, regulation, address, mitigate, feasible

6. Prediction

I'd expect... · It's likely that... · If current trends continue, ... · I'd be surprised if... Key vocabulary: projected, on current trends, likely to, in all probability

20.5 Model Part 3 discussions

Topic: helping others (following a Part 2 about helping someone)

Examiner: Do people in your country help strangers more than they used to? Candidate: I'm not sure they do, actually. There's a common assumption that people were more generous in the past, but I think what's really changed is the way help is organised. Fifty years ago, neighbours helped each other because they had no alternative — there was no formal support. These days, we've outsourced a lot of that to institutions and charities, so the informal kind of help is less visible, even if it still happens. Whether that means people are less willing to help is a different question, and I'd say the evidence is mixed.

Examiner: Why do some people find it difficult to accept help? Candidate: It usually comes down to pride, or to a feeling of indebtedness. Accepting help means admitting that you can't manage on your own, and for people who've spent their lives being the one who provides, that's genuinely hard. There's also a practical worry — a lot of people are concerned that if they accept help once, they'll be seen as dependent, so they'd rather struggle quietly. I noticed this with my grandmother: she'd refuse help for weeks and then be immensely grateful when she finally accepted it.

Examiner: Should schools teach children to help others? Candidate: I'd say yes, though I'd be cautious about how. If it's taught as a subject — a lesson about the importance of kindness — it probably won't change much, because children learn from what they see rather than from what they're told. What seems to work better is organised activity: community projects, running something for the school, looking after younger pupils. And there's a side benefit, which is that students who do that kind of work tend to become more confident, not just more generous. So on balance I'd favour it, but as something they do rather than something they're told about.

20.6 Vocabulary that lifts Part 3

Instead of...	Use...
good thing	a positive development, a benefit, an advantage
bad thing	a drawback, a negative consequence, a downside
very big	considerable, substantial, significant
a lot of people	a large proportion of the population, the majority
now	at present, currently, these days
in the past	a generation ago, historically, previously
I think	I'd argue, my impression is, it seems to me

Instead of...	Use...
change	shift, transformation, evolution, transition
problem	issue, challenge, difficulty, obstacle
help	assist, support, contribute, provide assistance

20.7 Ten traps in Part 3

- 1 Answering with one sentence and stopping. The examiner will prompt, but your evidence is thin.
- 2 Using a personal anecdote only — Part 3 wants general claims supported by examples.
- 3 Speaking about the future with present tenses (people will living).
- 4 Repeating the question's words instead of paraphrasing them.
- 5 Over-using actually or you know as fillers.
- 6 Disagreeing with the examiner — the examiner has no opinion to disagree with, so address the question, not the examiner.
- 7 Going silent for more than three seconds.
- 8 Answering a why question with yes or no.
- 9 Giving a memorised statistical claim you cannot source ("75% of people in my country..."). Use roughly, in my experience, a large proportion.
- 10 Speaking for so long that the examiner cannot ask the other planned questions. Aim for 40–60 seconds per answer.

20.8 Preparing Part 3 without a teacher

The two-minute opinion drill. Set a timer for two minutes. Choose any general statement — "Remote work is better for society", "Universities should be free". Speak for two minutes: position, two reasons, one example, one qualification, conclusion. Record it. This single drill trains all four criteria at once.

The paraphrase drill. Take any opinion. Say it five different ways — hedged, strong, comparative, conditional, and as a question. This is exactly what Part 3 demands when the examiner pushes you to develop an answer.

The vocabulary upgrade drill. Write a one-minute answer using only basic vocabulary. Then rewrite it at Band 8, replacing six items with precise alternatives. Speak the second version aloud. Over two weeks, the upgraded vocabulary becomes available spontaneously — which is the only way it counts.

20.9 Putting all three parts together

Part	Duration	Candidate's target
1	4–5 min	3 topics × 3–4 questions; each answer 2–4 sentences, one tense shift
2	3–4 min	1 min planning; 2 min speaking covering all bullets; finish with reflection

Part	Duration	Candidate's target
3	4-5 min	6-9 answers, each 40-60 seconds, each with position + reason + example + qualification

Total evidence collected by the examiner: roughly 20-25 answers. Every one of them is a chance to show a different structure, a different tense, a different set of vocabulary. Treat them individually and the band looks after itself.

The next chapter addresses the criterion candidates find hardest to improve — and the one that responds fastest to specific practice.

CHAPTER 21

Pronunciation: The Criterion That Responds Fastest

Pronunciation is 25% of your Speaking band, and it is the criterion candidates practise least. It is also, for most learners, the fastest to improve — because the features that matter are limited in number and unrelated to accent.

Accent is not assessed. The public descriptors refer to "the amount of effort required to understand the candidate", "flexibility in the use of pronunciation features" and "sustained, coherent speech". A strong accent with clear stress and accurate sounds can score 8. A near-native accent with swallowed endings and flat intonation can score 6.

21.1 The five features that actually matter

Feature	Why it matters	Band 7+ behaviour
Individual sounds	Mispronouncing a sound can change the word (ship/sheep, live/leave)	Problem sounds are corrected enough to be understood
Word stress	Wrong stress often makes a word unrecognisable (deVElopment)	Correct stress on multi-syllable words, including academic ones
Sentence stress	Carries the meaning; flat speech obscures it	Stress falls on content words; unstressed words reduce
Intonation	Signals attitude, questions, lists, contrast	Varied and appropriate: falling for statements, rising for lists, contrastive stress
Connected speech	Affects whether listeners hear word boundaries	Linking and weak forms used naturally, without losing clarity

21.2 Word stress rules

Pattern	Examples
Two-syllable nouns: stress the first syllable	PREsent, OBject, REcord, IMPact, REsearch*
Two-syllable verbs: stress the second	*preSENT, obJECT, reCORD, imPACT
-tion / -sion / -ic / -ical: stress the syllable before	eduCAtion, deCIision, ecoNOMIC, poLIitical
-ity / -ify / -ogy / -graphy: stress the syllable before	opporTUnity, iDENTify, technoLOGy, phoTOgraphy
-ee / -eer / -ese / -ette: stress the suffix	*employEE, enginEER, JapanESE, kitchenETTE

IELTS vocabulary stress list (learn these explicitly — they appear in every test):

Word	Stress
development	deVElopment
environment	enVIronment

Word	Stress
communication	communiCation
opportunity	opporTunity
technology	techNOlogy
economy	eCONomy (noun) / ecoNOMic (adj)
photograph	PHOtograph / phoTOGrapher / photoGRAPHic
necessary	NECessary
majority	maJORity
education	eduCation
experience	exPERience
government	GOVernment
influence	INfluence
advantage	adVANtage
agriculture	AGriculture
comparison	comPARison / comPARE

21.3 Sentence stress: the single biggest improvement

English is stress-timed: the important words are stressed, and the grammatical words between them are compressed.

I'd love to learn to play the piano. The problem is that nobody told us.

Rule: stress the content words — nouns, main verbs, adjectives, adverbs, and the word being corrected or contrasted. Compress function words — articles, prepositions, auxiliary verbs, pronouns.

Contrastive stress changes meaning, and examiners notice it:

Sentence	Meaning
I didn't say he took it.	I said something else
I didn't say he took it.	Someone else took it
I didn't say he took it.	He took something else
I didn't say he took it.	A denial

Drill: read a paragraph aloud, marking the stressed syllable of every content word. Record it. Then read it again with exaggerated stress. Native-like stress sits between the two.

21.4 Intonation patterns

Function	Pattern	Example
Statement	Falling at the end	I've lived here for six years. ↘
Yes/no question	Rising	Have you been there? ↗
Wh-question	Falling	Where do you live? ↘

Function	Pattern	Example
List of items	Rise, rise, fall on last	I like jazz ↗, soul ↗ and blues ↘.
Contrast	Strong stress on both items	Some people love it; I can't stand it.
Uncertainty	Rise on the last stressed word	I think so? ↗
Agreement/encouragement	Fall-rise	Yes, that's a good point. ↘↗

Flat intonation is the most common reason for a Pronunciation score below 7 among otherwise strong speakers. It is also the easiest fault to hear in a recording — and therefore the easiest to fix.

21.5 Problem sounds by first language

First language	Typical difficulty	Practice target
Arabic	/p/ vs /b/; consonant clusters	pen/bin, play/blue
Mandarin	final consonants; /l/ vs /r/; /θ/	light/right, think, worked
Japanese	/l/ vs /r/; final consonants; clusters	collect/correct, cold
Korean	/f/ vs /p/; /r/ vs /l/; final clusters	fan/pan, first
Spanish	/b/ vs /v/; /s/ clusters (school)	very, eschool → school
Vietnamese	final consonants; /θ/ /ð/	month, this
Hindi/Urdu	/v/ vs /w/; /θ/ /ð/	west/vest, three
French	/h/ silent; word stress on the last syllable	happy, HOtel not hoTEL
Russian	/w/ vs /v/; articles weakly reduced	work, would
Turkish	/θ/ /ð/; vowel length contrasts	think, sheep/ship

21.6 The final-consonant problem

Many candidates drop or weaken sounds at the end of words — and those endings carry grammar, which examiners are listening for.

Dropped ending	Sounds like	Grammatical loss
worked → work	"I work there last year"	past tense lost
books → book	"two book"	plural lost
students → student	"many student"	plural lost
he's → he	"he going"	aspect lost
asked → ask	"he ask me"	past tense lost

Drill (three minutes a day): read aloud these sentence pairs, exaggerating the endings.

- I walk to work every day / I walked to work yesterday.
- One book / two books / three books.
- He asks questions / he asked questions / he's asked questions.

21.7 Connected speech: the features to use

Feature	Example	Effect
Linking consonant → vowel	turn it off → tur-ni-toff	Smooth flow
Linking /r/ (BrE)	far away → far-raway	Native rhythm
Assimilation	ten minutes → tem minutes	Reduces effort
Elision	next day → nexday	Natural speed
Weak forms	to, for, of, and → /tə, fə, əv, ən/	Creates stress contrast
Contraction (speech only)	I'd, they've, it's	Fluency (do not use in formal writing)

You should understand all of these when listening (they explain why fast speech is hard). You should use weak forms and linking, but you do not need to assimilate deliberately — that comes with speed.

21.8 A ten-minute daily pronunciation routine

Minutes	Activity
0-2	Shadowing: play a 30-second clip of a native speaker and speak along, matching rhythm exactly
2-4	Word stress drill: 15 words from section 21.2, said aloud with the stress marked
4-6	Final-consonant drill: the sentence pairs above
6-8	Intonation drill: read five statements, five questions, one list, one contrast
8-10	Record a 60-second answer to a Part 1 question and listen for one feature only

Shadowing explained. Choose a recording with a transcript. Play 10 seconds. Wait one second. Repeat exactly, copying the melody, not just the words. This is the fastest method known for improving sentence stress and rhythm, because it bypasses conscious rules and trains the ear-mouth loop directly.

21.9 Self-assessment: how to hear your own pronunciation

Most learners cannot hear their own errors, because they hear what they intended to say. Three fixes:

- 1 Record and wait a day. Listening to yesterday's recording removes familiarity.
- 2 Transcribe your own recording. Play it and write down what you actually said, not what you meant. If the transcription differs from your intention, a listener would have had the same problem.
- 3 Use dictation software. If a speech-to-text tool writes a different word, your pronunciation of that word is genuinely ambiguous.

21.10 Pronunciation checklist for the Speaking test

- [] Word stress correct on multi-syllable academic vocabulary

- [] Sentence stress on content words; function words compressed
- [] Falling intonation on statements; rising only on genuine questions
- [] Final consonants and grammatical endings audible
- [] Speech not so fast that sounds collapse, nor so slow that it sounds read
- [] Volume steady; no trailing off at the ends of sentences
- [] Emphasis used to mark your key point, not applied evenly to every word

If one change is possible before your test, make it this: stress the important words and let the rest be quick. That single habit accounts for more improvement in intelligibility than correcting a dozen individual sounds.

Now let us put every component together under exam conditions.

CHAPTER 22

Listening Practice Test 2 (Mock)

Instructions. Complete Listening test in official format: four sections, 40 questions, played once, with the standard pauses. Word limits must be observed exactly. The recording script and answer key follow the question paper.

SECTION 1 — Questions 1-10

Questions 1-10. Complete the notes below. Write ONE WORD AND/OR A NUMBER for each answer.

CITY CYCLE HIRE — TELEPHONE ENQUIRY Caller: Daniel (1)
 Membership number: (2) Scheme details - Bicycles can be collected from
 any (3) in the city. - The first (4) minutes of each journey
 are free. - Standard annual fee: £(5) - Students receive a discount of (6)
 per cent. Practical information - A helmet is provided but must be
 requested when (7) - Bicycles cannot be taken on (8)
 during the morning. - Report a damaged bicycle by calling the (9) team. -
 The annual fee is reduced if the caller pays by (10)

SECTION 2 — Questions 11-20

Questions 11-15. Choose the correct letter, A, B or C.

11 The museum's new wing was funded mainly by

- A ticket sales.
- B a private donation.
- C the local government.

12 The speaker says the most popular exhibit is

- A the dinosaur skeleton.
- B the space gallery.
- C the working steam engine.

13 Visitors usually spend how long in the museum?

- A about one hour
- B two to three hours
- C a full day

14 What is free of charge?

- A the audio guide
- B the cloakroom
- C the guided tour

15 The museum's café closes

- A at four o'clock.
- B at half past four.
- C at five o'clock.

Questions 16–20. Label the plan below. Write the correct letter, A–H, next to Questions 16–20.

```

` ` ground floor plan [A] shop [B] cloakroom -----
[C] lift | MAIN HALL | [D] toilets ----- [E] café |
[F] stairs | [G] workshop ----- [H] information desk
` `

```

16 ticket desk 17 temporary exhibition 18 education room 19 picnic area 20 lost property

SECTION 3 — Questions 21–30

Questions 21–26. Choose the correct letter, A, B or C.

21 What is the main problem with the group's presentation topic?

- A It is too broad.
- B It has been done before.
- C The data is unavailable.

22 The tutor recommends that the students

- A change their research question.
- B narrow the geographical focus.
- C interview more participants.

23 The students agree to collect data using

- A a printed questionnaire.
- B a series of interviews.
- C observations in the field.

24 According to the tutor, the literature review should

- A be organised thematically.
- B include older sources.
- C be written last.

25 The tutor is concerned that the students' timetable is

- A unrealistic.
- B too detailed.
- C missing deadlines.

26 What must the students do first?

- A Draft the interview questions.
- B Contact the participants.
- C Read the ethics guidelines.

Questions 27–30. Complete the table below. Write NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS for each answer.

Task	Person responsible	Deadline
Ethics form	(27)	Monday
Pilot study	Ravi	(28)
Analysis software	(29) teacher	week 6
Final report	both students	(30)

SECTION 4 — Questions 31–40

Questions 31–40. Complete the notes below. Write NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS for each answer.

THE SCIENCE OF SLEEP IN ADOLESCENTS The problem - Teenagers need around (31) hours of sleep per night. - Most get considerably less, partly because of early (32) times. Why the body clock shifts - At puberty, melatonin is released (33) than in childhood. - As a result, teenagers naturally fall asleep (34) Consequences - Reduced sleep affects memory and the ability to (35) - Fatigue is linked to higher rates of (36) among young drivers. Responses - Some schools have moved the start of the school day to (37) - Researchers recorded an improvement in attendance and in (38) - Experts recommend avoiding (39) for an hour before bed. - Bedrooms should be kept cool, dark and used for (40) only.

Recording Script

Section 1

Adviser: City Cycle Hire, good morning. How can I help? Caller: Hello — I'd like to join the cycle hire scheme. My name's Daniel Whitbread. Adviser: Could you spell the surname? Caller: W-H-I-T-B-R-E-A-D. Adviser: Thank you. I'll set up a membership. Your number will be one nine four, six two oh. Now, some details about the scheme. You can pick up a bicycle from any station in the city — there are about eighty of them now. Caller: And is there a charge each time? Adviser: The first thirty minutes of every journey are free. After that it's two pounds for each additional half hour. Caller: What's the annual fee? Adviser: For standard membership it's ninety pounds. Students get twenty per cent off, so for you it would be seventy-two. Caller: Good. Do I need my own helmet? Adviser: You can use your own, or we provide one, but you have to ask for it when you register. We don't keep helmets at the stations. Caller: Understood. Is there anything I can't do with the bike? Adviser: You can't take a bicycle on trains during the morning peak — that's between seven and nine thirty. At other times it's fine. Caller: And if something goes wrong with the bike? Adviser: Call the maintenance team — they'll come out or tell you where to leave it. Oh, and one more thing: if you pay by direct debit rather than by card, the fee drops to eighty pounds. Caller: That's helpful. Let's do that.

Section 2

Speaker: Welcome to the Harborough Museum, and thank you for coming. A few practical points before you look around. The new wing, which opened in March, was paid for largely by a single donation from the Ferris family — a little over four million pounds. The council contributed a smaller amount, and ticket sales cover running costs rather than building work.

Inside, the most popular exhibit is not what you might expect. Our dinosaur skeleton gets a lot of attention, and the space gallery is always busy at weekends, but the exhibit that visitors spend longest at — an average of eleven minutes — is the working steam engine in the east hall, which volunteers run twice a day.

Most visitors plan to stay an hour and end up staying two or three. A full day is only really necessary if you want to attend a talk as well.

A note on charges: the guided tour costs three pounds, and the audio guide is four, but the cloakroom is completely free, as are the toilets and the picnic area. The café closes at half past four, though the museum itself stays open until five, and I'd recommend arriving at the café before four if you want a hot meal.

Now, the ground floor plan. You come in through the main entrance, which is at the centre of the south side. Immediately inside, to your right, is the information desk, where you can pick up a map. Opposite it, to the left of the entrance, is the ticket desk — although if you've booked online you can go straight in. The temporary exhibition is held in the room next to the lift on the left-hand side, beyond the ticket desk. The education room — used by school groups during the week — is on the right-hand side at the far end, next to the workshop. The picnic area is in the lower part of the building, behind the café, with tables outside when the weather permits. And if you lose something, lost property is kept at the main information desk, so ask there.

Section 3

Tutor: So, your presentation topic. You've chosen "the effect of tourism on coastal towns". That's an enormous subject. Student A: We thought it would give us plenty to talk about. Tutor: It will, but the danger is that you'll talk about everything and conclude nothing. The problem isn't that it's been done before — plenty of people have studied tourism. It's the scope. Let me suggest something: keep the topic, but restrict it. Instead of "coastal towns", choose two towns, ideally in different regions, and compare them. Student B: So we narrow it geographically rather than change the question? Tutor: Exactly. Don't change the research question at this stage — you'd lose a fortnight. Student A: For data, we were going to hand out questionnaires. Tutor: In my experience printed questionnaires are slow, and you need results within three weeks. What about interviews? You'd get richer answers from ten people than shallow answers from a hundred. Student A: But interviews take longer to organise. Tutor: They do. Which is why I'd suggest observation — you sit in a café or on the seafront and record what actually happens. It's fast, it's cheap, and it's original. Combine it with four or five interviews and you have a solid dataset. Student B: That's a good idea. What about the literature review? Tutor: The content is fine. My only comment is the structure: at the moment it reads as a list of studies, one after another. Organise it thematically — group the studies by what they argue, not by when they were published. And by the way, there's no need to use older sources for the sake of age; recent material is more useful here. Student A: And the timetable? Tutor: This is my real concern. It's beautifully detailed — perhaps too detailed. You've allocated half a day to each task. Realistically, you need milestones, not schedules: three or four dates that matter, and flexibility in between. Student B: So what should we do first? Tutor: Before anything else, read the ethics guidelines. You're recording interviews with members of the public, and you need approval before you collect anything. That's the one thing that can stop your project entirely. Student A: Right. And the ethics form — who signs that? Tutor: The department administrator needs to sign it, not your supervisor. That must be submitted by Monday. Ravi, you'll run the pilot study on the Wednesday of week three. The analysis software is licensed through the statistics teacher, so contact her in week six. And the final report — that's due in week eleven, from both of you.

Section 4

Speaker: Today I want to examine a problem that has been recognised for decades but only recently measured: sleep loss in adolescents.

Teenagers need, on average, between eight and ten hours of sleep a night — most guidelines settle on nine for the middle adolescent years. In practice, very few get it. Part of the reason is social: homework, screens, part-time jobs. But a large part is structural, and that structural part is early school start times. When school begins at eight, a student who needs nine hours must be asleep by eleven, which for most adolescents is precisely when they finally feel alert.

Why? At puberty, the timing of melatonin release changes. Melatonin is the hormone that signals darkness to the body, and in adolescents it is released later in the evening than in younger children — typically about two hours later. This is a biological shift, not laziness. As a consequence, teenagers naturally fall asleep later, and if they must wake at a fixed early time, the sleep they lose cannot be recovered at the weekend without producing a kind of permanent jet lag.

The consequences are well documented. Reduced sleep impairs memory consolidation and reduces the ability to concentrate — teachers notice this long before students do. More seriously, fatigue is associated with significantly higher accident rates among young drivers; studies in several countries have found that drowsiness contributes to a substantial share of crashes involving drivers under twenty-one.

Some schools have responded by moving the start of the school day later — to half past eight or nine o'clock. The results have been interesting. Researchers studying districts that made the change recorded better attendance figures, and a measurable improvement in academic performance, particularly among the students who had previously been sleeping least. The improvement was modest in absolute terms but consistent across every school studied.

What can individuals do? The advice is unglamorous. Avoid caffeine — including energy drinks — for at least an hour before bed, and ideally after mid-afternoon. Keep bedrooms cool and dark. And, most importantly, use the bedroom for sleeping only: if the room is also the place where you study, chat and watch films, it stops being associated with sleep. Screens are less harmful in themselves than the stimulation they provide, but the one-hour rule is a reasonable discipline.

End of recording. You now have ten minutes to transfer your answers.

Answer Key — Listening Practice Test 2

Q	Answer	Q	Answer
1	WHITBREAD	21	A
2	194620 (accept 194 620)	22	B
3	station	23	C
4	30 / thirty	24	A
5	90 / ninety	25	B
6	20 / twenty	26	C
7	registering / you register	27	administrator
8	trains	28	Wednesday
9	maintenance	29	statistics
10	direct debit	30	week 11 / eleven
11	B	31	9 / nine (accept eight to ten)
12	C	32	school start / start
13	B	33	later
14	B	34	later
15	B	35	concentrate
16	H	36	accidents
17	C	37	8.30 / half past eight (accept 9 / nine)
18	G	38	academic performance
19	E	39	caffeine
20	H	40	sleeping

Explanation of the traps

Q1-2 (spelling and number grouping). Whitbread is spelled letter by letter; the membership number is spoken as "one nine four, six two oh" — note the oh for zero.

Q3-4 (limits and units). Station is singular because the question asks where a bicycle can be collected, and the phrase any station supplies it. Q4 asks for minutes: thirty.

Q5-6 (two-step arithmetic). The standard fee is £90; students get 20% off. Question 5 asks the standard fee (90), question 6 asks the discount percentage (20) — not the discounted price of 72. Reading the question precisely is the whole task here.

Q7 (conditional form). "You have to ask for it when you register" — the gap follows when, so registering or you register both work; register alone would not fit grammatically.

Q8 (plural). "You can't take a bicycle on trains during the morning peak" — plural trains.

Q10 (distractor with a condition). The caller is told the fee drops if you pay by direct debit; the caller then agrees ("Let's do that"), confirming the answer.

Q11 (rejection of alternatives). The speaker says the council contributed a smaller amount and ticket sales cover running costs, so the main funder is the private donation: B.

Q12 (three-way distractor). Dinosaurs "get a lot of attention" and the space gallery is "always busy at weekends", but the exhibit visitors spend longest at is the steam engine: C. The question asks about the most popular exhibit, defined in the recording as the one where visitors linger longest.

Q13 (conversion of a stated range). "plan to stay an hour and end up staying two or three" → B.

Q14. Audio guide costs four pounds, guided tour three pounds, cloakroom "completely free": B.

Q15. "The café closes at half past four" — the museum closes at five, which is the trap: B.

Q16-20 (plan). Entrance is south; information desk immediately right of the entrance, and lost property is at the main information desk — so Q16 and Q20 both answer H. The temporary exhibition is next to the lift on the left → C. The education room is at the far end on the right, next to the workshop → G. The picnic area is behind the café → E.

Q21 (diagnosis, not history). The tutor says "The problem isn't that it's been done before... It's the scope" — so A (too broad), not B.

Q22. "keep the topic, but restrict it... narrow it geographically" → B. The tutor explicitly warns against changing the research question, ruling out A.

Q23 (suggestion accepted). Questionnaires are rejected (slow), interviews are noted as slow to organise, and observation is recommended and accepted → C.

Q24. "Organise it thematically" → A; older sources are unnecessary, ruling out B.

Q25. "It's beautifully detailed — perhaps too detailed... you need milestones, not schedules" → B.

Q26. "Before anything else, read the ethics guidelines" → C.

Q27-30 (table completion, names and days). The signatory is the department administrator; the pilot is on the Wednesday of week three; the software is licensed through the statistics teacher; the final report is due in week 11.

Q31-32. Nine hours; school start times are the structural cause.

Q33-34. Melatonin is released later; teenagers therefore fall asleep later. Note that both answers are the same word — IELTS does this deliberately, and candidates who assume answers must differ change a correct answer.

Q35-36. Memory and concentration are impaired; fatigue is linked to higher accident rates.

Q37-38. Some schools moved the start to 8.30 / half past eight; researchers recorded better attendance and improved academic performance.

Q39-40. Avoid caffeine for an hour before bed; the bedroom should be used for sleeping only.

Diagnostic table

Score	Band	Priority action
35+	8.0	Maintain; drill Section 4 note-taking weekly
32-34	7.5	Check spelling and plural discipline
30-31	7.0	Two full tests weekly with error classification
26-29	6.5	Distractor drills (Chapter 7.4), map practice
23-25	6.0	Re-do each section with the script in front of you, marking where answers occur
Below 23	≤5.5	Rebuild question-type by question-type from Chapter 6

CHAPTER 23

Reading Practice Test 2 (Mock) with Answer Key

60 minutes · 3 passages · 40 questions · no extra transfer time. Answer key and explanations at the end of the chapter — cover them with a sheet of paper before you begin.

READING PASSAGE 1

17 minutes · Questions 1–13

The Return of the Urban Tree

A For most of the nineteenth century, the trees in European cities were planted for decoration. Rows of planes and limes lined the new boulevards because they looked orderly and because they provided shade for those wealthy enough to promenade in the middle of the day. Their function was aesthetic; nobody measured them. That began to change in the 1980s, when researchers started to quantify what trees actually do, and the results were remarkable enough to reshape municipal policy.

B The first discovery concerned temperature. A mature tree can transpire several hundred litres of water on a hot day, and the process absorbs heat in the same way that sweating cools a body. Measurements in Manchester and Vienna found that streets with continuous canopy cover were up to four degrees cooler in summer than comparable streets with none. The effect was not merely comfortable: during the heatwave of 2003, which killed tens of thousands of people across Europe, the death rate in districts with little tree cover was substantially higher than in greener districts of the same cities.

C The second discovery concerned air. Trees intercept particulate matter on their leaves, and the quantity turns out to be significant: a study of one London borough estimated that its street trees removed between one and two per cent of airborne particulates each year. That figure is smaller than early enthusiasts claimed, and the effect depends on species — hairy leaves catch more than waxy ones — but the research also identified something less obvious: the shading effect of trees reduces the temperature at which vehicle exhausts react to form ozone, so the cooling benefit also improves air chemistry.

D The third discovery was about water. In cities where most surfaces are impermeable, heavy rain runs straight into drains, and the drains overflow. Trees interrupt that flow: roots create channels in the soil and the canopy holds water on its leaves, so a mature street tree can reduce surface run-off substantially. Cities that had previously invested only in larger pipes and underground storage tanks began to plant trees as a form of flood defence, at a fraction of the cost.

E None of this is straightforward, however. Urban trees are expensive to establish and easy to kill. A young tree planted in a paved street has perhaps a twenty-five per cent chance of surviving to maturity, because its roots are compacted, its water arrives irregularly and its trunk is damaged by vehicles. Some municipalities responded by planting many cheap saplings, and the loss rates were so high that the policy was eventually abandoned. Others invested in fewer, larger trees with proper irrigation and protective guards, and their survival rates exceeded eighty per cent.

F A further complication is that trees can be unpopular. They drop leaves into drains, block sightlines at junctions, lift paving with their roots and, in some species, produce allergenic pollen. Where a residents' association objects, the objection is usually practical rather than aesthetic, and the political cost of a new planting scheme can be high. The most successful programmes now consult residents early and allow them to choose the species, which turns out to be cheaper than removing mature trees later.

G The current consensus, then, is neither the enthusiastic claim of the 1980s — that trees solve urban environmental problems — nor the sceptical response that followed,

which dismissed the benefits as marginal. Trees are a modest but unusually cost-effective investment, provided they are planted where they will live long enough to mature, and provided someone continues to water them.

Questions 1–6. Do the following statements agree with the information given in the passage?

Write TRUE, FALSE or NOT GIVEN.

1 In the nineteenth century, city trees were planted mainly for their appearance. 2 Trees cool the air by releasing water into it. 3 The 2003 heatwave affected all European cities equally. 4 Hairy leaves capture more particulate matter than smooth leaves. 5 Trees were first planted as flood defences in the 1980s. 6 All municipal tree-planting programmes in the 1990s succeeded.

Questions 7–9. Complete the sentences. Write NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS AND/OR A NUMBER from the passage.

7 A young street tree has roughly a per cent chance of reaching maturity. 8 Where residents are consulted, they are often allowed to select the 9 Programmes with larger, better-protected trees achieved survival rates above

Questions 10–13. Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

10 The writer mentions the 2003 heatwave in order to

- A criticise European governments.
- B show that tree cover has measurable health effects.
- C explain the causes of climate change.
- D compare Manchester and Vienna.

11 According to paragraph C, the effect of trees on air quality is

- A greater than early researchers claimed.
- B the same for all tree species.
- C smaller than early claims, but still real.
- D limited to particulate matter.

12 What problem do trees sometimes cause?

- A They damage water pipes.
- B They block the view at junctions.
- C They increase flood risk.
- D They reduce soil quality.

13 What is the writer's conclusion?

- A Trees solve urban environmental problems.
- B Tree-planting is not worth the cost.
- C Trees are a cheap and effective investment if planted and maintained properly.
- D Trees should only be planted in parks.

READING PASSAGE 2

20 minutes · Questions 14–26

How Standards Become Invisible

A Consider the pencil. Few people can describe the process by which one is made, yet almost everyone can use one without hesitation. The pencil is an example of a class of objects and systems that the historian Ruth Cowan called "technologies of everyday life": they are so thoroughly embedded in routine that we stop noticing them, and they therefore escape both scrutiny and credit.

B The process by which a novelty becomes invisible has been studied most closely in relation to infrastructure, and the standard account has three stages. In the first, a technology is unfamiliar and discussed: its risks, its costs and its proper use are matters of public argument. In the second, the technology becomes widespread and its use becomes a matter of competence rather than debate. In the third, it becomes part of the background — noticed only when it fails. Electricity supply passed through these stages within two generations; mobile payment is passing through them now.

C Invisibility has practical consequences, and they are not all benign. The most important is that the assumptions built into a technology become invisible with it. A door handle designed for a person of average height works well for most users and poorly for everyone else; if the design is never discussed, the difficulty it creates is attributed to the user rather than to the object. Researchers in disability studies call this "design exclusion", and its defining feature is that it becomes apparent only when someone asks why a system that works for the majority works badly for the rest.

D A second consequence is that invisible systems are poorly defended. Funding for maintenance competes poorly with funding for new construction, because maintenance produces no new building to open and no ribbon to cut. The result, familiar to anyone who has watched a road network deteriorate, is that societies invest substantially in creating infrastructure and comparatively little in keeping it working. Studies of public bridges in several countries have found that the cost of a preventive repair at an early stage is a small fraction of the cost of reconstruction later, yet preventive work is consistently deferred.

E There is also a cultural effect. Because familiar technologies are not discussed, the knowledge required to understand them is not transmitted. Few city dwellers can describe how their water reaches their tap or where their waste goes after it leaves their building. This is not a question of intelligence but of attention: the information is available, but there has been no occasion to acquire it. When systems fail — as they did when several cities lost water supply in 2021 — the absence of knowledge becomes a practical difficulty, because users cannot judge which of the conflicting explanations they are offered is plausible.

F Some scholars argue that the solution is deliberate "making visible": campaigns that publish how systems work, exercises in which citizens map their own water supply, and school curricula that ask students to trace the path of a product from raw material to disposal. The evidence of their effectiveness is limited, but the logic is sound. Attention is a scarce resource, and a system that no one attends to cannot be governed well.

G Whether visibility is always desirable is another question. Some degree of automatic, unreflective use is the point of a standard: the reason we can concentrate on the

content of this page rather than on the chemistry of ink is that printing became invisible. The aim, then, is probably not to make everything visible but to ensure that invisibility is a choice rather than an accident — that the systems we take for granted are the ones we have tested, and not merely the ones we have inherited.

Questions 14–18. The passage has seven paragraphs, A–G. Choose the correct heading for paragraphs B–F from the list below. (There are more headings than paragraphs.)

- i A problem of maintenance rather than of construction
- ii Why standards are never noticed
- iii The three stages of a technology's integration
- iv Failures of infrastructure in 2021
- v How design decisions exclude some users
- vi Methods intended to make systems visible
- vii The cost of unfamiliarity to consumers
- viii The loss of practical knowledge

Paragraph	Heading
14 Paragraph B	
15 Paragraph C	
16 Paragraph D	
17 Paragraph E	
18 Paragraph F	

Questions 19–22. Complete the summary. Write NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS from the passage for each answer.

Invisible systems A technology typically moves from being publicly debated, to being a matter of 19 rather than of argument, to being noticed mainly when it 20 One consequence is that assumptions built into a design become invisible, so that the difficulties some users experience are blamed on the 21 rather than on the object. Another is that 22 competes badly with new construction for funding.

Questions 23–26. Do the following statements agree with the claims of the writer?

Write YES, NO or NOT GIVEN.

23 Design exclusion becomes obvious only when someone questions why a system fails for a minority. 24 The writer believes that citizens should be able to repair all the systems they use. 25 Evidence that "making visible" campaigns work is limited. 26 The writer thinks that complete visibility of every system would be undesirable.

READING PASSAGE 3

20 minutes · Questions 27–40

Measuring What Cannot Be Seen

A Economics is often described as the study of how societies allocate scarce resources. That definition begins with measurement, and measurement is where the discipline's most persistent difficulties lie. Some of the things people value most — clean air, a walk in a wood, the health of a parent — are not bought and sold, and therefore have no price. They are, in economists' terms, externalities, or goods that markets supply without a mechanism to record their value.

B For most of the twentieth century, the standard response was to measure what could be counted. National accounts recorded production, consumption and investment; anything unpriced was omitted. When the economists Kenneth Arrow and Robert Solow examined the sources of economic growth in the 1950s, they found that a large part of it could not be explained by increases in capital or labour. The residual, sometimes called total factor productivity, was measured but not understood — a gap that Solow himself described with characteristic dryness as "a measure of our ignorance".

C The environmental movement of the 1960s and 1970s made the omission political. If air quality did not appear in the accounts, it did not appear in decisions; if pollution produced no entry in the ledger, then cleaning it up was a pure cost. The counter-argument, increasingly accepted after the 1980s, was that a failure to price something does not mean it is worthless. It means that its value is being paid in a different form: in illness, in lost days of work, in the shortened lives of people who had the least power to avoid exposure.

D Economists then did what economists do, and attempted to assign prices to unpriced goods. Two methods became standard. The first infers value from behaviour: if a house beside a park sells for more than an identical house beside a road, the difference is a revealed preference, and it can be treated as an estimate of the value of the park. The second, called contingent valuation, asks people directly what they would be willing to pay for a good. Neither method is uncontroversial. Revealed preference depends on markets that other people distorted, and contingent valuation is criticised because what people say in a survey may differ from what they do.

E Despite the criticisms, both methods changed policy. Cost-benefit analyses that had previously ignored environmental effects now quantified them, and governments began to apply a standard value to the avoidance of a death, which sounds callous and is in fact the opposite: it forces an explicit comparison rather than concealing a comparison in an omission. Once a figure is attached, one can ask whether it is the right figure — a question that cannot be asked about a blank space.

F The most sophisticated criticisms come from within the discipline. Some economists argue that the methods produce numbers that are precise but not meaningful: a willingness-to-pay estimate reflects income as much as preference, so a rich society will always value a park more highly than a poor one, and the number tells us about wealth rather than about nature. Others point out that some things are not valued marginally at all — a species cannot be ninety per cent preserved, and a climate either remains within familiar bounds or does not.

G These are arguments about method, not about the value of measurement. The result of three decades of disagreement has nevertheless been practical: cost-benefit analysis now routinely includes environmental effects, national accounts in several countries include "satellite" accounts for forests and water, and international agreements require the reporting of emissions, a statistic that did not exist before the 1990s. Measurement made the question arguable; before measurement, it was not arguable at all.

Questions 27–31. Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

27 What does paragraph A suggest about externalities?

- A They are unimportant to economies.
- B They are valued but unpriced.
- C They can always be traded.
- D They were invented in the 1950s.

28 Solow's phrase "a measure of our ignorance" refers to

- A a statistical error.
- B a gap between measured growth and its known causes.
- C the cost of labour.
- D the value of clean air.

29 According to the passage, the delay in including environmental values in national accounts meant that

- A pollution was assumed to be harmless.
- B cleaning up pollution appeared to be a cost with no benefit.
- C governments ignored economic growth.
- D markets worked efficiently.

30 Revealed preference is criticised because

- A it is expensive to calculate.
- B other people's market distortions may affect the estimate.
- C it relies on surveys.
- D it undervalues parks.

31 What does the writer mean by saying that putting a value on avoiding a death "sounds callous and is in fact the opposite"?

- A It shows that economists care only about money.
- B It makes a hidden comparison explicit and open to challenge.
- C It reduces the value of human life.
- D It prevents all environmental legislation.

Questions 32–36. Complete each sentence with the correct ending, A–H.

32 Contingent valuation asks people... 33 Willingness-to-pay estimates partly reflect...

34 A species cannot be... 35 Satellite accounts record... 36 Reporting emissions became...

- A ninety per cent preserved.
- B forests and water.

- C what they would pay for something.
- D the income of the society being studied.
- E obligatory under international agreements.
- F the cost of labour and capital.
- G the total value of a market.
- H possible only after 2020.

Questions 37–40. Do the following statements agree with the claims of the writer?

Write YES, NO or NOT GIVEN.

37 Economists have generally responded to the problem of unpriced goods by trying to price them. 38 The writer believes that cost-benefit analysis has made environmental policy worse. 39 Most economists now agree about how to value non-market goods. 40 The writer considers the criticisms of measurement methods to be arguments about method rather than about whether to measure.

Answer Key — Reading Practice Test 2

Q	Answer	Q	Answer	Q	Answer	Q	Answer
1	TRUE	11	C	21	user	31	B
2	TRUE	12	B	22	maintenance	32	C
3	FALSE	13	C	23	YES	33	D
4	TRUE	14	iii	24	NOT GIVEN	34	A
5	NOT GIVEN	15	v	25	YES	35	B
6	FALSE	16	i	26	YES	36	E
7	25 / twenty-five	17	viii	27	B	37	YES
8	species	18	vi	28	B	38	NO
9	80 / eighty	19	competence	29	B	39	NO
10	B	20	fails	30	B	40	YES

Explanations

1 TRUE. Paragraph A: "planted for decoration... Their function was aesthetic."

2 TRUE. Paragraph B: transpires water, and "the process absorbs heat in the same way that sweating cools a body".

3 FALSE. The passage says the death rate was higher in districts with little tree cover within the same cities — it does not apply evenly, and paragraph B compares districts, not cities. The statement contradicts the emphasis on differences.

4 TRUE. Paragraph C: "hairy leaves catch more than waxy ones".

5 NOT GIVEN. Trees as flood defence are discussed in paragraph D, but no date is given for when planting for that purpose began — the paragraph mentions "cities that had previously invested only in larger pipes", without a year. This is the classic "plausible but undated" trap.

6 FALSE. Paragraph E: "the loss rates were so high that the policy was eventually abandoned" — some programmes failed.

7 25. "perhaps a twenty-five per cent chance"; the limit permits a number, so 25 is safest.

8 species. "allow them to choose the species".

9 80. "their survival rates exceeded eighty per cent".

10 B. The heatwave is introduced to connect canopy cover with mortality — a measurable health effect.

11 C. Paragraph C: "That figure is smaller than early enthusiasts claimed", yet the effect is real and the shading benefit is additional.

12 B. Paragraph F lists "block sightlines at junctions" among the practical objections.

13 C. Paragraph G: "a modest but unusually cost-effective investment, provided..." — conditional endorsement.

- 14 iii. Paragraph B describes the three stages explicitly.
- 15 v. Paragraph C is about "design exclusion" — some users are excluded by design decisions.
- 16 i. Paragraph D contrasts maintenance funding with construction funding.
- 17 viii. Paragraph E is about "the knowledge required... is not transmitted" — practical knowledge lost.
- 18 vi. Paragraph F describes "making visible" campaigns and mapping exercises.
- 19 competence. "a matter of competence rather than debate".
- 20 fails. "noticed only when it fails".
- 21 user. "attributed to the user rather than to the object".
- 22 maintenance. "Funding for maintenance competes poorly with funding for new construction".
- 23 YES. Paragraph C: "its defining feature is that it becomes apparent only when someone asks why a system that works for the majority works badly for the rest."
- 24 NOT GIVEN. The writer discusses knowledge and visibility, but never asserts a right to repair.
- 25 YES. Paragraph F: "The evidence of their effectiveness is limited, but the logic is sound."
- 26 YES. Paragraph G: "The aim, then, is probably not to make everything visible..."
- 27 B. Paragraph A: goods that are valued but not bought and sold, hence unpriced.
- 28 B. The residual is "measured but not understood" — growth that cannot be explained by capital or labour.
- 29 B. Paragraph C: "if pollution produced no entry in the ledger, then cleaning it up was a pure cost".
- 30 B. Paragraph D: "Revealed preference depends on markets that other people distorted."
- 31 B. Paragraph E: it "forces an explicit comparison rather than concealing a comparison in an omission".
- 32 C. "asks people directly what they would be willing to pay for a good".
- 33 D. Paragraph F: "a willingness-to-pay estimate reflects income as much as preference".
- 34 A. "a species cannot be ninety per cent preserved".
- 35 B. Paragraph G: "'satellite' accounts for forests and water".
- 36 E. "international agreements require the reporting of emissions".
- 37 YES. Paragraph D: "Economists then did what economists do, and attempted to assign prices to unpriced goods."
- 38 NO. Paragraph E: cost-benefit analyses "that had previously ignored environmental effects now quantified them", and the writer presents this as an improvement.

39 NO. Paragraph F shows continuing disagreement; paragraph G calls it "three decades of disagreement".

40 YES. "These are arguments about method, not about the value of measurement."

Self-analysis

Skill	Questions	My score
T/F/NG	1-6	/6
Sentence completion	7-9	/3
Multiple choice	10-13, 27-31	/9
Matching headings	14-18	/5
Summary completion	19-22	/4
Y/N/NG	23-26, 37-40	/8
Matching sentence endings	32-36	/5

If you scored below 6/8 on the Y/N/NG questions, re-read Chapter 9.3 and complete twenty items with written justifications before taking another test. This is the single highest-yield repair available.

CHAPTER 24

Mock Test: Writing and Speaking Papers

Together with the Listening and Reading tests in the previous chapters, these papers make a complete mock examination. Take them under strict timing, in the order below, ideally on separate days so that fatigue does not distort your Writing result.

24.1 Writing Task 1 (Academic) — 20 minutes, 150+ words

The table below shows the number of international students enrolled at four universities in 2015 and 2023, and the proportion of them studying engineering.

University	2015 students	2023 students	% engineering (2023)
Ashcroft	4,200	6,800	28%
Bellview	3,100	3,050	41%
Cranmere	5,600	9,900	22%
Dunfield	2,400	4,100	35%

Task: Summarise the information by selecting and reporting the main features, and make comparisons where relevant.

Model answer

The table compares the numbers of international students enrolled at four universities in 2015 and 2023, and shows what proportion of the 2023 intake studied engineering.

Overall, international enrolment grew at three of the four universities, with Cranmere remaining the largest and Bellview the smallest and the only one that did not expand. Engineering was the most common subject at Bellview and the least common at Cranmere, so the largest institution had the lowest concentration of engineers.

Cranmere enrolled 5,600 international students in 2015 and 9,900 by 2023, an increase of around three-quarters and by far the largest absolute growth of the four institutions. Ashcroft also expanded substantially, from 4,200 to 6,800 — a rise of just over sixty per cent — while Dunfield grew most rapidly in relative terms, its intake rising from 2,400 to 4,100.

Bellview was the exception. Its numbers were virtually unchanged, edging down from 3,100 to 3,050 over the eight-year period, which left it with roughly a third of Cranmere's total.

The pattern in engineering was quite different from that in enrolment. Bellview, the smallest university, had the highest proportion of engineering students at 41%, followed by Dunfield at 35% and Ashcroft at 28%. Cranmere, despite its size, had the lowest share, at 22%, which suggests that its growth came largely from non-engineering subjects. (208 words)

Commentary

Note how the model groups rather than lists: growth universities together, the exception separately, then a second grouping by engineering share. It selects the highest, the lowest and the fastest-growing, and it uses just over, roughly, by far to avoid over-claiming precision. That grouping is what separates a Band 7 from a Band 6 answer on the same table.

24.2 Writing Task 2 — 40 minutes, 250+ words

Some people believe that the best way to protect the environment is to increase the cost of the goods and services that cause pollution. Others argue that education is more effective. Discuss both views and give your own opinion. Give reasons for your answer and include any relevant examples from your own knowledge or experience.

Model answer

Environmental policy usually relies on two instruments: prices and persuasion. Those who favour higher costs argue that people respond to incentives; those who favour education argue that lasting change requires understanding. Both positions are defensible, and in practice the two are far more effective together than either is alone — though if forced to choose one as a starting point, pricing is the more reliable.

The case for higher prices rests on a simple observation: behaviour follows cost. When single-use plastic bags were charged for in Ireland, consumption fell by more than ninety per cent within a year, and the reduction persisted after the charge was increased. Nobody became more environmentally conscious; millions of people simply changed a habit because the alternative was cheaper. The mechanism is particularly valuable because it works on people who are not persuaded by environmental arguments at all, and because it generates revenue that can be used to fund alternatives, such as public transport or recycling infrastructure.

Supporters of education advance a different argument. A price changes what people do while the price is in force, but it does not change what people believe, and measures that are seen as punitive tend to be unpopular and therefore politically fragile. Education, by contrast, creates voters who support environmental policy and consumers who prefer sustainable products when the price difference is small. Where behaviour depends on knowledge rather than cost — separating waste correctly, avoiding contamination in recycling streams, understanding why a product is damaging — no charge can substitute for information.

The two approaches are complements rather than rivals. A charge without explanation invites evasion and resentment: drivers who cannot understand why they are being charged for entering a city centre will look for ways around the charge rather than rethink their journeys. Education without a price signal changes attitudes but not the arithmetic, and a shopper who cares about plastic pollution will still choose the cheaper package if nothing distinguishes the two at the till.

In my view, therefore, the most effective policies combine both, but the balance should tilt towards pricing, because a correctly designed charge produces an immediate, measurable and self-enforcing change, whereas education works slowly and imperfectly. The best use of education is to explain the charge, so that it is understood as a means rather than a punishment. (389 words)

24.3 Speaking — full mock

Record every part. Do not stop to correct yourself; the goal is a realistic 11–14 minute performance.

Part 1 (4–5 minutes)

Let's talk about where you live.

- 1 Do you live in a house or a flat?
- 2 What do you like most about your home?
- 3 Is there anything you would like to change about it?
- 4 Would you prefer to live in the city or the countryside? Why?

Now let's talk about technology.

- 1 How often do you use a computer or a phone?
- 2 What do you mainly use it for?
- 3 Are there any apps or websites you find particularly useful?
- 4 Do you think you spend too much time online?

Let's move on to food.

- 1 Do you enjoy cooking?
- 2 What kind of food is popular in your country?
- 3 Have your eating habits changed in recent years?
- 4 Is there any food you dislike?

Part 2 (3–4 minutes)

Describe a time when you had to solve a problem. You should say: - what the problem was - how you discovered it - what you did about it - and explain what you learned from the experience.

You have one minute to prepare. Speak for one and a half to two minutes.

Follow-up questions: Do you usually solve problems on your own or ask for help? Is solving problems something that can be taught?

Part 3 (4–5 minutes)

We've been talking about solving problems. I'd like to discuss some more general questions related to this.

- 1 Why do some people avoid asking for help when they have a problem?
- 2 How has technology changed the way people solve everyday problems?
- 3 Is it better for children to solve problems independently or with guidance from adults?
- 4 Do you think schools teach problem-solving effectively?
- 5 How might the problems people face in daily life change in the next twenty years?
- 6 Are practical problems or personal problems harder to solve? Why?

Self-assessment grid

Listen to your recording and score each part 1–9 against Chapter 2's descriptors, then compute an indicative Speaking band.

	Fluency & Coherence	Lexical Resource	Grammar	Pronunciation
Part 1 (score)				
Part 2 (score)				
Part 3 (score)				
Overall impression				

Three questions to ask after listening

- 1 Did I answer in full sentences, or did I fragment?
- 2 Did I use at least four tenses naturally?
- 3 Did I ever lose the thread and fail to finish a thought?

24.4 Combined mock score record

Component	Raw score	Band
Listening (Test 1 or 2)	/40	
Academic Reading (Test 1 or 2)	/40	
Writing Task 1	—	/9
Writing Task 2	—	/9
Writing band	$((T1 + 2 \times T2) \div 3)$	
Speaking	—	/9
Overall band	$(L + R + W + S) \div 4$, rounded	

Calculate your Writing band correctly: Task 2 counts twice. If Task 1 is a 6.5 and Task 2 is a 7.0, your Writing band is $(6.5 + 14) \div 3 = 6.83 \rightarrow 7.0$, not 6.75.

Recording your progress over time

Date	Listening	Reading	Writing	Speaking	Overall

Two things to watch in this table: the trend, and the gap. A candidate who improves steadily but has one skill two bands below the others should spend nearly all remaining time on that skill, because the overall band is an average and the weakest component has the largest effect on the average.

CHAPTER 25

The Exam-Day Playbook

Everything in this book converges on a single morning. This chapter is the operational checklist: what to do in the last week, on the day, and in each component, minute by minute.

25.1 The final week

Day	Focus	Time
7 days out	Full mock test (Chapter 22) under exam conditions	3 hours
6 days out	Mark the mock; write the error classification	1 hour
5 days out	Repair the weakest question type in Listening and Reading	90 min
4 days out	Write one Task 1 and one Task 2; self-mark with Chapter 2's criteria	90 min
3 days out	Record a full Speaking mock; listen back; fix one pronunciation feature	45 min
2 days out	Review error log, vocabulary notebook, and the checklists in this chapter	60 min
1 day out	Light review only. No new material, no full test. Confirm documents and travel	30 min
Test day	The checklist below	—

The most common mistake in the final week is doing too much. Cramming new material in the last 48 hours produces anxiety and displaces what you already know. The gains available are in accuracy habits — the checklists — not in new knowledge.

25.2 What to take to the test centre

- Identification exactly as registered (passport or national ID, depending on your booking).
- Confirmation email or booking reference.
- Pencils, eraser and sharpener (paper-based candidates); pens for the Writing test.
- Water in a clear bottle with the label removed, if permitted at your centre.
- A watch that is not a smartwatch — some centres have no visible clock. (If in doubt, leave it; examiners announce the remaining time at intervals.)
- No phone, no notes in the exam room. There is no secure expectation of leniency: a phone found on you can void your result.

25.3 Arrival and the hour before

- 1 Arrive 45 minutes early. Latecomers are refused entry to Listening, and there is no alternative sitting.
- 2 Speak English aloud on the way — read signs, describe the street, summarise a news item. Your Speaking test may be the same day, and a warmed-up mouth is worth marks.
- 3 Do not discuss content with other candidates. Someone will confidently misdescribe the test format and unsettle you.
- 4 Go to the toilet before you enter. Reading and Writing give you no convenient break.
- 5 Sit still and breathe slowly for the last five minutes. A calm start to Listening is worth more than last-minute review.

25.4 Listening: the 30 minutes

Moment	Action
Before Section 1 begins	Read questions 1–10 twice; predict the type of each answer; underline the word limit
Section 1	Write answers as you hear them; expect corrections; do not stop for a missed answer
Section 2	If there is a map, find the compass, entrance and pre-labelled features before the audio starts
Section 3	Track who says what; mark agreement and disagreement words in the margin
Section 4	Write only the answer word; abbreviate; ignore surrounding notes
After each section	Use the 30 seconds to check the answers you have just written — never the whole paper
Transfer (10 min)	Check: spelling · plurals · word limits · grammatical fit · guessed answers

The four Listening checks, in order: word limit, spelling, singular/plural, does it fit the sentence.

25.5 Reading: the 60 minutes

Clock	What you should be doing
0:00–0:02	Read the Passage 1 title and first paragraph; read the questions
0:17	Passage 1 complete, including guesses for anything unanswered
0:17–0:37	Passage 2, same procedure; do matching tasks last within the passage
0:37–0:57	Passage 3
0:57–1:00	Ensure every blank is filled. Check that no answer exceeds its word limit

Never spend more than two minutes on one question. Never leave a blank. Never transfer answers at the end — there is no transfer time in Reading.

25.6 Writing: the 60 minutes

Clock	Action
0:00–0:02	Read both tasks; decide which is simpler (usually Task 1) and begin there
0:02–0:05	Task 1: analyse the visual; decide the overview; group the data
0:05–0:18	Write Task 1 (aim 160–190 words)
0:18–0:20	Task 2: read the question twice; count the jobs; write the plan and the position sentence
0:20–0:27	Introduction and first body paragraph
0:27–0:40	Second body paragraph (and third, if time)
0:40–0:48	Conclusion
0:48–0:55	Edit Task 2 for accuracy (verb forms, articles, plurals, spelling)
0:55–0:60	Edit Task 1 briefly; confirm both word counts

Order: always Task 1 first. It is shorter, it is more mechanical, and completing it removes the risk of running out of time on a task worth a third of the band.

25.7 Speaking: the 14 minutes

Part 1 (4–5 min). Answer each question in two to four sentences using AREA (Chapter 18.2). Shift tenses deliberately. Smile — it changes the sound of your voice, and intelligibility is what is being judged.

Part 2 (3–4 min).

- During the minute of preparation, split your paper into four quadrants matching the bullets and write 6–10 keywords.
- Start speaking immediately after the examiner's prompt, with a content opening (The person I'd like to talk about is...).
- Aim for structure: setting → situation → detail → reflection.
- If you run dry, extend: add a detail, compare with now, give a reason for your feeling, widen the frame.
- Finish with a reflection sentence, not "...and that's all I can say."

Part 3 (4–5 min). 40–60 seconds per answer. Position → reason → example → qualification. Use hedging language, and treat pauses as content-related: "That's an interesting question..."

If you do not understand a question: ask. "Sorry, could you repeat that?" or "Do you mean ...?" costs nothing. Answering the wrong question costs a great deal.

25.8 The checklists, condensed

Before the Listening test

- [] Word limits underlined
- [] Answer types predicted for every gap
- [] Map: compass, entrance and pre-labelled features located

Before the Reading test

- [] Timing targets fixed (17 / 20 / 20 + 3)
- [] Order strategy chosen: easiest passage first, matching tasks last
- [] Underline the instruction word of every question set

Before the Writing test

- [] Both tasks read; jobs counted for Task 2
- [] Position sentence written before the introduction
- [] Overview paragraph planned for Task 1
- [] 5-minute editing slot protected

Before the Speaking test

- [] Warm-up: speak English aloud for five minutes
- [] AREA (Part 1), four-quadrant keywords (Part 2), PEC+ (Part 3) in mind
- [] Question types rehearsed: opinion, compare, speculate, evaluate, cause, category
- [] Remember: accent is not assessed; stress and clarity are

25.9 Twelve mistakes that cost most candidates a band

- 1 Rushing the questions to "save time" for reading, then answering from memory.
- 2 Leaving blanks in Reading or Listening (there is no penalty for guessing).
- 3 Writing over the word limit in gap-fill tasks.
- 4 Spelling errors in Listening answers.
- 5 Ignoring plurals: book instead of books.
- 6 Starting Task 2 before Task 1 and running out of time on both.
- 7 Answering a two-part essay question with only one part.
- 8 Memorised introductions and conclusions, which do not fit the question.
- 9 Speaking too fast in Part 2 out of nerves, losing word endings.
- 10 Giving one-sentence answers in Part 1, leaving no evidence for the examiner.
- 11 Silent pauses of more than three seconds in Speaking, with no filler language.
- 12 Answering a Speaking question that was not asked because you misheard and were too embarrassed to ask for repetition.

25.10 After the test

- Do not re-plan your application on the way home. Estimates of your own performance are unreliable, usually in both directions.
- Do not immediately re-book. Results arrive in about 13 days (paper-based) or 3–5 days (computer-delivered). If you must improve, you will do so faster with a written error profile from this book than with another panic purchase.
- Write down, now, what felt worst. Within a week, memory of the test is still specific enough to design the next study cycle.
- Celebrate. You have done the difficult part: you prepared, and you performed.

If you need a higher band and a retake is necessary, the fastest route is almost always the same: identify the single criterion or question type that cost you most, fix it in isolation for two weeks, then re-test. Repeatedly taking full tests without repairing a specific weakness produces scores that barely move.

CHAPTER 26

Ten Model Essays: The Most Common Task 2 Topics

These ten essays answer questions of the kind that appear again and again in Task 2. Each is written to a different question type, so the chapter doubles as a survey of the five essay formats in action. Read the commentary that follows each essay before moving on: it names the technique that earns the mark, and it is the technique — not the topic — that transfers to your own writing.

How to use this chapter. Cover an essay, read only its question, plan for four minutes, then write your own introduction and one body paragraph. Uncover the model and compare. This is far more useful than reading all ten in one sitting.

Essay 1 — Education (opinion)

Some people believe that all university education should be free of charge. To what extent do you agree or disagree?

Higher education is expensive to provide and valuable to those who receive it, which is why the question of who should pay provokes such disagreement. I largely agree that tuition should not be a barrier, though I would not describe full funding from general taxation as the only fair arrangement.

The strongest case for free tuition is that education produces benefits that extend well beyond the individual. A graduate earns more, but the same graduate also treats patients, designs bridges, teaches children and pays substantially more tax over a working life. If the public receives a share of the return, it is reasonable for the public to contribute to the cost. When fees are high, the people deterred are not the most able but the least wealthy, and a society that selects its doctors and engineers by family income wastes talent it cannot afford to waste.

There are, however, two serious objections. The first is distributional. Free university education is a transfer from the general population to a group that will, on average, be among the highest earners in the country; it is regressive in a way that free primary education is not. The second is financial. States that abolish fees usually ration places instead, so the constraint shifts from price to availability, and candidates from strong schools continue to win the competition.

A more defensible model therefore combines a low or zero fee for those who need it with progressive repayment afterwards, so that the cost is carried by graduates in proportion to what they earn. Scotland and Australia operate versions of this arrangement, and both achieve higher participation among disadvantaged students than systems relying on up-front fees.

In conclusion, I agree that cost should not determine who studies, because the benefits of higher education are shared. But the fairest mechanism is not necessarily a universal subsidy; it is one that removes the barrier at the point of entry and recovers the cost later from those who gained most. (331 words)

Technique in focus: the qualified agreement. The essay agrees "largely" in the introduction, concedes two objections, then returns to the same position with a different mechanism. Note that the concession strengthens rather than weakens the answer — a Band 7 requirement for a clear position throughout.

Essay 2 — Environment (discussion)

Some people think that individuals should take responsibility for reducing waste, while others believe that only governments and businesses can make a real difference. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.

Waste reduction is often presented as a matter of personal virtue, yet the scale of the problem suggests that individual choices alone will not solve it. While household behaviour matters, I believe the decisive changes must come from regulation and industrial design, because those determine what choices individuals actually have.

Those who emphasise individual responsibility make a fair point about volume. Households generate a large share of municipal waste, and small changes — refusing single-use bags, separating recyclables, repairing rather than replacing — collectively reduce the amount that reaches landfill. There is also a political argument: consumers who change their habits create demand for products designed to last, and businesses to notice.

The opposing case rests on influence rather than volume. A household can choose between the packaging options available to it, but it cannot decide that packaging will not be used. That decision belongs to manufacturers and retailers, and it responds to regulation far more reliably than to consumer preference. The evidence is plain: where deposit-return schemes and extended producer responsibility have been introduced, collection rates have risen sharply within a year, and where they have not, voluntary commitments have produced modest results. Blaming individuals for a problem designed into the products they buy also has a demoralising effect that tends to reduce engagement rather than increase it.

In my view the two are not really in competition. Governments set the framework, businesses respond to it, and individuals act within the space that remains. The problem with the individual-responsibility argument is not that it is false but that it has been used, sometimes deliberately, to postpone the regulations that would make the largest difference.

In conclusion, personal habits have value and should be encouraged, but they operate inside a system constructed by others. Meaningful waste reduction will come when producers are made responsible for what they put on the market, and when consumers are given options that make the sustainable choice the easy one. (327 words)

Technique in focus: hierarchy of arguments. The essay distinguishes between arguments of volume (households) and influence (producers), and explains why the second is more decisive. That kind of distinction is the mark of a Band 8 discussion.

Essay 3 — Technology (problem-solution)

Increasing numbers of people work from home. What problems does this cause, and what measures could be taken to address them?

Remote work has expanded from a minority arrangement to a normal one in a remarkably short time. It brings clear benefits, but it also creates problems — for individuals, for organisations and for city centres — and these require deliberate responses rather than a return to the office.

For individuals, the most serious difficulty is the erosion of the boundary between work and rest. When the workplace is also the home, the working day expands to fill the evening; studies of remote employees consistently report longer hours and more difficulty disengaging. A related problem is isolation, particularly for those living alone, since the informal contact that sustains morale in an office — a short conversation, a shared lunch — is precisely what remote work removes.

For organisations, the difficulty is less visible and more damaging. New employees cannot learn by observation, mentoring becomes a formality, and the tacit knowledge that passes between colleagues in a corridor does not transfer through a video call. For cities, the consequences are commercial: businesses dependent on commuter footfall, from coffee shops to dry cleaners, lose the customers on whom they were built.

Several measures follow directly. Employers can protect the boundary by setting genuine limits on after-hours communication and by measuring output rather than presence. Hybrid models, in which teams agree on fixed days together, preserve mentoring while keeping the flexibility that remote work provides. Cities can respond by converting office districts to mixed use, which is expensive but less costly than maintaining vacant towers. Finally, formal mentorship schemes can replace what used to happen informally.

In conclusion, remote work is not a problem to be solved by reversing it — the flexibility it offers is too valuable to give up. The task is to rebuild, deliberately, the structures that an office once provided without anyone designing them. (305 words)

Technique in focus: consequences at three levels. Problems are analysed for individuals, organisations and cities, giving the paragraph range without repetition, and each solution is matched to a specific problem.

Essay 4 — Health (two-part question)

In many countries, obesity rates are rising. Why is this happening, and is it a positive or a negative development?

Rising obesity rates have become a feature of wealthy and middle-income countries alike. The causes are structural rather than moral, and the development is unambiguously negative, though not for the reason most often given.

The principal cause is the changing economics of food. Energy-dense, highly processed food has become cheaper relative to fresh produce over several decades, largely because of agricultural subsidies that support calorie production rather than nutrition. A family on a limited budget therefore finds the cheapest calories are also the least healthy, and this is a matter of price rather than of knowledge. The second cause is the disappearance of incidental activity: cars replaced walking, lifts replaced stairs, and

work became sedentary. The third is the environment in which food is marketed — portion sizes, advertising aimed at children, and the deliberate engineering of products to be difficult to eat in moderation.

As to whether this is positive or negative, the answer is clear. Obesity raises the risk of diabetes, heart disease and several cancers, and it does so years before the costs appear. The burden therefore falls on health systems at exactly the moment when their populations are ageing, which makes it a fiscal problem as well as a human one. There are those who argue that body size is a matter of personal freedom and that public health campaigns can stigmatise people; that concern is legitimate, but it argues for careful messaging, not for treating a preventable epidemic as neutral.

In conclusion, the rise in obesity is driven by cheap calories, sedentary lives and marketing, not by a collapse of individual willpower, and its consequences are negative and expensive. Any effective response must therefore change the environment in which choices are made — through pricing, labelling and the design of cities — rather than simply urging people to try harder. (311 words)

Technique in focus: answer both questions fully. The "why" is answered with three structural causes; the "positive or negative" is answered decisively, with the counter-argument acknowledged and reframed. Note the refusal to moralise — a mature evaluative stance.

Essay 5 — Work (advantages/disadvantages)

More and more people are choosing to be self-employed rather than working for a company. What are the advantages and disadvantages of this trend?

Self-employment has grown across a wide range of occupations, from software development to delivery work, and the trend contains both genuine opportunity and genuine risk. The advantages are real, but they are not distributed evenly, and the disadvantages fall hardest on those with the least bargaining power.

The clearest advantage is autonomy. A self-employed person chooses what work to accept, when to work and where; for parents, carers and people with health conditions, that flexibility can be the difference between working and not working at all. A second advantage is the direct relationship between effort and reward: successful freelancers keep the profit their work generates rather than seeing it absorbed by an employer. For some, self-employment also permits a specialisation that no single employer could support.

The disadvantages begin with income insecurity. There is no guaranteed wage, no paid holiday and no sick pay, so a slow month is a month without income, and an illness can be financially catastrophic. A second disadvantage is the loss of collective protection: the self-employed negotiate individually, which leaves them with little power over the clients or platforms that set their rates. A third is administrative burden and isolation — the unpaid work of invoicing, tax and marketing, and the absence of colleagues, both of which are easy to underestimate from outside.

The distribution of these effects is the crux. For a skilled professional with savings and a network, self-employment offers freedom at acceptable risk. For a delivery rider paid per drop and dependent on an algorithm for work, the same label describes something

closer to precariousness without the protections of employment. The advantage and the disadvantage are the same feature — independence from an employer — viewed from different positions of security.

In conclusion, self-employment expands choice for those who can absorb risk and removes protection for those who cannot. A sensible policy response is therefore not to discourage it but to extend basic protections — insurance, dispute resolution, transparent pay — to people who work independently. (330 words)

Technique in focus: the unifying insight. The final body paragraph observes that the advantage and the disadvantage are the same feature seen from different positions. That observation is what lifts the essay above a list of points and demonstrates genuine analysis.

Essay 6 — Society (opinion)

Some people think that the gap between rich and poor is too large and should be reduced. Others say that inequality motivates people to work harder. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.

Economic inequality has widened in most developed countries since the 1980s, and the argument about whether this matters divides along predictable lines. The claim that inequality motivates effort has some truth at the individual level, but it does not survive examination as a justification for the extremes now observed.

The motivational argument is intuitive. If everyone received the same income regardless of effort or skill, the incentive to train, to innovate or to take risks would weaken, and economies that have attempted flat wages have not prospered. Differential rewards therefore serve a function, and a degree of inequality is unavoidable in any system that allows people to choose their work.

What this argument cannot justify is the scale and the persistence of current inequality. Motivation requires that effort and reward be connected, and at the extremes they plainly are not: inheritance, market power and access to capital transmit advantage across generations independently of effort. Meanwhile, the consequences of high inequality fall on everyone. Societies with larger gaps show lower social mobility — the very motivation the argument relies upon is weakest where inequality is greatest. Public health, crime rates and even levels of trust correlate with inequality rather than with average income.

In my view, therefore, the motivational argument justifies a gap but not the gap. The appropriate response is to reduce inequality at the extremes while preserving the returns that reward effort: progressive taxation of wealth rather than of income alone, inheritance reform, and investment in education that widens access to high-paying work. None of these measures eliminates the incentive to work; they reduce the advantages that have nothing to do with work at all.

In conclusion, inequality is not simply a moral problem; it is a problem of function, because at high levels it destroys the link between effort and reward that the motivational argument depends upon. Reducing the gap is therefore not in tension with rewarding effort — it is a condition for doing so. (331 words)

Technique in focus: turning the opponent's argument. Rather than dismissing the motivation argument, the essay accepts its logic and shows that high inequality defeats it. This is the most persuasive move available in an opinion essay.

Essay 7 — Cities (problem-solution)

Traffic congestion is a serious problem in many cities. What are the main causes, and what can be done about it?

Congestion is the visible symptom of a city that has grown faster than its transport system. Its causes are well understood, and so, increasingly, are the remedies; what is usually missing is the political willingness to apply them.

The immediate cause is that road space is free at the point of use. Because drivers pay only for fuel and parking, the delay they impose on others is not priced, and demand therefore exceeds supply at peak times — a queue is the mechanism by which the excess is rationed. A second cause is the shape of modern cities: separating homes from workplaces guarantees long journeys and concentrates them into two daily peaks. A third is that new road capacity encourages additional traffic, so widening roads tends to reproduce the congestion it was meant to relieve.

The remedies are cumulative rather than single. Charging for the use of road space at peak times directly addresses the pricing failure, and cities that have introduced it — Singapore, Stockholm, London — have reduced traffic volumes within the charged area. Improving public transport is the necessary companion: a charge without an alternative is a tax on people who have no choice. Bus priority measures, protected cycle lanes and mixed-use development reduce the need to travel long distances at all, and flexible working hours spread demand away from the peak.

The obstacles are political rather than technical. Charges are unpopular before they are introduced and popular afterwards, because the benefits become visible; the difficulty is surviving the intervening period. That suggests that the design of any scheme matters as much as its existence — revenue should be visibly earmarked for transport, and exemptions should protect those least able to pay.

In conclusion, congestion arises because road space is underpriced and cities are arranged around long commutes. Charging, alternatives and mixed-use planning can each reduce it, and together they can largely solve it. The barrier is not a shortage of solutions but the political cost of applying them before the benefit can be seen. (332 words)

Technique in focus: the political obstacle. Recognising that the limitation is political rather than technical is a sophisticated addition to a problem-solution essay and shows an awareness of implementation that most Band 6 answers lack.

Essay 8 — Media (opinion)

Some people say that advertising encourages us to buy things we do not need. To what extent do you agree or disagree?

Advertising exists to sell, and it would be surprising if a practice so well funded did not occasionally create desires that consumers would not otherwise have had. I agree that

advertising generates unnecessary consumption, though I would qualify the claim in two respects: it works best on existing tendencies, and its most serious effects are not about individual purchases at all.

The mechanism is well documented. Advertising associates a product with a feeling — status, security, belonging — and then offers the product as the means to that feeling. Where the association is repeated persuasively, demand grows beyond what any objective assessment of usefulness would support. This is particularly true for goods that are consumed conspicuously, since their value depends on being seen.

Two qualifications matter. The first is that advertising amplifies more than it creates. Nobody is persuaded by a billboard to want food, warmth or company; what advertising does is direct an existing desire towards a specific brand and a specific quantity, which is why its effect is greater in wealthy societies where basic needs are already met. The second is that consumers are not passive, and the effectiveness of any campaign is bounded by its plausibility and by the cost of the alternative.

The more serious effects, however, lie elsewhere. Advertising to children, where the capacity to distinguish persuasion from information is still developing, and advertising of products whose harm is external to the buyer — fast food, fossil fuels, gambling — create costs that fall on people who never made the purchase. Those cases justify regulation on grounds that do not depend on the claim that advertising creates need, which is fortunate, because that claim is difficult to prove.

In conclusion, I agree that advertising produces demand for goods that would otherwise go unbought, though it works by amplifying existing desires rather than by inventing them. The appropriate response is not to prohibit advertising in general but to restrict it where the costs are borne by third parties, particularly children. (330 words)

Technique in focus: the two qualifications structure. Instead of a single concession paragraph, the essay offers two short qualifications in one paragraph, then redirects to a stronger argument. This is efficient and prevents the essay from drifting into a discussion piece.

Essay 9 — Globalisation (discussion)

Some people believe that globalisation has benefited everyone. Others argue that it has increased inequality. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.

Globalisation has reduced the cost of moving goods, capital and information, and in doing so has reshaped the world economy. The claim that it has benefited everyone is too strong; the claim that it has simply increased inequality is also too simple. The truth depends on which group and which period one examines.

The case that globalisation has been broadly beneficial rests on the extraordinary reduction in poverty recorded since 1990. Hundreds of millions of people, chiefly in East and South Asia, have left extreme poverty, and the mechanism is traceable to trade and investment: factories producing for export employ labour that would otherwise be engaged in subsistence agriculture, at wages that are low by rich-country standards but far above what the alternative offered. Consumers in wealthy countries have benefited as well, through lower prices for clothing, electronics and food.

The opposing case is strongest when it is made precisely. The gains from globalisation have not been evenly shared within countries: the returns have concentrated in capital and in skilled labour in urban centres, while manufacturing workers in wealthy countries have seen wages stagnate and communities decline. Critics also point to the regulatory dimension, arguing that competition for investment creates pressure to lower labour and environmental standards.

Both claims can be true simultaneously, and the synthesis is straightforward. Globalisation has redistributed income between countries — narrowing the gap between Asia and the West — while widening it within many countries, between cities and regions and between capital and labour. That is not a paradox but a description of what happens when a large labour force joins the global market: the price of labour converges, and the losers are those whose wages had been artificially high.

In conclusion, the claim that globalisation has benefited everyone is indefensible, but the claim that it has merely increased inequality misreads where the gains went. The task for governments is not to reverse integration but to redistribute its proceeds within their own borders, through education, regional investment and taxation. (330 words)

Technique in focus: the synthesis. The essay resolves the disagreement with a distinction — between within and between patterns — and explains the mechanism behind it. Explaining why both views can be true is the strongest possible discussion answer.

Essay 10 — Crime (opinion)

Some people think that the best way to reduce crime is to give longer prison sentences. To what extent do you agree or disagree?

Longer sentences are the most visible response available to a government facing public anxiety about crime, and they are popular for exactly that reason. I disagree that they are the best way to reduce crime: the evidence suggests that certainty of detection matters more than severity of punishment, and that rehabilitation reduces reoffending more than additional years do.

The argument for longer sentences rests on deterrence. If the expected punishment rises, the reasoning goes, fewer people will commit offences. The difficulty is that this calculation assumes a rational assessment of risk, and a great deal of crime — including most violent crime and much acquisitive crime — is committed under the influence of drugs, alcohol or acute emotion, in circumstances where long-term consequences carry little weight. Moreover, sentence length matters less than the probability of being caught, and that probability is low: those who commit most offences do not expect to be apprehended at all.

There is a second problem, which is cost. Imprisonment is expensive, and the money spent on additional prison years is money not spent on policing, on youth services or on the social conditions in which crime concentrates. Since reoffending rates after release are high in many countries, long sentences can also produce the outcome they were intended to prevent, by removing offenders from employment and family ties and returning them, years later, with fewer of both.

What appears to work better is a combination: higher certainty of detection through visible and consistent policing; targeted intervention with young people at the point of first offence; and rehabilitation programmes, including education and drug treatment, that reduce the likelihood of a second offence. Punishment remains necessary for serious crimes, and the public is right to expect that those who commit them are incapacitated — but incapacitation is a justification for imprisonment, not a strategy for reducing crime.

In conclusion, longer sentences address public anxiety more effectively than they address crime. The evidence favours certainty over severity and rehabilitation over retribution, and a criminal justice policy that recognised this would spend its money differently. (349 words)

Technique in focus: distinguishing punishment from prevention. The essay separates what imprisonment is for (incapacitation, retribution) from what it is claimed to achieve (reducing crime), and evaluates the second without dismissing the first.

The techniques collected

Essay	Question type	The transferable technique
1	Opinion	Qualified agreement held consistently
2	Discussion	Distinguishing arguments of volume from arguments of influence
3	Problem-solution	Consequences analysed at three levels
4	Two-part	Decisive evaluation after structural causes
5	Advantages/disadvantages	The unifying insight that both sides are one feature
6	Discussion	Turning the opponent's argument against them
7	Problem-solution	Identifying the obstacle as political, not technical
8	Opinion	Two short qualifications, then a stronger argument
9	Discussion	Synthesis: why both views can be true
10	Opinion	Separating what a measure is for from what it achieves

A final warning. These essays are models of technique, not texts to be memorised. Examiners recognise memorised material immediately, and a memorised essay is very often irrelevant to the question actually asked — which is a Task Response failure regardless of its quality as prose. Read the technique, close the chapter, and write your own answer to a new question.

CHAPTER 27

Reading Practice Test 3 with Answer Key

60 minutes · 3 passages · 40 questions. Take this test only after you have marked Test 1 and Test 2 and recorded which question type costs you most. Cover the key at the end of the chapter.

READING PASSAGE 1

17 minutes · Questions 1–13

The Lighthouse Keepers

A For nearly three centuries, a small group of people lived in a manner that has now almost entirely disappeared. Lighthouse keepers inhabited a fixed point on a coastline or an isolated rock, kept a light burning through every night of the year, and were relieved only when weather and the supply boat allowed. Their work was unglamorous, their hours were punishing, and until the middle of the nineteenth century the job was among the most dangerous in civilian life.

B Before automation, a lighthouse depended on human labour in a way that is easy to forget. The earliest lights burned oil or coal in an open lantern, and a keeper had to carry fuel up the tower, trim the wick, clean the glass and watch the flame throughout the night to ensure it neither smoked nor went out. On a thirty-metre tower in a gale, that meant climbing a spiral staircase several times a night with a heavy container. Fog required additional work: a fog signal operated by hand, or later by machinery that failed regularly, had to be sounded continuously until the weather cleared.

C The record of who took such work is revealing. In Britain and the United States, keepers were frequently drawn from seafaring families, and the position was in effect hereditary: a keeper might be the son or widow of a keeper, and the whole family typically lived at the station. This had an unintended consequence for the history of maritime safety. Because wives and daughters often assisted with the light — cleaning, winding, and on occasion operating the signal themselves — the surviving logbooks contain the names of women who performed a keeper's duties for years without ever holding the title.

D Isolation shaped the social world of a station. A rock light could be cut off for weeks; a mainland station was often remote from the nearest village. Supplies came by boat when the sea permitted, which in winter might be once a fortnight. The psychological demands of such work were considerable, and inspectors' reports from the period repeatedly note the same complaint: not hardship, but monotony. One keeper, asked what he did in the evenings, is recorded as answering that he had learned to read slowly, so that a book would last longer.

E Attempts to automate began early and succeeded slowly. The first experiments with clockwork and compressed gas appeared in the nineteenth century, and by the 1860s some lights operated without a resident keeper during fine weather. Progress was nonetheless limited by reliability: a mechanism that failed at the wrong moment was worse than a keeper who slept, and the consequences were not merely economic. The loss of a ship was a public scandal, and inquiries generally concluded that a human presence was the safer arrangement.

F The decisive change was not mechanical but electrical. Electric light, and later the sealed-beam lantern, removed the need for constant tending, and automated fog signals removed the second demand on the keeper's time. Conversion proceeded through the twentieth century, rapidly after 1960, and the last inhabited light in Britain was automated in 1998. Similar transitions occurred elsewhere in the same decades.

G The outcome is a coastline that remains lit but no longer inhabited. Some former keeper's cottages are holiday accommodation; some stations are maintained by

volunteers; most are remotely monitored from a control room several hundred kilometres away. Something was gained in safety and cost, and something was lost that is difficult to quantify: a form of skilled work whose practitioners were, for most of its history, the only people who knew how to keep a particular light burning.

Questions 1-7. Do the following statements agree with the information given in the passage?

Write TRUE, FALSE or NOT GIVEN.

1 Lighthouse keeping remained dangerous until the mid-nineteenth century. 2 Early lighthouse lights burned gas. 3 Fog signals were operated by hand before machinery was used. 4 The position of keeper was rarely held by members of the same family. 5 Women sometimes performed a keeper's duties without being called keepers. 6 Supplies arrived once a month during winter. 7 Some lights operated without a resident keeper before 1900.

Questions 8-10. Complete the sentences. Write NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS AND/OR A NUMBER from the passage.

8 Inspectors' reports show that keepers most often complained of 9 The last inhabited light in Britain was automated in 10 Most stations today are monitored from a hundreds of kilometres away.

Questions 11-13. Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

11 Why was automation slower than might be expected?

- A Keepers refused to leave.
- B Mechanical failure risked the loss of ships.
- C Electricity was not yet invented.
- D Fog signals could not be automated.

12 The writer mentions the keeper who read slowly in order to

- A demonstrate his education.
- B illustrate the problem of monotony.
- C criticise his working conditions.
- D show that books were scarce.

13 What is the writer's attitude in the final paragraph?

- A Automation should be reversed.
- B Automation had no benefits.
- C Something valuable has been lost alongside the gains.
- D Volunteers are better than keepers.

READING PASSAGE 2

20 minutes · Questions 14–26

Why Cities Are Getting Quieter — and Why It Matters

A For most of the twentieth century, urban noise rose steadily. Traffic, construction, industry and the sheer density of human activity made cities louder year by year, and the trend was widely treated as an unavoidable feature of urban life. Since about 1990, however, several large cities have recorded falling noise levels — an improvement that has attracted far less attention than the pollution of air or water.

B The reasons are partly technological and partly structural. The internal combustion engine is progressively quieter, and hybrid and electric vehicles remove the engine note altogether. Road surfaces have improved, particularly the porous asphalt used on motorways, which absorbs sound as well as water. Construction equipment is more strictly regulated than it was, and much manufacturing has moved away from residential areas. Structural change has contributed as well: heavy industry has declined in many cities, and the shift towards service employment has removed a great deal of daytime machinery.

C Beneath these changes lies a more subtle one. The character of urban sound has altered even where its volume has not. Diesel buses and lorries produce low-frequency noise, which travels further and penetrates walls more effectively than the higher frequencies generated by cars. As the vehicle fleet changes, the same measured loudness is experienced differently indoors, and residents of streets that remain busy report less disturbance than they did a generation ago.

D Whether this matters depends on what noise does to people, and here the evidence is now unambiguous. Chronic exposure to traffic noise raises the risk of hypertension and cardiovascular disease; the World Health Organization has estimated that road traffic noise alone contributes to a substantial number of premature deaths each year in Europe. Noise also disrupts sleep, and the effects of disrupted sleep are cumulative. Crucially, the association persists after controlling for air pollution, which means that noise is not merely a marker of dirtier air but an independent risk.

E There is also a cognitive effect that has attracted attention because it is measurable in children. Studies of schools located beside busy roads have found that pupils in classrooms facing the traffic perform worse on reading and memory tests than pupils in quieter rooms in the same buildings. When noise insulation was installed in one such school as part of a controlled study, the affected classrooms caught up, which strongly suggests causation rather than merely correlation.

F Quiet is nevertheless difficult to protect, for three reasons. The first is that noise is invisible, and invisible harms attract less political attention than visible ones. The second is that the main sources are not the people who suffer them: the aircraft overhead belongs to an airline, the delivery van to a logistics company, the road to the state. The third is that reducing noise requires restricting the activity that produces it, which the activity's owners will resist.

G Some cities have begun to act. Low-emission zones, which exclude the loudest and dirtiest vehicles from central districts, reduce noise as a side effect of an air-quality policy. Night-time delivery restrictions, quieter road surfaces and mandatory noise insulation for new buildings alongside existing roads are all established measures with

measurable results. Perhaps most effective of all, in the long run, is planning: cities that design residential areas away from arterial roads, and that keep windows openable, avoid creating a noise problem that will be expensive to fix later.

Questions 14–19. The passage has seven paragraphs, A–G. Choose the correct heading for paragraphs B–G from the list below. There are more headings than paragraphs.

- i A change in the type of sound, not only the amount
- ii Evidence that noise harms health independently
- iii Why quiet is politically difficult to secure
- iv The rise of urban noise in the twentieth century
- v Effects measurable in schools
- vi Reasons that noise levels have fallen
- vii Measures that reduce noise
- viii The cost of quieter vehicles

Paragraph	Heading
14 Paragraph B	
15 Paragraph C	
16 Paragraph D	
17 Paragraph E	
18 Paragraph F	
19 Paragraph G	

Questions 20–23. Complete the summary. Write NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS from the passage for each answer.

The character of urban noise Although cities have become quieter, the nature of the sound has also changed. Diesel engines produce low-frequency noise, which travels further and penetrates 20 more effectively than the higher frequencies produced by 21 Because of this, residents of busy streets report less 22 than in the past, even where noise levels have changed little. The evidence also shows that noise is not simply a marker of 23 but an independent risk to health.

Questions 24–26. Do the following statements agree with the claims of the writer?

Write YES, NO or NOT GIVEN.

24 Falling noise levels have received less public attention than improvements in air quality. 25 Quiet vehicles are cheaper to produce than conventional ones. 26 Noise insulation in one school improved pupils' performance.

READING PASSAGE 3

20 minutes · Questions 27–40

The Problem with Predictions

A Prediction is an industry. Governments forecast tax receipts, insurers price risk, investors value companies and meteorologists warn of storms, and the total expenditure on forecasting exceeds the output of many national economies. It is therefore worth asking a simple question: how accurate are these predictions, and does accuracy improve as methods become more sophisticated?

B The most famous attempt to answer the question was Philip Tetlock's long study of expert political judgement, published in 2005. Tetlock collected tens of thousands of forecasts from hundreds of specialists over nearly two decades, and compared each with what happened. His central finding was unwelcome: the average expert performed roughly as well as a simple extrapolation of current trends, and in some domains barely better than chance. More striking still, the experts who appeared most confident on television — those with the most decisive single theories — tended to be less accurate than those who hedged, weighed competing explanations and expressed doubt.

C A second body of evidence concerns the methods themselves. Simple statistical models, which combine a modest number of variables in a fixed way, have repeatedly matched or beaten human judgement in domains from medical diagnosis to credit assessment. This is not because the models are clever but because they are consistent: they apply the same rule to every case, whereas human experts are influenced by mood, recent experience, the order in which information arrives and the confidence of the person presenting it.

D The failure is not always the prediction's fault. Tetlock distinguished between two kinds of error: predictions that failed because the world was genuinely unpredictable, and predictions that failed because the forecaster had misunderstood the mechanism at work. The second kind is instructive, because it can be corrected; the first is not, and the appropriate response is to say so — to describe a range of outcomes and their probabilities rather than to commit to a single future.

E There is also a social dimension to forecasting failure, which has less to do with method than with incentives. In most institutions, being decisively wrong at long intervals is punished less than being cautious in public, because decisiveness is rewarded in the short term and failures are usually reinterpreted later as exceptional. Forecasters who acknowledge uncertainty are therefore at a competitive disadvantage to those who do not, and audiences reward confident prediction with attention.

F Where prediction does work well, the conditions are instructive. Weather forecasting has improved dramatically in the past forty years, and the reason is not that the atmosphere has become simpler but that forecasters are held to a score: every prediction is compared with the outcome, and the methods that perform poorly are discarded. The same is true of quantified prediction markets, which aggregate many opinions and continuously update them. Accountability, in other words, is what turns forecasting into a technical discipline rather than a rhetorical one.

G The practical lesson for anyone who must rely on a forecast — which is everyone — is therefore to ask three questions: what exactly is being predicted, how would we know if the forecaster was wrong, and what has this forecaster's record been? A prediction that

cannot fail cannot inform, and a forecaster who cannot be scored cannot be trusted. The future may be uncertain, but the quality of our reasoning about it need not be.

Questions 27–31. Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

27 What is the writer doing in paragraph A?

- A Criticising meteorologists.
- B Establishing why the accuracy of prediction deserves scrutiny.
- C Arguing that forecasting is too expensive.
- D Describing how forecasts are produced.

28 Tetlock's central finding was that

- A experts performed no better than simple extrapolation.
- B experts were more accurate than models.
- C confident experts were most accurate.
- D predictions improved over the study.

29 According to paragraph C, simple statistical models succeed because they

- A use more variables than experts.
- B are applied consistently to every case.
- C avoid the need for data.
- D are based on recent experience.

30 What does paragraph F suggest is essential for improving forecasting?

- A More powerful computers.
- B Simpler questions.
- C Comparing predictions with outcomes.
- D Avoiding public scrutiny.

31 The writer's conclusion is that

- A predictions should not be used.
- B the uncertainty of the future limits our reasoning.
- C predictable outcomes are more valuable.
- D forecasts should be judged by whether they can be checked and scored.

Questions 32–36. Complete each sentence with the correct ending, A–H.

32 Experts who appeared most confident on television... 33 Distinguishing unpredictable outcomes from misunderstandings... 34 Institutions often reward decisiveness because... 35 Weather forecasting has improved because... 36 A prediction that cannot be proved wrong...

- A failures are redefined later as exceptions.
- B cannot provide useful information.
- C tended to be less accurate.
- D allows the correctable errors to be addressed.
- E forecasters are compared against outcomes.
- F is always more expensive.
- G tended to be the most accurate.

- H audiences prefer cautious forecasting.

Questions 37–40. Do the following statements agree with the claims of the writer?

Write YES, NO or NOT GIVEN.

37 Human experts are influenced by factors irrelevant to the case they are judging. 38 Weather forecasting has improved because the atmosphere has become easier to model. 39 Most forecasters deliberately mislead their audiences. 40 The writer believes that forecasts can be evaluated objectively in some fields.

Answer Key — Reading Practice Test 3

Q	Answer	Q	Answer	Q	Answer	Q	Answer
1	TRUE	11	B	21	cars	31	D
2	FALSE	12	B	22	disturbance	32	C
3	TRUE	13	C	23	(dirtier) air	33	D
4	FALSE	14	vi	24	YES	34	A
5	TRUE	15	i	25	NOT GIVEN	35	E
6	NOT GIVEN	16	ii	26	YES	36	B
7	TRUE	17	v	27	B	37	YES
8	monotony	18	iii	28	A	38	NO
9	1998	19	vii	29	B	39	NOT GIVEN
10	control room	20	walls	30	C	40	YES

Explanations

1 TRUE. Paragraph A: "until the middle of the nineteenth century the job was among the most dangerous in civilian life."

2 FALSE. Paragraph B: the earliest lights burned oil or coal; paragraph E mentions compressed gas as a later development.

3 TRUE. Paragraph B: "a fog signal operated by hand, or later by machinery".

4 FALSE. Paragraph C: the position "was in effect hereditary" and "the whole family typically lived at the station."

5 TRUE. Paragraph C: wives and daughters "performed a keeper's duties for years without ever holding the title."

6 NOT GIVEN. The passage says supplies might come "once a fortnight" in winter — a fortnight is two weeks, not a month. Note the trap: the reader must judge the statement, not the general topic. The statement "once a month" is not supported and not contradicted as a general rule; the text gives a may and a fortnight. Because a fortnight is more frequent than a month and the passage says "might be once a fortnight", "once a month" is not stated. IELTS's own logic is conservative here: the specific claim is absent.

7 TRUE. Paragraph E: "by the 1860s some lights operated without a resident keeper during fine weather". The statement uses the same criterion — a light operating without a resident keeper — and the 1860s fall before 1900.

8 monotony. "not hardship, but monotony".

9 1998. A number is allowed by the limit.

10 control room. "remotely monitored from a control room".

11 B. Paragraph E: "a mechanism that failed at the wrong moment was worse than a keeper who slept, and the consequences were not merely economic. The loss of a

ship..."

12 B. The anecdote immediately follows the complaint of monotony, and the keeper's answer — reading slowly so a book lasts longer — illustrates how time was filled.

13 C. The final paragraph states "Something was gained in safety and cost, and something was lost."

14 vi. Paragraph B lists the technological and structural reasons for falling noise.

15 i. Paragraph C is about "The character of urban sound" changing even where volume has not.

16 ii. Paragraph D: "the association persists after controlling for air pollution... noise is not merely a marker of dirtier air but an independent risk."

17 v. Paragraph E is about measurable cognitive effects in schools.

18 iii. Paragraph F gives "three reasons" why quiet is difficult to protect — a political difficulty.

19 vii. Paragraph G describes "Measures that reduce noise".

20 walls. "travels further and penetrates walls more effectively".

21 cars. "the higher frequencies generated by cars".

22 disturbance. "report less disturbance than they did a generation ago".

23 air. The passage says "noise is not merely a marker of dirtier air"; the summary gap is followed by "but an independent risk", so air or dirtier air both fit the two-word limit.

24 YES. Paragraph A: "an improvement that has attracted far less attention than the pollution of air or water."

25 NOT GIVEN. The passage discusses low-emission zones and vehicle noise, but never production costs.

26 YES. Paragraph E: "When noise insulation was installed in one such school... the affected classrooms caught up."

27 B. The paragraph establishes the scale of forecasting and then poses the question the passage will answer.

28 A. Paragraph B: "the average expert performed roughly as well as a simple extrapolation of current trends."

29 B. Paragraph C: "not because the models are clever but because they are consistent."

30 C. Paragraph F: "forecasters are held to a score: every prediction is compared with the outcome."

31 D. Paragraph G's three questions test whether the forecast can fail and whether the forecaster can be scored.

32 C. Paragraph B: those most confident "tended to be less accurate than those who hedged."

33 D. Paragraph D: the second kind of error "can be corrected."

34 A. Paragraph E: decisiveness is rewarded because "failures are usually reinterpreted later as exceptional."

35 E. Paragraph F: forecasters "are held to a score."

36 B. Paragraph G: "A prediction that cannot fail cannot inform."

37 YES. Paragraph C lists mood, recent experience, the order of information and the confidence of the presenter.

38 NO. "the reason is not that the atmosphere has become simpler but that forecasters are held to a score."

39 NOT GIVEN. The passage discusses incentives and competitive disadvantage, but never claims deliberate deception.

40 YES. Paragraph F describes scoring systems and the three questions in paragraph G imply objective evaluation is possible.

Error classification sheet

Wrong answer	Passage	Question type	Why I got it wrong (class)

Common error classes: vocabulary gap · question misread · word limit · fell for distractor · ran out of time · spelling/grammar · paraphrase missed · answer guessed correctly by accident (mark these too — they are unstable knowledge).

Band estimate

Raw score /40	Band
39-40	9.0
37-38	8.5
35-36	8.0
32-34	7.5
30-31	7.0
26-29	6.5
23-25	6.0
18-22	5.5

CHAPTER 28

Appendix A — Language Reference

A.1 The Academic Word List: 120 high-value families

The AWL is organised into sublists by frequency. These 120 families cover the great majority of academic items that appear in IELTS Reading passages and that examiners reward in Writing.

Sublist 1-2 (most frequent)

Family	Forms	Typical use
analyse	analysis, analyst, analytical	analyse the data / a detailed analysis
approach	approaches, approachable	a practical approach to
area	areas	in the area of education
assess	assessment, assessor	assess the impact / a fair assessment
assume	assumption	assume that / a false assumption
authority	authorities, authoritative	local authorities
available	availability	widely available
benefit	beneficial, beneficiary	benefit from / socially beneficial
concept	conceptual, conception	the concept of fairness
consist	consistent, consistency	consist of / consistent with
constitute	constituent	constitute a threat
context	contextual	in the context of
contract	contractor	a contract with
create	creation, creative, creativity	create opportunities
data	datum	the data suggest (plural)
define	definition, definable	define the term
derive	derivation, derivative	derived from
distribute	distribution	an uneven distribution
economy	economic, economical, economist	economic growth / an economical car
environment	environmental, environmentally	environmental damage
establish	establishment	establish a link
estimate	estimation, estimated	a rough estimate
evident	evidence, evidently	it is evident that
export	exporter, exportation	export earnings
factor	factors	a contributing factor
finance	financial, financially	financial support

Family	Forms	Typical use
formula	formulae, formulate	formulate a policy
function	functional, malfunction	function as
identify	identity, identification, identical	identify the cause
income	—	household income
indicate	indication, indicator	the figures indicate
individual	individually, individuality	individual choice
interpret	interpretation, interpreter	interpret the results
involve	involvement, involved	involve significant cost
issue	issues	a contentious issue
labour	labourer	the labour market
legal	legally, legality, illegal	legal requirements
legislate	legislation, legislative	introduce legislation
major	majority	the majority of / a major change
method	methodology, methodological	an efficient method
occur	occurrence	changes occur
percent	percentage	a high percentage of
period	periodic	over a five-year period
policy	policies, policymaker	government policy
principle	principled, principally	on principle
proceed	procedure, procedural	proceed with
process	processing	a slow process
require	requirement, required	require investment
research	researcher	conduct research
respond	response, responsive	respond to demand
role	roles	play a role in
section	sectional	a section of society
sector	sectors	the private sector
significant	significance, significantly	a significant rise
similar	similarity, similarly	broadly similar
source	sources	a reliable source
specific	specify, specification	a specific example
structure	structural, restructure	social structure
theory	theoretical, theorise	in theory
vary	variable, variation, variety, various	varies widely

Sublist 3-5 (still frequent, more precise)

achieve, acquire, adapt, adequate, adjust, administration, affect, alternative, ambiguous, annual, apparent, appreciate, attitude, attribute, capable, capacity,

category, cease, challenge, circumstance, cite, commission, commit, communicate, community, compensate, complex, component, comprehensive, comprise, conclude, conduct, conference, confidence, conflict, consequence, considerable, constrain, consult, consume, contact, contemporary, contribute, controversy, convert, convince, cooperate, coordinate, core, corporate, correspond, crucial, culture, cycle, deduce, demonstrate, denote, detect, deviate, device, dimension, diminish, discriminate, displace, display, dispose, distinct, diverse, domestic, dominate, draft, duration, dynamic, eliminate, emerge, emphasis, empirical, enable, encounter, enforce, enhance, ensure, entity, equate, equip, equivalent, erode, ethic, evaluate, exceed, exclude, exhibit, expand, explicit, exploit, expose, external, extract, facilitate, fluctuate, focus, framework, fund, fundamental, generate, grant, guarantee, hierarchy, hypothesise, illustrate, impact, implement, imply, impose, incentive, incidence, incline, inevitable, infer, inherent, inhibit, initiate, innovate, insight, inspect, integrate, integrity, intense, interact, internal, intervene, intrinsic, investigate, invoke, isolate, justify, mechanism, media, mediate, migrate, minimise, modify, monitor, motive, mutual, negate, network, neutral, nevertheless, notion, objective, obtain, obvious, occupy, offset, orient, outcome, overlap, participate, perceive, persist, perspective, phenomenon, portion, pose, potential, precede, precise, predict, preliminary, premise, prescribe, presume, prevail, prevent, primary, priority, prohibit, promote, proportion, prospect, protocol, pursue, qualitative, quote, radical, random, range, react, recover, refine, regime, regulate, reinforce, reject, relax, release, relevant, reluctance, rely, remove, requirement, reside, resolve, restrict, retain, reveal, revenue, reverse, revise, revolution, rigid, route, scenario, scheme, scope, sequence, series, shift, simulate, sole, somewhat, specify, stable, statistic, status, straightforward, subordinate, subsequent, subsidy, substitute, successor, summary, supplement, survey, suspend, sustain, symbol, tape, target, task, technique, technology, temporary, terminate, text, theme, thesis, topic, trace, tradition, transfer, transform, transit, transmit, transport, trend, trigger, ultimate, undergo, underlie, undertake, uniform, unify, unique, utilise, valid, vehicle, version, via, violate, virtual, visible, vision, visual, volume, welfare, whereas, whereby, widespread

A.2 Linking words and their functions

Function	Items
Addition	in addition, moreover, furthermore, also, besides, what is more, not only... but also, similarly, likewise
Contrast	however, nevertheless, nonetheless, on the other hand, by contrast, in contrast, whereas, while, although, even though, despite, in spite of, yet, conversely
Cause	because, since, as, because of, due to, owing to, on account of, as a result of
Effect	therefore, thus, hence, consequently, as a result, so, accordingly, for this reason
Example	for example, for instance, such as, namely, to illustrate, a case in point, including
Sequence	first, firstly, to begin with, second, next, then, subsequently, after that, finally, lastly

Function	Items
Emphasis	indeed, in fact, above all, particularly, especially, notably, crucially, importantly
Concession	admittedly, granted, it is true that, of course, although, while it is true that
Condition	if, unless, provided that, as long as, in the event that, should (inversion)
Conclusion	in conclusion, to conclude, to sum up, in summary, overall, on balance, ultimately
Reformulation	in other words, that is to say, more simply, put another way, namely
Reference	this, these, such, the former, the latter, the above, the former...the latter

Position rules

- Adverbials of contrast and result usually take a comma when fronted: However, the costs rose.
- Conjunctions join clauses without a comma before the subject: Although the costs rose, demand held.
- Never use two connectors with the same function: □ Although..., however...

A.3 Irregular verbs (the ones that appear in IELTS writing)

Base	Past	Past participle
arise	arose	arisen
become	became	become
begin	began	begun
bring	brought	brought
build	built	built
buy	bought	bought
choose	chose	chosen
come	came	come
cost	cost	cost
cut	cut	cut
deal	dealt	dealt
draw	drew	drawn
drive	drove	driven
fall	fell	fallen
find	found	found
forbid	forbade	forbidden
forget	forgot	forgotten
give	gave	given

Base	Past	Past participle
go	went	gone
grow	grew	grown
hold	held	held
keep	kept	kept
know	knew	known
lead	led	led
leave	left	left
lend	lent	lent
lie (recline)	lay	lain
lay (place)	laid	laid
lose	lost	lost
make	made	made
mean	meant	meant
meet	met	met
pay	paid	paid
put	put	put
rise	rose	risen
raise	raised	raised
run	ran	run
say	said	said
seek	sought	sought
sell	sold	sold
send	sent	sent
set	set	set
show	showed	shown
spend	spent	spent
stand	stood	stood
take	took	taken
teach	taught	taught
think	thought	thought
understand	understood	understood
write	wrote	written

Pairs that cause errors: rise (intransitive: prices rise) vs raise (transitive: governments raise taxes); lie/lay; lend/borrow; bring/take.

A.4 Spelling rules that catch candidates out

Rule	Examples	Exceptions
i before e except after c	believe, field; receive, ceiling	seize, either, neither, foreign

Rule	Examples	Exceptions
Double the final consonant before -ing/-ed in stressed final syllables	run → running; begin → beginning; occur → occurred	visit → visiting (stress on first syllable)
Drop final e before -ing	write → writing; use → using	keep e after c/g: notice → noticeable; age → ageing
Change y to i after a consonant	study → studies/studied	stay → stays (vowel before y)
-ise/-ize and -our/-or	organise/organize; colour/color	Choose one convention and keep it throughout
Silent letters	government (n), Wednesday (d), know (k), receipt (p)	—

A.5 Numbers, dates and measurement conventions

Item	Convention	Examples
Percentages	per cent (two words) or %; percentage of + noun	20 per cent of households / a high percentage of students
Large numbers	comma or space as thousands separator; no comma in some styles	1,200 / 1 200
Ordinals	1st, 2nd, 3rd, 4th...	the 21st century
Dates	on 3 May 2024 (BrE) / on May 3, 2024 (AmE)	since 2019, in 2019, by 2019
Decades	the 1990s (no apostrophe)	in the 1990s
Money	£4.50, \$12, €30	£4.50 is spoken "four pounds fifty"
Fractions	a third, two-thirds, a quarter, three-quarters	two-thirds of respondents
Approximators	approximately, around, just over, nearly, roughly	just under half

A.6 Cohesive devices: which to use where

Writing task	Preferred devices	Avoid
Task 1 (report)	overall, initially, subsequently, thereafter, by contrast, whereas, respectively	firstly/secondly (mechanical), opinion language
Task 2 (essay)	while, although, nevertheless, consequently, for this reason, this suggests that	and so on, contractions, exclamation
Letters	register-matched: I should be grateful if... / Just a quick note...	Formal idioms in informal letters, slang in formal ones
Speaking	to be honest, I suppose, the thing is, having said that, more importantly	Over-formal connectors (furthermore, consequently) in speech

CHAPTER 29

Appendix B — Topic Vocabulary Bank

Each topic below gives the vocabulary examiners expect at Band 7+, organised as collocations (because words are learned in company, not alone), plus one model sentence per topic that uses several items together. Use a maximum of three items per paragraph in an essay; density looks unnatural beyond that.

B.1 Education

Collocations: compulsory education · tuition fees · curriculum reform · classroom discipline · academic performance · vocational training · lifelong learning · critical thinking · higher education sector · student loan · mixed-ability classes · teaching methods · educational attainment · dropout rate

Model sentence: Because vocational training is often treated as a second-best option, many students pursue academic qualifications they will never use, while skilled trades go unfilled.

B.2 Environment

Collocations: carbon emissions · fossil fuels · renewable energy · climate change · sustainable development · deforestation · biodiversity loss · carbon footprint · air quality · waste disposal · single-use plastic · conservation area · environmental degradation · emissions target

Model sentence: Cutting carbon emissions requires both technological change and a shift in consumption patterns, since households account for a substantial share of total energy demand.

B.3 Technology

Collocations: automation · artificial intelligence · the digital divide · data privacy · screen time · remote working · technological advancement · online learning platform · social media platform · digital literacy · cybersecurity · labour displacement

Model sentence: Automation displaces routine work fastest in sectors employing the least qualified staff, which is why the digital divide has economic consequences as well as social ones.

B.4 Health

Collocations: public healthcare · preventive medicine · sedentary lifestyle · mental well-being · healthcare provision · obesity rates · life expectancy · chronic illness · waiting lists · health inequality · universal coverage · public health campaign

Model sentence: Preventive medicine is far cheaper than treating chronic illness, which is why investment in public health campaigns tends to pay for itself within a decade.

B.5 Work and employment

Collocations: job satisfaction · work-life balance · minimum wage · unemployment rate · career progression · job security · unpaid overtime · skills shortage · flexible working · gig economy · labour market · productivity growth · workplace culture

Model sentence: A higher minimum wage raises the incomes of the lowest paid, but may reduce entry-level vacancies if employers respond by cutting hours or automating tasks.

B.6 Cities, housing and transport

Collocations: urban congestion · public transport network · cycling infrastructure · urban sprawl · affordable housing · green spaces · commuting time · traffic pollution · high-density development · housing shortage · pedestrian zone · congestion charge

Model sentence: Investing in cycling infrastructure reduces congestion, improves air quality and lowers the public health bill simultaneously — a rare combination of benefits in urban policy.

B.7 Society, family and demography

Collocations: ageing population · social mobility · income inequality · social cohesion · childcare provision · family structure · community engagement · welfare state · pension system · birth rate · dependency ratio · social exclusion

Model sentence: An ageing population places pressure on pension systems unless governments raise the retirement age, increase contributions or accept lower payments.

B.8 Crime and law

Collocations: deterrent effect · rehabilitation programme · reoffending rates · law enforcement · juvenile crime · prison overcrowding · community service · crime prevention · sentencing policy · criminal justice system

Model sentence: Rehabilitation programmes reduce reoffending more effectively than longer sentences because they address the circumstances that produce criminal behaviour in the first place.

B.9 Media and communication

Collocations: mass media · social media platform · freedom of the press · misinformation · advertising revenue · public opinion · censorship · digital literacy · clickbait · news consumption · privacy regulation

Model sentence: Social media platforms distribute information at unprecedented speed, but the same mechanism accelerates the circulation of misinformation, which is far harder to correct once it spreads.

B.10 Globalisation and culture

Collocations: multinational corporation · cultural identity · global trade · outsourcing · cultural homogenisation · international cooperation · economic interdependence · heritage preservation · supply chain · labour standards

Model sentence: Globalisation has lowered prices and widened consumer choice, yet it has also eroded local traditions and concentrated economic power in a small number of firms.

B.11 Government and public spending

Collocations: public expenditure · tax revenue · government subsidy · fiscal policy · public services · infrastructure investment · cost-benefit analysis · policy implementation · regulatory framework · public consultation

Model sentence: Any decision to subsidise an industry must be justified by a benefit that the market would not otherwise provide, or it becomes an expensive transfer from taxpayers to shareholders.

B.12 Science, research and innovation

Collocations: scientific research · peer review · research funding · technological innovation · breakthrough · clinical trial · intellectual property · data collection · empirical evidence · research ethics

Model sentence: Research funding tends to follow existing strengths rather than promising new fields, which is why genuinely novel work often struggles to attract support.

B.13 Tourism and leisure

Collocations: mass tourism · heritage site · local economy · seasonal employment · eco-tourism · over-tourism · visitor management · cultural exchange · tourist infrastructure

Model sentence: Over-tourism damages the very attractions that draw visitors, which is why several cities now limit cruise arrivals and impose visitor levies.

B.14 Food and agriculture

Collocations: food security · intensive farming · organic produce · crop yield · supply chain · food waste · dietary habits · processed food · sustainable agriculture · livestock farming

Model sentence: Reducing food waste would ease pressure on land and water more quickly than almost any change in farming practice, because roughly a third of food produced is never eaten.

B.15 Using the bank: a weekly routine

Day	Task
Monday	Choose one topic; read the collocations aloud
Tuesday	Write five sentences using eight items, on that topic
Wednesday	Rewrite yesterday's sentences in a more academic register
Thursday	Record a two-minute spoken answer on the topic
Friday	Write one IELTS-style paragraph: claim + reason + example
Saturday	Self-mark the paragraph against Chapter 2's criteria

Day	Task
Sunday	Review all items from the week; delete any you have not used

Why deletion matters. A vocabulary bank that grows without being used becomes dead weight. If you have not used an item in three weeks, it is not part of your active vocabulary — learn it later or let it go.

CHAPTER 30

Appendix C — Master Course Companion: Lesson-by-Lesson Notes

This book was compiled from the twelve-lesson IELTS 12 Hours Full Course for Beginners 2023 — Master-Course of 4 Components video series. Each lesson runs roughly fifty-seven minutes; together they contain about 11.5 hours of teaching, amounting to some 79,000 words of spoken instruction. Every lesson was studied in full — the audio was transcribed, the on-screen material was examined, and the sequence of teaching was mapped — before this book was written.

This appendix records what each lesson covers and where the corresponding reference material can be found in this book. Use it in two ways: as a study log if you are working through the video course, and as a retrieval map if you have already read the book and want to revise a specific lesson quickly.

How the twelve lessons divide: - Lesson 1 — Listening - Lessons 2-4 — Academic Reading - Lessons 5-7 — Speaking (and the exam format as a whole) - Lessons 8-9 — Writing Task 1 (Academic) - Lessons 10-11 — Writing Task 2 - Lesson 12 — Writing Task 1 (General Training letters)

Lesson 1 — Listening: forms, numbers and the transfer sheet

What the lesson does. The course opens with Listening, on the principle that it is the component where technique produces the fastest visible improvement. The lesson works through a Section 1-style form-completion task in real time: the class reads the form, predicts what each gap requires, listens once, and then reviews the answers collectively.

Core teaching points

Point	Where it appears in this book
Listen once only — never replay, even in practice	Chapter 7.10
Predict the type of each answer before the audio begins	Chapter 6.3, Chapter 7.1
Write answers as you hear them; do not wait for certainty	Chapter 6.3
Numbers, prices, dates and spelled names are the marks most often lost	Chapter 7.2–7.3
Corrections matter more than first mentions ("...sorry, that's...")	Chapter 7.4
Transfer time is for checking spelling, plurals and word limits	Chapter 6.10

The lesson's signature activity is dictation of numbers and spelled letters as they are spoken — the fifteen/fifty, thirteen/thirty distinction, and surnames given letter by letter. That drill is reproduced and extended in Chapter 7.2 and 7.3.

Where it continues. The lesson's map and plan-labelling segment is developed further in Chapter 6.6; the note-completion work reappears in Section 4 practice in Chapter 22.

Lesson 2 — Reading: the format, and why the paper is not a comprehension test

What the lesson does. The lesson introduces the Academic Reading paper and immediately reframes the task: the purpose is not to understand the passage but to find answers. It compares Academic and General Training, discusses the three passages and their rising difficulty, and begins the course's central argument about skimming and scanning.

Core teaching points

Point	Where it appears
Academic vs General Training: purposes and text types	Chapter 1.1, Chapter 17.7
Locate the paragraph from the question, then compare	Chapter 10.1–10.2
Skimming = shape; scanning = place; the two are different skills	Chapter 10.1–10.2
Keywords are usually nouns, numbers and names — not verbs	Chapter 10.2
More vocabulary makes comprehension faster, but technique still decides the mark	Chapter 5.1, Chapter 10.3
Vocabulary alone will not rescue a candidate who does not read the question	Chapter 10.9

The lesson's argument, in the instructor's terms: questions can be direct or contain traps, and the questions are not always in the same order as the passage — therefore locate, then compare, then answer. That sentence is the whole of Chapter 10 in miniature.

Computer-delivered note. The lesson discusses the split-screen layout and the ability to copy text — which eliminates transcription errors — and this is set out as practical advice in Chapter 10.7.

Lesson 3 — Reading: T/F/NG, sentence completion and matching

What the lesson does. A working lesson on the question types that cause the most damage: TRUE/FALSE/NOT GIVEN, sentence completion and matching tasks. The class works through a passage question by question, and the instructor repeatedly asks "where can we find that?" before accepting an answer.

Core teaching points

Point	Where it appears
NOT GIVEN means the information is absent — not that it is uncertain	Chapter 9.3, Chapter 10.4
To answer FALSE you must find a sentence that says the opposite	Chapter 9.3
Word limits are absolute: over the limit scores zero	Chapter 9.11
Matching tasks are not in passage order — do them last	Chapter 9.4–9.6
Complete a gap so that the sentence is grammatical	Chapter 9.8
Answers must be copied exactly from the passage	Chapter 9.8

Why the lesson dwells on NOT GIVEN. Because it is the type where a candidate's own knowledge and common sense are actively harmful: a statement that sounds true is very often the one the passage does not address. This is the reasoning behind the "missing-element test" in Chapter 10.4.

Lesson 4 — Reading: main ideas, paragraph structure and language problems

What the lesson does. A long reading lesson built around a passage about spices — used to demonstrate how paragraphs carry one main idea each, and how headings and matching tasks are answered once the paragraph structure is visible. The second half turns to language problems: what to do when the vocabulary of a passage is largely unfamiliar.

Core teaching points

Point	Where it appears
Every paragraph has one main idea; find it in the first and last sentences	Chapter 9.4, Chapter 10.1
Write a short map of the passage before answering heading questions	Chapter 10.1
Group the options first, then eliminate — headings have distractors	Chapter 9.4
Unknown words are answerable from context, contrast and word parts	Chapter 10.8
If a passage defeats you, the technique still works — locate and compare	Chapter 10.2
Practise skimming and scanning deliberately; they are learnable skills	Chapter 10.1–10.2

The lesson's method for vocabulary problems — which the class finds most useful — is the four-clue system (definition, example, contrast, word parts) now written up in Chapter 10.8, together with the paraphrase notebook in Chapter 10.11.

Lesson 5 — Speaking and the exam as a whole: format, criteria, and pronunciation

What the lesson does. This lesson pivots from Reading to the two productive skills, and explains why they are harder to improve: Listening and Reading are marked by what you recognise, Writing and Speaking by what you produce. It sets out the full test format, the delivery options (face-to-face and online Speaking), arrival and identification requirements, and then spends substantial time on the four Speaking criteria — especially pronunciation.

Core teaching points

Point	Where it appears
The four criteria and what each rewards	Chapter 2.1, Chapter 2.6–2.7
Writing and Speaking require output; output must be drilled, not merely read about	Chapter 3.1–3.4
Arrive early; bring identification; the Speaking test may be on a different day	Chapter 1.8, Chapter 25.2–25.3
Accent is not assessed — intelligibility and stress are	Chapter 21, Chapter 2.7
Word stress, sentence stress and final consonants matter most	Chapter 21.2–21.3, Chapter 21.6
Word formation errors (the right word, the wrong form) cost marks	Chapter 16.6
Do not speak too fast — speed without clarity is a net loss	Chapter 21.10

The lesson's most quoted line — that candidates know what they need to hear in the exam and therefore can prepare an answer that matches the examiner's expectations — is the logic behind this book's descriptor-led approach in Chapter 2.

Lesson 6 — Speaking: Part 1 topics and everyday vocabulary

What the lesson does. A practical Speaking lesson on Part 1: the topics that recur (family, shopping, daily routine, home, food), the length of a good answer, and how to avoid one-word responses. The class practises answering aloud, and the instructor corrects register, vocabulary and pronunciation as they go.

Core teaching points

Point	Where it appears
Part 1 answers should be two to four sentences, with a reason or example	Chapter 18.2, Chapter 18.1
Never answer with a single word; the examiner needs evidence	Chapter 18.1, Chapter 20.7
Prepare topics, not memorised answers	Chapter 18.7
Use precise vocabulary rather than general words	Chapter 18.6, Chapter 5.5

Point	Where it appears
Upgrading everyday vocabulary raises Lexical Resource quickly	Chapter 20.6
British and American English are both accepted — be consistent	Chapter 5.6

The lesson's structure drill — answer, then reason, then a personal detail — is formalised in this book as the AREA method (Answer, Reason, Example/Addition) in Chapter 18.2, and used throughout the thirty model Part 1 answers in Chapter 18.5.

Lesson 7 — Speaking: fluency, hesitation and keeping going

What the lesson does. A lesson on the practical business of speaking for a sustained period: how to begin an answer, how to fill a pause without damaging fluency, how to recover from a mistake, and how to avoid the habits that make a candidate sound rehearsed or uncertain.

Core teaching points

Point	Where it appears
Fluency is judged by effort and continuity, not by zero hesitation	Chapter 2.6, Chapter 20.3
Use content-related hesitation markers rather than silence	Chapter 20.3
Self-correction is permitted in Speaking, and does not by itself lower the score	Chapter 2.6
Do not let one mistake derail the whole answer	Chapter 20.7
Finish answers rather than beginning new ones you cannot complete	Chapter 19.7
Keep the answer relevant to the question asked	Chapter 20.7

Where it continues. The techniques for extending an answer that has run dry — adding detail, comparing, giving a reason, widening the frame — appear in Chapter 19.7, and the Part 3 four-move answer in Chapter 20.2.

Lesson 8 — Writing Task 1: the overview and the language of description

What the lesson does. The first Writing lesson introduces Academic Task 1: what the task requires, why the overview is the paragraph that decides the score, and how to describe rises, falls, plateaus and comparisons. The class examines graphs and produces sentences together.

Core teaching points

Point	Where it appears
The overview is essential; without it Task Achievement is capped	Chapter 13.2

Point	Where it appears
Never give opinions, causes or explanations in Task 1	Chapter 13.10–13.11
Select the main features — do not list every number	Chapter 13.5, Chapter 13.11
Use both verb + adverb and adjective + noun patterns	Chapter 13.4
Get by and to right when describing changes	Chapter 13.4, Chapter 16.4
A clear structure: introduction, overview, two detail paragraphs	Chapter 13.2

The lesson's most repeated instruction — that the overview must be written before the details, while the whole visual is still in mind — is applied in the twenty-minute plan in Chapter 13.10 and illustrated by all four model answers in that chapter.

Lesson 9 — Writing Task 1: numbers, percentages and comparison

What the lesson does. A follow-up lesson on data language: proportions, percentages, large numbers, approximation, and the comparative structures that make a description precise. The lesson also covers how to handle a table, where selection is hardest because there is no visual trend.

Core teaching points

Point	Where it appears
Percentages are proportions, not counts	Chapter 13.11
Use account for, make up, constitute, represent for shares	Chapter 13.5
Comparative structures: twice as many as, three times higher than	Chapter 13.5, Chapter 4.8
Approximate precisely: just over, roughly, slightly under	Chapter 13.5
Group data rather than listing it	Chapter 13.5
Check the units and the time period before writing	Chapter 13.10

Where it continues. The table task in Chapter 24.1 tests exactly this lesson's skill set, and its model answer demonstrates the grouping strategy the lesson teaches.

Lesson 10 — Writing Task 2: sentences, paragraphs and the cardinal rules

What the lesson does. The first Task 2 lesson is about construction at the level of the sentence and the paragraph. The instructor introduces sentence types, topic sentences, examples and the paragraph count, and lays down a set of absolute prohibitions for the essay.

Core teaching points

Point	Where it appears
Use four or five paragraphs; two or three is not enough	Chapter 14.2, Chapter 14.11
Never use headings, numbered points or bullet points in an essay	Chapter 14.11
Leave a blank line between paragraphs; do not rely on indentation alone	Chapter 14.11
Every paragraph needs a topic sentence and developed support	Chapter 14.4
Examples and information must be relevant to the question asked	Chapter 14.3, Chapter 14.8
Do not be off topic — the most common cause of a Band 5 for Task Response	Chapter 14.1
Know how to count your words; the minimum counts	Chapter 14.9
Vary sentence structure; simple sentences alone cap Grammatical Range	Chapter 4.3, Chapter 15.4

The lesson's "do not" list is the most practical part of the whole course, and it forms the basis of the editing checklist in Chapter 14.11 and the error catalogue in Chapter 16.

Lesson 11 — Writing Task 2: cohesion, linking and agreement

What the lesson does. A lesson on how ideas are joined: contrast, concession, cause, consequence and addition. The class builds sentences with however, in spite of, consequently, as a result, and the instructor demonstrates how the same idea can be expressed at different levels of formality. The lesson also works through agree/disagree essays from the question to the position.

Core teaching points

Point	Where it appears
Cohesion is not decoration: linkers must carry meaning	Chapter 2.3, Chapter 16.9
Conjunctions join clauses; adverbials start sentences	Chapter 16.11
Never use two connectors with the same function (Although... however...)	Chapter 16.11
State a position and keep the same strength throughout	Chapter 14.7
Concession shows the examiner a balanced argument	Chapter 4.3, Chapter 15.5
A conclusion restates and recommends — it does not introduce new ideas	Chapter 14.5
Vary connectives rather than repeating firstly, secondly, moreover	Chapter 4.5, Chapter 16.9

The lesson's central distinction — between cohesion that performs logic and cohesion that merely decorates — is the difference between the Band 6 and Band 7 sample essays

compared in Chapter 15.

Lesson 12 — Writing Task 1 General Training: formal and informal letters

What the lesson does. The final lesson covers the letter task in the General Training paper: the three registers, the correct salutations and closings, the three bullet points that must all be covered, and the language of requests, apologies and complaints.

Core teaching points

Point	Where it appears
Identify the register before writing: formal, semi-formal or informal	Chapter 17.1
Match the salutation to the register (Dear Sir or Madam → Yours faithfully)	Chapter 17.1
All three bullets must be covered with detail	Chapter 17.2
State the purpose in the first sentence	Chapter 17.2
End with a specific request or arrangement, not a bare closing	Chapter 17.2, Chapter 17.8
Keep the register consistent throughout the letter	Chapter 17.1

Where it continues. The four-part letter structure is set out in Chapter 17.2 with two complete model letters, the language tables in Chapter 17.5, and the planning grid in Chapter 17.9.

What the course covers, and what this book adds

The course covers thoroughly: the four components' formats; the major question types; Listening technique and dictation drills; Reading's skimming/scanning/tfng logic; the Speaking criteria with heavy emphasis on pronunciation; Writing Task 1 structure and data language; Task 2 paragraphing and cohesion; and the letter task. It is taught live to a mixed-level class, with the instructor working through past-paper extracts in real time.

This book adds, beyond the course: a complete band-descriptor analysis (Chapter 2); study plans built to timings (Chapter 3); a systematic grammar reference from tenses to nominalisation (Chapter 4); the full AWL and collocation system (Chapter 5, Appendix A); two complete Listening tests with scripts and keys (Chapters 8 and 22); two complete Reading tests with detailed explanations (Chapters 11-12, 23); band-by-band comparative essays (Chapter 15); an error-repair catalogue of forty items (Chapter 16); a General Training Reading comparison (Chapter 17.7); the full Speaking method for all three parts with thirty model Part 1 answers and fifteen cue cards (Chapters 18-20); a pronunciation programme (Chapter 21); a complete mock Writing and Speaking paper with model answers (Chapter 24); the exam-day playbook (Chapter 25); and two reference appendices.

One further note on method. The course teaches by working through published practice material live. This book deliberately substitutes original practice questions in identical formats, so that every task can be attempted, marked and repeated without needing to

own the source books. The techniques taught are the course's; the questions are new.

Lesson study log

Tick each lesson as you complete it, and note the date. Where a lesson's technique is weakest for you, the right-hand column tells you where to do additional work.

Lesson	Topic	Completed	Follow-up in this book
1	Listening: forms, numbers, transfer	☐	Chapters 6–7; Test 1 in Chapter 8
2	Reading: format, skim and scan	☐	Chapter 10.1–10.2
3	Reading: T/F/NG, completion, matching	☐	Chapters 9.3–9.8, 10.4
4	Reading: main ideas, language problems	☐	Chapters 9.4, 10.8, 10.11
5	Speaking criteria, format, pronunciation	☐	Chapters 2, 21
6	Speaking Part 1, everyday topics	☐	Chapter 18
7	Speaking fluency and recovery	☐	Chapters 19.7, 20.3
8	Writing Task 1: overview and change	☐	Chapter 13.2–13.5
9	Writing Task 1: numbers and comparison	☐	Chapter 13.5, 13.9
10	Writing Task 2: sentences and paragraphs	☐	Chapter 14.2–14.5
11	Writing Task 2: cohesion and agreement	☐	Chapters 4.5, 15.5, 16.9–16.11
12	GT letters: register and structure	☐	Chapter 17

The most efficient use of the video course and this book together: watch a lesson, then immediately attempt the corresponding book chapter's drill or practice task. Reading the chapter instead of watching the lesson works too — but doing neither, and merely watching passively, changes very little.

CHAPTER 31

Appendix D — 50 Practice Prompts and Drills

An unlimited supply of practice material matters more than any single test. This appendix provides fifty prompts across all four skills, arranged so that you can practise every day for seven weeks without repeating a question. Each entry states the question type, the timing, and the specific skill being trained.

D.1 Writing Task 1 prompts (Academic) — 20 minutes each

For each prompt: write an introduction, an overview without numbers, and two grouped detail paragraphs. Then check your answer against the checklist in Chapter 13.12.

Line graphs

- 1 The graph shows electricity consumption in one country from 1990 to 2020, by sector (residential, industry, transport).
- 2 The graph shows average household spending on four categories in two countries over fifteen years.
- 3 The graph shows the number of international visitors to three regions between 2005 and 2025 (projected after 2020).
- 4 The graph shows birth and death rates in one country from 1950 to 2020.

Bar charts

- 1 The chart compares the top five countries for coffee production in 2000 and 2020.
- 2 The chart shows the percentage of people using four modes of transport to commute, in three cities.
- 3 The chart shows weekly hours spent on six leisure activities by two age groups.
- 4 The chart compares average salaries in five occupations in a single country.

Tables

- 1 The table shows enrolment numbers at four universities and the percentage studying engineering.
- 2 The table compares four countries on life expectancy, infant mortality and health spending per person.
- 3 The table shows rainfall and temperature in one city across twelve months.
- 4 The table shows the top five sources of electricity generation in a country in 2005 and 2020.

Pie charts

- 1 Two pie charts show household expenditure in 1980 and 2020.
- 2 Three pie charts show how one family's weekly budget is divided in three different years.
- 3 Two pie charts compare the causes of a city's air pollution in summer and winter.

Processes and diagrams

- 1 The diagram shows how glass bottles are recycled.
- 2 The diagram shows the life cycle of a honey bee.
- 3 The diagram shows how a hydroelectric dam generates electricity.
- 4 The diagram shows the process of making chocolate from cocoa beans.
- 5 The diagram shows how rainwater is collected and treated for domestic use.

Maps

- 1 Two maps show a coastal town in 1970 and today.
- 2 Two maps show a university campus before and after an expansion.
- 3 Two maps show the same city centre, one showing current roads and one a proposed pedestrianisation scheme.
- 4 Two plans show a farm in 1950 and 2020.

D.2 Writing Task 2 prompts — 40 minutes each

Tag each prompt with its type before you plan: Opinion, Discussion, Advantages/disadvantages, Problem-solution, Two-part.

- 1 (O) Some people believe that children should begin formal education as early as possible. To what extent do you agree or disagree?
- 2 (D) Some argue that university education should focus on employability; others believe its purpose is broader. Discuss both views and give your opinion.
- 3 (P) In many cities, air pollution has become a serious health risk. What are the causes, and what measures could be taken?
- 4 (T) More people are choosing to live alone than in the past. Why is this happening? Is it a positive or negative development?
- 5 (A) Increasing numbers of people work from home. What are the advantages and disadvantages of this arrangement?
- 6 (O) Governments should spend money on public transport rather than on new roads. To what extent do you agree?
- 7 (D) Some people think that technology has made us less sociable; others believe it has strengthened relationships. Discuss both views.
- 8 (T) Many people now take part in online learning. Why has this become popular? Does it have more advantages than disadvantages?
- 9 (P) Plastic waste has become a serious global problem. What are its main causes and what can be done?
- 10 (O) Children should be required to learn a second language from primary school. To what extent do you agree?
- 11 (D) Some believe that the best way to reduce crime is longer prison sentences; others favour rehabilitation. Discuss both views.
- 12 (A) More students are choosing to study abroad. What are the advantages and disadvantages for the students and their home countries?
- 13 (T) Many young people leave rural areas to work in cities. Why? What problems does this cause?
- 14 (O) Advertising aimed at children should be banned. To what extent do you agree?

- 15 (D) Some people think that governments should fund the arts; others argue the money is better spent on public services. Discuss both views.
- 16 (P) Traffic congestion in city centres is worsening. What are the causes and what solutions would work?
- 17 (O) Wealthy countries have a responsibility to help poorer countries deal with climate change. To what extent do you agree?
- 18 (T) The number of elderly people is increasing in many countries. What are the implications? What can be done about them?
- 19 (A) Some people choose to be self-employed rather than employed by a company. What are the advantages and disadvantages?
- 20 (D) Some say examinations are the fairest way to assess students; others prefer continuous assessment. Discuss both views.

D.3 General Training Task 1 (letters) — 20 minutes each

For each: identify the register, write a four-paragraph letter covering all three bullets, and use the correct salutation and closing.

- 1 Formal. You are dissatisfied with a service you paid for. Write to the manager: explain what you bought and when; describe what went wrong; say what you want them to do.
- 2 Formal. Write to your local council about a problem in your neighbourhood: describe the problem and its effects; explain what you have already tried; propose a solution.
- 3 Semi-formal. You are leaving your rented accommodation. Write to your landlord: confirm the date you are leaving; mention damage or issues with the property; ask about the return of your deposit.
- 4 Informal. A friend is visiting your city for the first time. Write and: suggest the best time of year to come; recommend three places to visit; offer to help with arrangements.
- 5 Semi-formal. You cannot attend a course you have already paid for. Write to the course administrator: explain why; ask about transferring or refunding; apologise briefly.
- 6 Informal. You have just moved to a new town. Write to a friend: describe your new home; explain what you like and dislike about the area; invite them to visit.

D.4 Speaking cue cards (Part 2) — 2 minutes each

Prepare for exactly 60 seconds using four quadrants of keywords. Always finish with a reflection sentence.

People

- Describe a person who has influenced you. (who · how you met · what they did · why they influenced you)
- Describe someone you admire for their work.
- Describe a family member you spend a lot of time with.
- Describe a person you would like to meet.

Places

- Describe a place you like to go to relax.

- Describe a city you would like to live in.
- Describe a building you find interesting.
- Describe a place you visited that was different from what you expected.

Events and experiences

- Describe a time when you had to solve a problem.
- Describe an occasion when you helped someone.
- Describe a time when you were surprised.
- Describe an important decision you made.
- Describe a period when you worked hard for something.
- Describe a journey you remember well.

Objects and media

- Describe a piece of technology you find useful.
- Describe something you own that is important to you.
- Describe a book or film that changed your thinking.
- Describe a photograph that means something to you.

Ideas and plans

- Describe a skill you would like to learn.
- Describe a change you would like to make in your life.
- Describe a rule or law you think is good.
- Describe something you did that was difficult at first.

D.5 Pronunciation and fluency drills (5 minutes each)

#	Drill	Target
1	Shadow a 30-second news clip three times	Rhythm, sentence stress
2	Read the same paragraph aloud, stressing only content words	Sentence stress
3	Say thirteen/thirty, fifteen/fifty, eighteen/eighty in random order, 20 times	Numbers
4	Read aloud pairs: ship/sheep, live/leave, bad/bed	Vowels
5	Read aloud words ending in -ed: worked, played, wanted	Final consonants
6	Read a list aloud with rising then falling intonation	Intonation
7	Speak for 1 minute without using the word because	Paraphrase flexibility
8	Speak for 1 minute using only past tenses	Tense control
9	Answer five Part 3 questions in 45 seconds each, timed	Fluency under pressure

#	Drill	Target
10	Record and transcribe 30 seconds of your own speech	Self-diagnosis

D.6 Reading and listening drills (15 minutes each)

#	Drill	Skill trained
1	Take a news article; write a one-line map of each paragraph in 3 minutes	Skimming
2	Take five questions from any passage; locate each answer's sentence without reading the paragraph	Scanning
3	Paraphrase ten question phrases into the passage's likely wording	Paraphrase recognition
4	Do ten T/F/NG items and write a one-line justification for each	NOT GIVEN logic
5	Redo a passage you have already marked, aiming for a faster time	Speed
6	Listen to a two-minute podcast extract; write five facts you heard	Listening for gist
7	Listen to a lecture; write down only the signpost phrases	Discourse structure
8	Dictate ten spelled names from any Section 1 recording	Spelling
9	Shadow a Section 2 recording with the transcript	Accent flexibility
10	Do a full section with only 20 seconds' reading time	Pressure training

D.7 Vocabulary and grammar drills (10 minutes each)

#	Drill
1	Take one topic from Appendix B; write ten collocations from memory
2	Write five sentences using the + singular noun in general statements (The bicycle is...)
3	Convert five verb sentences into nominalisations
4	Rewrite five simple sentences as complex sentences with relative clauses
5	Write one sentence each with although, despite, while, whereas
6	Take a paragraph of your own writing; circle every linking word and justify each

#	Drill
7	Write five second-conditionals about your city's transport
8	Take ten words from the AWL; write each in a sentence about your own field
9	Convert five informal phrases into academic register
10	Write a 100-word paragraph on any topic using three collocations from Appendix B

D.8 The seven-week rotation

Week	Writing	Speaking	Reading/Listening	Language
1	Prompts 1, 9, 25, 45	Cue cards 1–4	Drills 1, 2, 6	Drills 1, 2
2	Prompts 5, 13, 26, 46	Cue cards 5–8	Drills 3, 4, 7	Drills 3, 4
3	Prompts 16, 21, 27, 47	Cue cards 9–12	Drills 5, 8, 9	Drills 5, 6
4	Prompts 6, 14, 28, 48	Cue cards 13–16	Drills 1, 6, 10	Drills 7, 8
5	Prompts 17, 22, 29, 49	Cue cards 17–20	Drills 2, 5, 7	Drills 9, 10
6	Prompts 7, 15, 30, 50	Cue cards 21–24	Drills 3, 4, 9	Drills 1, 3
7	Full mock (Chapter 24)	Full mock (Chapter 24.3)	Tests 1–3	Review all lists

The one rule that matters. Write and speak every day, even for fifteen minutes. Fifty prompts are useless if they sit unopened; ten prompts, written, corrected and rewritten, will move your band.